

IMMUNITY TO CHANGE

COACH'S GUIDE

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Volume 2

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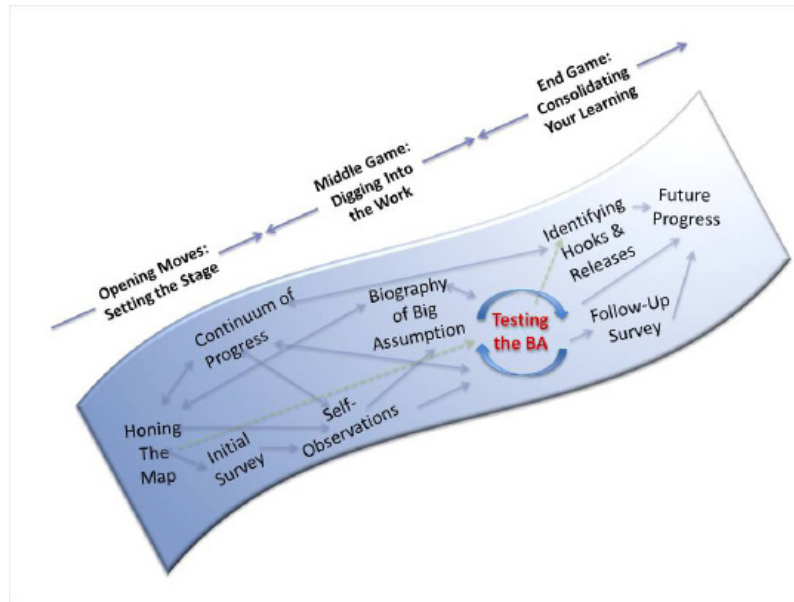
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Chapter 6

Designing Tests of the Big Assumption

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Context for this Exercise

By now, your client should have “set the stage” for overturning his Immunity to Change. (He should have a map that feels compelling to him, as well as a picture of future success in realizing his self-improvement goal. He may have received input from people on the importance and value of his goal, and if so, also he has a baseline of his current performance relative to this goal.) He should also have been “*digging into the work*,” observing and reflecting on the Big Assumption in order to learn about its reality.

The outcome of his work, to this point, may include: clarifying which Big Assumption he wants to test; clarifying the Assumption itself (he may have a more nuanced, differentiated version of it compared to his initial statement of it); developing the observational skills that allow him to see his Big Assumptions operating in his life, not just on paper; developing self-reflective skills of knowing what he thinks and feels as he acts out of his Big Assumptions; developing greater awareness of the ways his Big Assumptions **are** assumptions (not TRUTHS) that have the potential to be altered; and finally, beginning to see how looking for disconfirming data can help him to challenge these assumptions.

The deepest digging occurs when your client begins to design, run and interpret a series of tests of his Big Assumptions. This is the heart of the process and serves as the biggest lever for overturning an immune system, especially when it is done iteratively and each subsequent test examines a next layer or portion of a Big Assumption. As we turn up the heat a bit, and risks are higher, so are the learning opportunities.

This chapter focuses on the first of the three exercises that make up the testing phase of this work, namely, *Designing Tests of the Big Assumption*. The following chapter addresses the other two exercises, *Running Tests of the Big Assumption*, and *Interpreting Tests of the Big Assumption*.

Overview

In the Coaching Journey graphic, “**Testing the Big Assumption**” is written in bold, and surrounded by two arrows to convey two essential points about this exercise: 1) it is at the heart of the ITC coaching process, and serves as the biggest lever for overturning an immune system, and 2) it is iterative. By testing key Big Assumptions, your client will be *intentionally* changing his behaviors and with a clear purpose in mind: to see *what she learns about the accuracy of his Big Assumption*. In other words, the purpose of a test is to “get information,” not immediately to improve or “get better.” Your client can generate such information by using the S-M-A-R-T criteria to design a quality test, which will prepare him to then run his first test.

Purpose and Benefits

- ✓ To make a plan for how to get information about the accuracy (or inaccuracy) of his Big Assumptions.
- ✓ To do something different than he would if he was holding his Big Assumptions as true in order to get information about the accuracy (or inaccuracy) of his Big Assumptions.
- ✓ To increase motivation for overturning his immunities.
- ✓ To increase his ownership over the work and progress.
- ✓ To develop his understanding of the connections between behavior, mind, and change.
- ✓ To gain enough skill and experience in designing tests so as to continue testing even after the contracted coaching period has ended.

Two General Points about Testing the Big Assumption

We will turn to the particulars of how to design tests in the sections below, “Engaging Your Client in This Exercise.” In the meantime, here are two general pointers to keep in mind:

1. The key purpose of designing and running tests of the Big Assumption is to do something different than what we would ordinarily do if holding our Big Assumptions as true *in order to get information about the accuracy (or inaccuracy) of our Big Assumption(s).*

The purpose of a test is *not* to try immediately to improve or to get better, nor is it to prove whether the assumption is right or wrong. Rather it is to get information about the validity of a Big Assumption. It is often difficult for a client to keep this purpose in mind because the prevalent mindset about change tends towards *performance*, not learning. When a client filters the notion of “testing” through a performance mindset, the result is an event-focused approach to testing the Big Assumption. This happens when someone assumes that there is some important action that he hasn’t been able to take that, if taken, would “solve” the Big Assumption and neutralize its effects on him. A common example involves having a long-delayed, difficult conversation with a boss or coworker, surviving it, and moving on. It is the coach’s job to keep the client from slipping into that mindset by keeping the focus on testing to gather information.

A good test is planned in advance and meets the S-M-A-R-T criteria.

Like all good design work, it helps to start with the end in mind. A good test is planned in advance and meets the S-M-A-R-T criteria (spelled out later in the chapter). In practice, this means that the test design intentionally sets out to generate data that, if it exists, could disconfirm a Big Assumption. We call this a “best-case” scenario. After running such a test, your client can discover how accurate his assumption is by examining the resulting data, that is, what *actually happened* when he acted contrary to his Big Assumption. Was his assumption correct and did a “Big Time Bad” result occur despite creating a best-case scenario to learn otherwise? Was the outcome less horrible than he expected? Neutral? Positive? A mixed bag? The better your client understands the endgame, the better able he will be to design a quality test of his Big Assumption.

This mindset-behavior approach to testing Big Assumptions sees tests as incremental experiments, each allowing for greater understanding of the Big Assumption’s power and limitations (not as incremental steps toward immediately improving behavior). This approach views testing as part of an iterative, continuing process – taking small, deliberate steps in the world and doing ongoing reflective work to make sense of the data that result from those steps. The test is not viewed as a performative end in itself, but rather as one in a series of playful learning experiences, ultimately leading to changes to the mindset (which generate future behavior). The second general point is one practical implication of the mindset-behavior approach to testing Big Assumptions.

2. Plan to have enough time to work with your client so that he can design (run, and debrief, see next chapter) at least two tests.

It is rare that any Big Assumption can be sufficiently explored, confirmed, revised and/or overturned after running just one test unless the assumption is incredibly specific and context-bound (e.g., I assume that if I tell my friend that I can't spend as much time with her since I had a baby, she will be angry with me). And, even if one test provides conclusive information about one Big Assumption, more tests will still be necessary to make further progress on overturning the larger immune system. Even if your client runs two tests, he will be unlikely to have completely overturned his immune system. However, he will have had more experience in how to design, run, and interpret tests that will provide some basis for him to continue to do that work on his own if he so chooses (once the contracted coaching sessions have ended). (Of course, some clients will choose to re-contract and extend their coaching period, but the point is they should not feel they must.)

If you haven't left enough time to plan and run at least two tests, that's fine. That happens. But if you first take into account the risks of spending too much time on earlier steps and short-changing the test exercises, you will be less likely to let it happen frequently.

- The client may be using reflection and “talk” as a defensive device to avoid doing the uncomfortable work ahead.
- The client is unaware of, or loses track of what you and he are really up to and mistakes the work as more about “thinking” about his immunity than working to overcome it.
- Your client becomes antsy to get going, feels he is being held back, and begins to lose motivation.
- You will reach the end of your contracted number of sessions (typically 8-10) and realize that you have focused too much on diagnosing the immunity and not enough on overturning it. The client will not have progressed far enough in overturning his immunity and doesn't yet know how to take on the work himself.

Before we move to the examples and details of test design, we want to say that the various concerns and what-if's presented here are not representative of how the designing test exercise tends to go. We include them because we want you to be able to handle predictable curve-balls when they do occasionally arise. There **is** a lot to consider, and some clients (and some immunities) are more challenging than others. But, most of the time, test design goes fairly smoothly and productively when you keep the ITC mindset-behavior connection in view. Clients and their coaches can quickly design a robust test during one session (or part of a session) together. When clients understand the purpose of a test, many can draft a quality test design on their own. And, with experience, it gets easier for both parties.

Brief Examples of Test Designs

Below are examples of three different Big Assumptions. Each is followed by two test designs. These are intended to give you a flavor of various Big Assumptions and how they can be tested over time. (See Chapter Appendix for additional examples). Then, in the following section, we will provide two in-depth test design examples and bring you into an ITC coach's thinking and coaching interactions in order to prepare you to engage your own client in this exercise.

Big Assumption:

“I don’t believe I can ever be skillful at managing my anger or frustrations.”

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I don’t believe I can ever be skillful at managing my anger or frustration.	Take an anger management course.	Do I find the strategies compelling? Do they provide me with believable success stories or others who became skillful?	I can imagine the possibility of increasing my skills.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I don’t believe I can ever be skillful at managing my anger or frustration.	Try out a new relaxation technique at work.	How do I feel (physically, mentally, emotionally) before using the technique? After? How do I behave?	I can increase my skills.

Big Assumption

“My self-worth is based on how others view me.”

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
My self-worth is based on how others view me. (In other words, if others view me negatively in the moment, then I will have low self-worth.)	I will engage in some thought experiments – to imagine the most likely situations where others might possibly view me negatively, that would actually not lead me to have low self-worth. For example, I can imagine a situation like... I give kids daily chores to do and they are mad at me. But I know that over time, they are becoming more responsible people, and so that anger doesn't lead me to have low self-worth – because I know that I am doing the right thing for them, I actually feel better.	Can I think of several, plausible situations in my life when I can imagine something positive could come out of a moment when someone views me negatively?	There are any circumstances under which I wouldn't base my self-worth on others' opinions of me.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
My self-worth is based on how others view me. (In other words, if others view me negatively in the moment, then I will have low self-worth.)	Remind myself about the bigger picture – my intention for asking the kids to do daily chores so that I don't focus only on their anger.	Am I remembering the bigger picture for asking them to do chores? Am I noticing them being responsible? Am I repeating myself less? How do I feel when they are mad at me? And how do I feel later, if they do their jobs?	I can develop a sense of self-worth that is based on what I want to make happen over time.

Big Assumption

*“If I’m not skeptical,
there’s no clear way for me to add value as a leader.”*

Test #1:

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I’m not skeptical, there’s no clear way for me to add value as a leader.	I will interview another leader (who is a very positive guy and has a fantastic reputation in our company) to ask him how he thinks about how he “adds value as a leader” (and also about the role of skepticism in that).	His definition of what it means to “add value,” which I can compare to my own idea.	He adds value without being skeptical.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I’m not skeptical, there’s no clear way for me to add value as a leader.	At the departmental meeting on Friday, I will attempt to suspend judgment until Carl has presented his entire proposal. Then I will create two buckets of evaluations – potential strengths and potential weaknesses. Before the meeting, I’ll ask Amelia to observe how I act in the meeting and what she thinks of the contributions I will make – do they add value? How do they compare to my usual contributions?	I will see if I feel that I still capture all the possible concerns I have, while also attending to the positives. Do I feel we have covered all our bases? I will get feedback after the meeting from Amelia.	I can add value without only expressing my skepticism.

In-depth Examples: Jackson & Amanda

Jackson's Map

Let's return to Jackson. Here's a reminder of his most recent map.

Commitment:	Doing/NotDoing	Hidden Competing Commitment	Big Assumptions
To publicize my accomplishments with senior management.	I don't request time for or offer status updates. I make self-deprecating comments to be funny. When people praise me, I get embarrassed and try to change the subject. . I criticize colleagues who can publicize their accomplishments – I label that type of behavior as bragging, being arrogant. I imagine ways I could publicize my successes better but I don't act on these plans.	Fears – being a jerk, selfish, opportunistic and blind to my own human foibles. Losing touch with reality. Convincing myself that I deserve more than I do_____ I am committed to not becoming my brother (Kurt). I am committed to not fitting the mold of the "asshole" executive. ...not finding out that I actually am an asshole executive.	I assume that saying anything about my accomplishments is bragging. I assume that if I am bragging, I am just like Kurt (also selfish, arrogant, etc.). . I assume that if I publicize my successes, I'll believe what I say. . I assume that being proud equals being selfish. . I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully –other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend. .

Jackson's Test Design

At the end of the last coaching session, the coach reviewed with Jackson the next exercise, Designing a Test of Big Assumptions. He explained how the test should connect explicitly to one or more of Jackson's Big Assumptions; it should involve him doing something counter to his Column 2 entries, and it should allow him to collect data about the accuracy or inaccuracy of the Big Assumption(s) in question. The coach reviewed the S-M-A-R-T criteria, and how a good test creates a best-case scenario to discover data that disconfirms his Big Assumption. Jackson expressed confidence in understanding the exercise and confirmed that the assumption he had been observing ("I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend") was the one he wants to test. He agreed to email his proposed test design, using the exercise in his ITC Workbook, to the coach at least a day before their next session.

Here is what Jackson sent to his coach:

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I will plan what I want to say to my boss about the difficulties we faced – and overcame – in the work we did with client X. I will frame this report to focus on what we learned in overcoming these obstacles without minimizing or misrepresenting my role in doing so.	Can I plan what to say that will strike the right tone? How well do I say what I have planned? How does my boss respond to my report? How do others respond to my report? Is there anyone to whom you'd like to give a "heads-up" or ask to serve as an observer who can give you feedback after the fact? Larissa, my good friend, shares my distaste for bragging and self-aggrandizement. She'll be at the meeting.	I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting embarrassed.

Review your test on the following criteria:

CRITERIA	YES	NOT SURE
Is it safe? (If the worst case were to happen, you could live with the results.)	✓	
Is the data relevant to your Big Assumption?	✓	
Does it have face validity? (The test actually tests your Big Assumption.)	✓	
Are the data sources valid? (No one is either out to get you or wants to protect or save you.)	✓	
Might it “re-true” your Big Assumption? (Is it designed so that it surely will lead to bad consequences, just as your BA tells you? Are you setting yourself up to fail? Is there any data you could collect that could disconfirm your BA?)	NO	
Is it actionable in the near-term? (E.g., the people or situation you need in order to enact the test are available, you are reasonably certain you know how to do what you plan, and you can run the test within the next week or so.)	✓	

When his coach reads Jackson’s test design, she notices particular things she’d like to know more about, and marks a few places where she thinks to focus their conversation. In particular, she wants to ask the following questions:

- I’m not sure I really understand the context. Tell me more about the difficult situation and the report – why might these be good opportunities to use as the basis for a test?
- Can you explain your thinking about the data you’ll collect? For example, what do you mean by “Can I plan what to say that will strike the right tone?”
- Also regarding data: What will tell you how your boss has responded to your report? (Similarly, what will tell you how others have responded?) Can you imagine specific things he (they) could do or say? What would be the best case scenario? What would be the worst, that you’re hoping to avoid?

In their next session, Jackson and his coach explore a bit more of the context and his intentions, get clearer about his thinking for this test and make some aspects of the design more explicit. One thing that becomes clear is the context – Jackson’s team has worked

through several challenges in a recent project that have helped them discover some important insights that have implications for the entire organization (e.g., marketing, cross-departmental communications, and project management). Typically, his report would focus exclusively on these points, as they represent the most consequential message to give his boss. However, Jackson sees that he can take this as an opportunity to publicize what he sees as an important personal success – turning a tricky situation with significant challenges to their advantage. What is most important to him is to be honest about his own role without making that the main story (which would feel like bragging). His goal is to maintain the focus on what he has learned that has relevance for the rest of the organization and be able to do so in a way that also accurately describes and perhaps celebrates his own role in the process.

During his conversation with his coach, Jackson becomes clearer in his thinking and planning for the test. In particular, he gets more explicit about how to collect data and what data to be looking for. He adds this additional information (which appears here in red) to his design:

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I will plan what I want to say to my boss about the difficulties we faced – and overcame – in the work we did with client X. Planning will help me take the time and choose words carefully to convey the right emphasis/ tone. I will frame this report to focus on what we learned in overcoming these obstacles without minimizing or misrepresenting my role in doing so. I'll let Larissa know what I'm up to, will rehearse with her, and will ask if she can observe the meeting. I will want her to watch for: how I came off (arrogant, etc.)? How was my tone? Did I back off?	Can I plan what to say that will strike the right tone – maintain the focus on the organizational learning while also conveying my own part/ contributions? When I say what I have planned, do I feel like I maintain that desired tone and focus? What else do I notice about how it went? How does my boss respond to my report? (Does he get impatient, wave me on to suggest I get to the point, lose eye contact, get distracted...?) How do others (e.g., Larissa) respond to the things I've asked her to look for?	I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting embarrassed.

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
		Is there anyone to whom you'd like to give a "heads up" or ask to serve as an observer who can give you feedback after the fact. I consider Larissa a good friend who shares my distaste for bragging and self-aggrandizement. I plan to practice the test with her beforehand and think she will be able to provide me with good feedback as to my tone, choice of words, comfort level, etc. If possible, she's going to join me at the meeting.	

Review your test on the following criteria:

CRITERIA	YES	NOT SURE
Is it safe? (If the worst case were to happen, you could live with the results.)	✓	
Is the data relevant to your Big Assumption?	✓	
Does it have face validity? (The test actually tests your Big Assumption.)	✓	
Are the data sources valid? (No one is either out to get you or wants to protect or save you.)	✓	
Might it "re-true" your Big Assumption? (Is it designed so that it surely will lead to bad consequences, just as your BA tells you? Are you setting yourself up to fail? Is there any data you could collect that could disconfirm your BA?)	NO	
Is it actionable in the near-term? (E.g., the people or situation you need in order to enact the test are available, you are reasonably certain you know how to do what you plan, and you can run the test within the next week or so.)	✓	

Amanda's Map

What about Amanda?

Commitment:	Doing/NotDoing	Hidden Competing Commitment	Big Assumptions
To lose 25 pounds thereby lowering my blood pressure and improving my cholesterol.	I don't count calories. I don't stick to diets. I eat when I'm stressed or feeling down. I use any excuse not to go to the gym (bad weather, too tired, too busy, etc.). I drink beer before, during, and after dinner. I use food and drink as rewards. I tell myself that I can't change my habits or get thin, and probably can't improve my numbers (BP, cholesterol) much because I inherited these problems.	Fears – having to follow rules, feeling trapped, inconvenienced and annoyed by diet. Embarrassment that others will know I can about this stuff. That my life will be bleak. I am committed to always feeling the freedom of having lots of options, making my own decisions, not having to follow someone else's rules. I am committed to rewarding myself, getting what I deserve. Not admitting that the implications on my health are as bad as they might actually be.	I assume that if I don't have lots of options, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak. I assume that if I don't reward myself with food or drink, then I will be less motivated at work and in my personal life. I assume that if I were to take seriously the fact that my health is not great, I'll become depressed and maybe act in ways that are even more unhealthy.

Amanda's Test Design

As she has been working on her CoP, her observations, and her Bio, Amanda has been reading about diet and exercise. She has learned how self-talk, especially self-sabotaging-talk is common among dieters, and she has learned about more productive thought patterns she'd now like to try out. She also has been taking notes on strategies for healthy eating. While she has been making modest progress on her diet, she knows that she will really be tested during the holidays, when her Big Assumptions are most likely to get triggered. She designs the following test and emails it to her coach in advance of their upcoming session:

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	When I go to the holiday party, I will survey the buffet and make a conscious choice about what foods I will allow myself to eat and how much. I will allow myself one beer or glass of wine.	Do I feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed? Did I enjoy the party? Did I enjoy what I ate and drank? Did I enjoy other parts of the party (met new people I liked, had interesting conversations, etc.)? Is there anyone to whom you'd like to give a "heads-up" or ask to serve as an observer who can give you feedback after the fact? Josslyn – she's my ITC partner, who is working on similar issues – will also be at the party. She will observe whether I can effectively change my behavior.	I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, stressed. I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

Review your test on the following criteria:

Criteria	YES	NOT SURE
Is it safe? (If the worst case were to happen, you could live with the results.)	✓	
Is the data relevant to your Big Assumption?	✓	
Does it have face validity? (The test actually tests your Big Assumption.)	✓	
Are the data sources valid? (No one is either out to get you or wants to protect or save you.)	✓	
Might it “re-true” your Big Assumption? (Is it designed so that it surely will lead to bad consequences, just as your BA tells you? Are you setting yourself up to fail? Is there any data you could collect that could disconfirm your BA?)	NO	
Is it actionable in the near-term? (e.g., the people or situation you need in order to enact the test are available, you are reasonably certain you know how to do what you plan, and you can run the test within the next week or so).	✓	

When Amanda’s coach receives and reads the test, he wonders whether this is a “best-case” scenario to generate data to disconfirm her assumption, and whether she might end up re-trueing her Big Assumptions. His hunch is that there are ways they can tweak the test design to increase the chances of modifying them in a way that will help Amanda continue to make progress on her goal. He asks himself:

- Are there ways that Amanda can eat healthily at this party that don’t just require her to blindly follow a rule she has set for herself? How can her test allow her to maximize her choices, or at least to be clear about the ways that she doesn’t have to restrict herself?
- One of the things Amanda has learned from her work in the earlier stages of this process is that she really uses self-talk and imagery well – as a way of keeping stress at bay in other aspects of her life. Can we apply these strategies to this issue, in this test.

As they discuss these ideas in their coaching meeting, Amanda makes the following changes to her test design:

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	When I go to the holiday party, I will survey the buffet and make a conscious choice about what foods I will allow myself to eat and how much. I will not limit the amount of fresh fruit and vegetables I can have. I will allow myself one beer or glass of wine. I won't stand next to the buffet during the party. I will get my food and then walk away. I will tell Josslyn my plan (just telling her will make me more mindful!).	Do I feel in charge, like I make my own choices or that I am forced to live by someone else's choice? How does it feel to make my initial decision after surveying the buffet? How do I feel during the party (esp. regarding decisions about what to eat)? How do I feel afterward? Did I feel like I had some choice? How did I feel about that? Was I realistic in setting goals and limits about what I could and couldn't eat? (Was I still hungry?) Was I overly restrictive in my initial decision? Did I develop counter arguments in my head to overrule my initial decisions? Could I use self talk to talk back to and overrule those counter arguments? Did I enjoy the party? Did I enjoy what I ate and drank? Did I enjoy other parts of the party (met new people I liked, had interesting conversations, etc.)?	Being in charge means following my impulses and indulgences or following my conscious decisions. I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, stressed. I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

Engaging your Client in This Exercise

Help your client understand the context for the assignment. As with the other ITC exercises, your job is to help your client to understand how this exercise is connected to those he has already completed and to the core ideas of the immunity-to-change concept (especially the connection between making progress on his column one goal and making changes to the

Big Assumptions he currently holds). You can also highlight for your client the importance of this step in the process of overturning one's immunities.

What are the connections that you see between the testing step and those that have come previously? Which exercises do you see this step as most connected to and why?

Here are the connections we see:

This exercise is directly connected to the ITC Map, particularly to the Big Assumptions that your client has identified. Big Assumptions, when taken as true, explain why we engage in the column 2 behaviors and therefore also undermine our column 1 goals. If we are able to alter or even reject those Big Assumptions, we can also change our behaviors so as to make progress on our column 1 goal.

How much of this connection you wish to share with your client, and when you share it, is up to you.

The more your client understands about the purposes and potential benefits of testing and sees these as focused on his Big Assumptions, the easier it will be to work with him to make this exercise as effective as possible.

Before we describe the process of designing a good test, we want to invite you to consider the potential challenges and pitfalls to avoid.

1. Conceptually, how could the design of a test be off track?
2. In practice, what might you actually say to your client to either learn what's off or to address what's off?

The next section describes some of the challenges and pitfalls we've identified, as well as ways to identify and address them with your client.

Identifying which Big Assumption to Test

If your client has identified and been working with several Big Assumptions, you'll need to agree on which one to focus on for the test. Often, a test will have implications for more than one Big Assumption, which is fine, but it is important that every test be explicitly connected to at least one Big Assumption.

...there may still be reasons to unpack the Big Assumption a bit more.

Ideally, the Big Assumption you select should be both powerful and clearly testable. For example, let's say your client's Big Assumption is "If I were to fail as a lawyer, then I would not be able to face myself." Designing a test of this Big Assumption as it is currently framed would mean that he would have to fail in order to see if he actually could or couldn't face himself. Clearly, this test would not be safe or modest, and we would need to

identify other more testable assumptions within or related to it. Even when the assumption seems safer, there may still be reasons to unpack the Big Assumption a bit more. For example, we can imagine the Big Assumption worded somewhat differently, "If I discover I am not a great lawyer, I will not be able to face myself." While it may be possible to design a safer test of this assumption, what it means to be a "great lawyer" is very broad. What does this client think is "great?" He could mean, "If I can't make partner by the time I'm 35, then I'm not great." He could mean, "If my father, who was a lawyer, doesn't feel I am living up to his standards, then I'm not great." He could mean, "If I don't win every case that goes to trial, then I'm not great." We can see how important it is to unpack these assumptions because whichever one we decide to test will lead to very different tests. (See the chapter on *Honing the Map* if you're not sure if your client's Big Assumption is testable and for more on this topic).

Here are some questions to ask your client that might help you establish which Big Assumption to test:

- Which Big Assumption jumps out as the one that most gets in your way?
- If you could change any single Big Assumption, which one would make the biggest, most positive difference for you?
- Is the Big Assumption too catastrophic to test safely? (E.g., "If I tell my boss what I think of him, he'll fire me.") If so, how can this Big Assumption be unpacked to identify a less catastrophic one that might be testable? (E.g., "I assume that I can't express any disagreement to my boss without her getting angry.")
- Can you imagine any information or data that would disconfirm (to any degree) your Big Assumption? (Hint: if your client cannot imagine any information or data that would lead him to question the validity of his big assumption, *then his assumption is not testable.*)

Sometimes the client starts to design a test by proposing an idea for what he could do differently than he typically does that he would like to try out. It strikes you as just the kind of thing he has been unable to do in the past and it intuitively seems connected to his larger immune system. How might you respond to that?

Our response:

Whatever test your client designs needs to connect explicitly to one or more of his Big Assumptions. If there seems to be an intuitive connection, see if you can identify what the connection is. It may help surface an important aspect of his immunity that is not represented in his map, and it will strengthen the test if you are clear about what you are ultimately hoping to learn. Watch out for getting so focused on the behavior change that you miss the overall purpose of learning about the accuracy of the Big Assumption in question.

Standards and Suggestions for Good Test Design

The participant workbook summarizes the crucial criteria necessary for designing a good test. We refer to them as the **S-M-A-R-T** criteria:

- **S-M**: it is important that your client's experiment be both **safe** and **modest**. You might ask your client, "What can you risk doing, or resist doing, on a small scale that might seem inadvisable if you held my Big Assumption as true, in order to learn what the results would actually be?"
- **A**: a good test will be **actionable** in the near-term. This means that the test is relatively easy to carry out (ideally, it doesn't require your client to go out of her way at all, but rather is an opportunity to do something different in her normal day), and that she is able to carry it out within the next week or so.
- **R-T**: finally, a good test **researches** the question, "how accurate is your client's Big Assumption?" and, like any good research, it requires collecting data (including data that would qualify your assumption or call it into doubt). In addition to how people react to you client, *her feelings* can be a very rich data source. The test, in fact, **tests** her Big Assumption. A "test" should not be some clever way to prove that her Big Assumption is true! Her test should be designed so that it can generate disconfirming data, if it exists.

One of the most useful starting points for designing a test is to ask your client this question: "What data, if it could be collected, would disconfirm (to any degree) your Big Assumption?" This prompts your client to start with the R-T criteria, often the trickiest one to meet. Once he has identified that data, he can work backwards and think about an upcoming situation in which he can safely create the conditions to produce that data (the S-M-A criteria). How does your client create such conditions? He changes his behavior...

Changing Behavior

Testing requires us to change our behaviors so that we can collect data about our Big Assumptions. Often a change in behavior can be extremely modest (e.g., actively looking to identify someone who embodies a way of being that your assumption holds as impossible), quite modest (e.g., asking someone for advice about how they succeeded in making a similar change), or more risky (e.g., saying "no" when you would ordinarily, automatically say "yes"). Other times it may seem like an ambitious change (e.g., confronting one's father about a long-standing issue in the family). Deciding what behavior change to undertake can be tricky. Some clients will know exactly what they would like to do. Others will want lots of guidance from their coaches.

Here are some questions that can help your client to start:

What data would lead you to doubt your Big Assumption? This question prompts your client to start with the R-T criteria, often the trickiest one to meet. Once she has identified those data, she can work backwards and think about an upcoming situation in which she can safely create the conditions to produce those data (the S-M-A criteria). If your client can answer that question, she may then have the necessary direction she'll need to identify how to change her behavior.

What behavior could you change (start or stop doing) that would get you useful information about your Big Assumption? For example, your client could:

- Alter a behavior from your Column 2.
- Perform an action that runs counter to your Column 3 Commitment.
- Start directly from your Big Assumption (Column 4): “What experiment would give me information (as to whether, e.g., the if-then sequence built into the assumption is really so certain)?”
- Go to her Continuum of Progress and enact a version of a next recognizable step.
- Go to her Observations of Counters to her Big Assumption and try an intentional version of one of these.

Sometimes the immediate context of the client's life suggests possible tests. For example, if there is an important event coming up – a meeting, family reunion, holiday, interview that directly implicates column 2 behaviors and Big Assumptions – that event may inspire your client to consider ways she could participate differently in that event and gather valuable information about her Big Assumption. Tests that are designed around upcoming events usually have the advantage of being actionable. Make sure they are also safe enough, and that your client is not making unreasonable demands on herself to carry out the test.

Practice can increase the chances that your client's behaviors can generate quality data in her test. To actualize a “best-case” test, your client may need to enact less familiar, even new, behavior(s) to her. In that situation, most clients benefit from planning what they will do or say. Depending on how they choose to prepare, they can receive and use feedback from their coach to successfully enact their intended behaviors. This also increases the safety of the test.

Practice can increase the chances that your client's behaviors can generate quality data in her test.

Here are a few suggestions to consider with your client:

- Your client talks about what she plans to say or do and how she plans to do it.
- Your client writes down what she plans to say or do and how she plans to do it.

- She anticipates possible ways that others could respond or events could unfold that might lead your client to default to typical and/or unproductive ways of making sense and behaving. She prepares alternative strategies.
- You and your client role-play the test situation (this will allow you to assess her skill level and give your client an opportunity to practice new behaviors).
- Consider with your client the implications of tone of voice, body language, choice of words.

Another reason to invite your client to practice is to increase the likelihood that when the test time comes, she can actually test his Big Assumption, and not re-true it. Imagine this: your client intends to run a test but doesn't know how to engage in these new behaviors with sufficient competency. In his clumsy attempts at these behaviors she may end up creating the very conditions under which his Big Assumption is valid (in which case, she is re-trueing, not testing, her assumption). For example, let's say that your client Marjorie decides that she will change her behavior by saying "no" when her colleague asks her for help with an assignment. Conceptually, that is a very reasonable test to run, but whether it is a "best-case" test or not depends on how she says "no". She could, for instance, decide, "I have had it. I'm just going to tell my colleague there's no way I'm helping out, and that she needs to stop being so lazy, dependent, and demanding!" Or she could say, "I wish I could help you out, but I have an overflowing plate right now." Clearly the second response is more likely to challenge the client's Big Assumption that her colleague will necessarily be angry with her.

Draw on your real-time experience coaching your client, as well as your knowledge of her Big Assumptions to help you assess how ready she is and what preparation might be most useful to offer. Is your client's ITC map about wanting to look good and to be seen in the best light by others (including you!)? She may have a hard time revealing that she doesn't know how to enact his test skillfully. Has your client had an angry outburst about something you said or did? She may need to practice how she wants to handle tense "what-if" situations.

If you have questions about whether or not your client will produce appropriate behavior for her test, discuss with her options for what is in her best learning interests. You and your client may decide that she needs additional skill development before she can safely run her test. As you plan for how she can receive that training, work together to develop a safer test design.

Data

The test design must allow your client to gather data that will inform his Big Assumption.

What kind of data do we want to collect?

Directly observable data about self and other: Some data will be directly observable data – the actual things people say or do, the words or action that would be captured on a videotape if the event were recorded. This includes what your client did and said, as well as what the other people in the test situation did and said.

Experiential data about self: It is also important to collect experiential data on one's own inner states. These include how your client felt or made sense of what happened (not necessarily whether he expressed or conveyed his reaction). Depending on the Big Assumption, your client may only be able to collect this type of data. For example, imagine a client with this Big Assumption: "I assume that if I feel sympathy for my mother, I will lose touch with my own feelings." Any test designed around this Big Assumption will collect data about your client's internal experience (data about his feelings of sympathy and data about whether or not he loses touch with his own feelings).

Not interpretations: We ask clients to **not** collect "data" that depend on them having to "read between the lines" of someone else's thoughts or feelings. For example, reporting that "my mother did not like what I said" is not "data." Instead, they should keep track of the directly observable data: what the others said or did, including their non-verbals, that led to their inference. If data about others' thoughts and feelings is important to the test, the client should explicitly ask for that feedback from others.

If, and then clauses: Your client should collect data relevant to both the "if" clause and the "then" clause so that he can see the connection between what he actually does (vs. intends/ designs) and the outcomes. Consider this example. Your client's Big Assumption is, "If I ask for help, people will let me down." Testing his Big Assumption will depend on whether or not he actually **did** ask for help. Your client might have planned to say "I would appreciate 15 minutes of your time" and ended up saying "I'm so busy," hoping that his colleague would get the hint that he needs help. Getting directly observable data (from your client and other potential data sources) about what he actually did and said will help you both determine if he actually enacted the "if" part of his Big Assumption. Then consider the "then" clause. What data will indicate whether people let him down or not? Do they offer to help but sound insincere? Do they offer to help but then don't follow through? Getting good data (from your client and other potential data sources) about what others actually did (and didn't) say and do will help you both determine the validity of the "then" part of his Big Assumption.

*What might make it challenging to collect the data he intends?
Any tips?*

Insufficient Skill: As you might expect from our discussion of what data to collect, some clients will be skilled data collectors, easily recalling specific details and able to describe events, actions, and their own feelings without making large interpretive leaps and rushing to judgment. However, that is not a skill all clients will necessarily possess, and you may need to help yours to build that skill.

One way you can help is to ask your client to prepare to collect data

- Invite her to imagine actually running her test, and to imagine the possibilities for what the collected data could be.
- Role-play the test situation.
- Ask her to expand on her answers if they are too broad or vague (see the in-depth examples above, especially Jackson).
- Extend some of the behavior practice options described in the Changing Behavior section above. For example, after role playing the test, you could ask your client what the relevant data were (directly observable things you said and did, and her internal experience).
- If your client has trouble remembering descriptive details or differentiating between data and interpretation or assessment, it would be good if he recorded what actually happened or didn't happen in the moment, how people responded, how she felt, and what was going on in her mind.

A good pointer in deciding upon strategies for collecting data is that data collection should not interfere with your client's ability to still be present in the moment.

Overwhelmed by Feelings: Also, as your client enacts a test, she may experience many feelings at once, and her feelings may change during the test. She may also experience a great deal of "mind chatter" as she struggles to remember what she planned to do or say and has reactions and interpretations to what is happening. You may want to help your client identify some techniques or strategies for staying focused on the task at hand. Is there a guiding image or phrase (like a mantra) she can repeat that might help her stay focused? Are there specific phrases or actions that she can prepare in advance that she can use when she feels at a loss for what to do next?

Big Assumption Takes Over: One way to improve the quality of the data is to enlist others as data collectors. The more a person is under the grip of her Big Assumptions, the less skillful she will be at observing. She will have a strong tendency to see things as she wants them to be, fears them to be, and/or expects them to be. Getting even one more perspective about what the data are, what they show, and how they reflect back on the Big Assumption can lead to much more powerful learning. If your client can include others as data collectors, she should prepare what will he say to them about what she is doing and the particular form of data he wants. The clearer your client can be in communicating exactly what he wants, the more likely this person will be able to gather useable and valuable data.

If she can ask for others to act as data collectors, consider if there is any reason to believe that these data collectors won't act or speak in ways that are honest. For example, someone with a grudge, who has good reason to wish ill of your client, may provide data that is skewed with a negative bias. Clients often choose a supportive friend or colleague as a data source. These people can often serve that function well, as long as their inclinations to protect and/or root for your client are not so strong that they provide skewed data of a different sort, reflecting only a positive bias.

Forecasting Potential Results: Is it a True Test of the Big Assumption?

Forecasting the potential results of your client's test will help you both determine whether it is safe enough (or perhaps too safe). Consider with your client how bad it would be if the outcome of the experiment confirmed her Big Assumption's worst suspicions. Might it cause unacceptable costs or other harm to her or others (including the organization)? Share any "what if" scenarios you can think of that might be risky. Keep in mind that while the test situation should not be controversial or emotionally charged, the test should not be so routine, small, or unimportant to her that it wouldn't matter what happened.

Imagining the possible results can also help you look for any re-truing qualities in the test. Has your client designed a test that is more likely to confirm when and if her Big Assumption is true than to find examples that disconfirm it? Imagine, for example, this Big Assumption: "If I delegate more work to my direct reports, the work won't be done well enough to meet my standards." If this client's test is to simply hand over projects to others and wait for the results, she may in fact find his Big Assumption confirmed. However, if she meets with the relevant direct reports about each project she is handing over, so that they reach agreement about the priority level of the project, the standards for the quality of work, and the type of support or training needed to ensure success, she is much more likely to receive results that disconfirm his Big Assumption.

Designing Tests of Philosophical/ Religious Assumptions

Some of the most difficult tests to design are those that focus on Big Assumptions that are religious or philosophical in nature. Consider, for example, how to test these assumptions:

- I assume I deserve to be punished for my sinful thoughts.
- I assume that I am weak because I cannot transcend my physical limitations.
- I assume that if I don't always sacrifice my own wishes on behalf of others, I will go to hell.

It is challenging, if not impossible, to imagine a SMART test that will lead to conclusive results about any one of these assumptions. However, that doesn't mean that these assumptions are completely un-testable. If I, for example, assume that I am weak because I cannot transcend my physical limitations, I could deliberately seek out data about how others have

I don't judge myself harshly for my weaknesses but instead see them as part of the universal struggle to be human.

lived their lives in ways that challenge my assumption. Perhaps there is someone I deeply admire whom I could interview (or even read about) who faced a similar type of struggle. I might come away from that experience feeling, "This person I admire so much also struggles with her physical limitations.

She is not weak. Therefore, I cannot necessarily conclude I am weak either." Or, I may conclude, "This person I admire so much also struggles with her physical limitations. Perhaps we are all weak in some ways, but now I feel differently about 'weakness' than I used to. I don't judge myself harshly for my weaknesses but instead see them as part of the universal struggle to be human." I may conclude, "This person I admire so much cannot transcend her physical limitations, but that does not make her weak at all. Her struggle makes her strong."

Testing the belief therefore involves imagining what type of data or data source could potentially provide a more differentiated or contrasting picture that could challenge my assumption. In the case of religious assumptions, a data source that presents a contrasting picture may come in the form of a conversation with a religious leader, reading a book that presents a complex and nuanced portrait of an admired religious person, or by engaging in particular practices (e.g., meditation, prayer, or worship) that help the client achieve an inner state (e.g., peacefulness, forgiveness, or compassion) that contrasts with that fueling his assumption.

Tips and Pitfalls

Coach's Tips for Designing a Test

1. Keep the purpose and intended results in mind throughout the process of planning a test. The purpose of a test is to see what happens when you intentionally alter your usual behavior in order to learn about the accuracy of your Big Assumption.
2. Plan to have enough time to work with your client so that he can design and run at least two tests.
3. Due to the fact that clients will vary in their ability to design their own tests, be sensitive to cues about how much (and how little) help they'll need from you in order to design and run a high quality ITC test.
4. Do not forget the "Two Hats" of the coach: being an empathetic listener and probing for the ITC implications of what is said.
5. Be alert to the ways that your meetings with your client provide you with information relevant to your coaching. The ways in which his immunities do and don't show up with you are an important source of data as well.

Overall Tips

1. Make sure that any test your client designs is clearly connected to at least one of his Big Assumptions. Often, a test connects to more than one.
2. You may need to unpack or hone a Big Assumption in order to design a test for it.

Tips for Identifying Which Big Assumption to Test

Tips for Good Test Design

1. A test should meet the S-M-A-R-T criteria – it should be safe, modest, and actionable. It should be designed to research the Big Assumption, and it should be a true test (not designed to confirm the Big Assumption).
2. If possible, start with the R-T criteria and ask “What realistic data would challenge the validity of your Big Assumption?” Then create a test design that increases the likelihood that such data, if it exists, could be generated.
3. In planning how to change his behavior (the “if” part of his Big Assumption), make sure your client has the skill to enact the new behavior successfully.
4. Be on the lookout for any re-truing dimensions of the test (in addition to #3 above, also consider who else is involved; is there enough time; etc.).

Tips for Collecting Good Data

1. Wherever possible, look for ways that your client can collect directly observable data – the actual things people say or do, the words or action that would be captured on a videotape if the event were recorded.
2. Your client should also collect experiential data on her own inner states. Sometimes this is the only data that can be collected.
3. Your client **should not** collect “data” that are actually her beliefs about how others felt or others made sense of the situation.
4. The client may likely feel heightened emotion during the test. It is important to prepare sufficiently so that high quality data can be collected and so that data collection will not interfere with your client’s ability to be present in the moment.
5. One way to improve the quality of data is to enlist others as data collectors, providing them with enough information about the test and what data are needed.
6. In designing a test, it should be clear how the anticipated data can potentially inform the Big Assumption.

Potential Pitfalls

Coach	Client
Loses sight of the purpose of developing a test (gathering data to learn about the Big Assumption). Gets pulled into client's enthusiasm for successfully enacting new behaviors.	Experiences his new behavior as exciting and even powerful, but not because he is overturning his immune system. Behavior changes are likely to be short-lived.
Assesses the quality of the test but does not make that process transparent for client or share criteria with him.	Runs a "correct" test according to coach's standards, but not powerful to himself. Does not improve his ability to design and run tests on his own.
Approves test design as having "face validity" without assessing carefully.	Is not clear about the focus of the test, what data he will be collecting, or how that data can inform his Big Assumption.
Structures test as a way to lead client into pre-ordained "deeper" level or insight.	Feels manipulated, overwhelmed, judged, and/or resistant.
Gets overly focused on meeting the criteria, not carefully listening to (and so getting disconnected from) client's own meaning, understanding, and/or experience.	Feels dread or worry about what the overturning process will entail. Loses sight of the overall purpose of testing in focusing on so many details.
Spends too much time and energy on the test design and preparations, engaging in unnecessary analysis and planning.	Loses motivation and grows impatient. Feels insulted or infantilized by the slow pace. May feel coach lacks trust in his ability to overturn immunities.
Doesn't help client prepare sufficiently for test.	Feels excessively anxious about test or fails to identify potential risks that may exist.

Now it's your turn to assess some test designs. Remember to consider all of the S-M-A-R-T criteria and to ensure there is a strong connection to one of the client's Big Assumptions. There is a space after each test design that should be used for recording your comments (including what you would do to improve any weaknesses). After doing each, you can read our comments on these designs. We strongly suggest that you do not look ahead to our commentary until after you have completed your own.

Practice Time: Over To You

Andrew

Andrew is an expert in issues connected to the preservation of wilderness and works for a large national park. Recently, he has taken on new responsibilities for promoting the park's programs that focus on habitat sustainability and wildlife management. The park's policies, based on research, can often impact and sometimes conflict with the agendas of people living and working in surrounding towns. Part of Andrew's responsibility is to promote the education of and outreach to citizens and businesses in the area. In the past, Andrew's work has not required him to take on this level of (and exhibit skill in) social interaction. He finds himself avoiding the education and outreach work because he is worried that he will not be able to do it effectively.

Andrew's Map

Commitment:	Doing/NotDoing	Hidden Competing Commitment	Big Assumptions
I am committed to identifying and building strong partnerships and coalitions to not only move the park's sustainable wildlife program forward, but to mend relationships that have recently broken down between the park and surrounding businesses.	Waiting for someone else to step-up and initiate actions. Communicating through e-mail rather than the phone or in person. Making myself so busy that I don't have the time for this. (Distractions) "Playing it Safe." Not speaking up or reaching out to others because I fear failure and rejection.	Fear of rejection/ failure. Fear of things getting out of my control. Fear of finding myself in a situation I don't know how to handle. I am committed to not taking "social risks" that will increase my stress/ anxiety level. Committed to not looking bad professionally. Committed to not finding out that I can't do this work.	I assume that if... 1. I take "social risks" it will increase my stress level (anxiety, frustration, and embarrassment) to unbearable levels. 2. I take "social risks," I will misstep, and people will judge me negatively. 3. I take social risks I might say the wrong thing or end up looking bad, things might go wrong, people will question my professionalism, and I will feel like a failure. All this will result in lasting negative impressions of me.

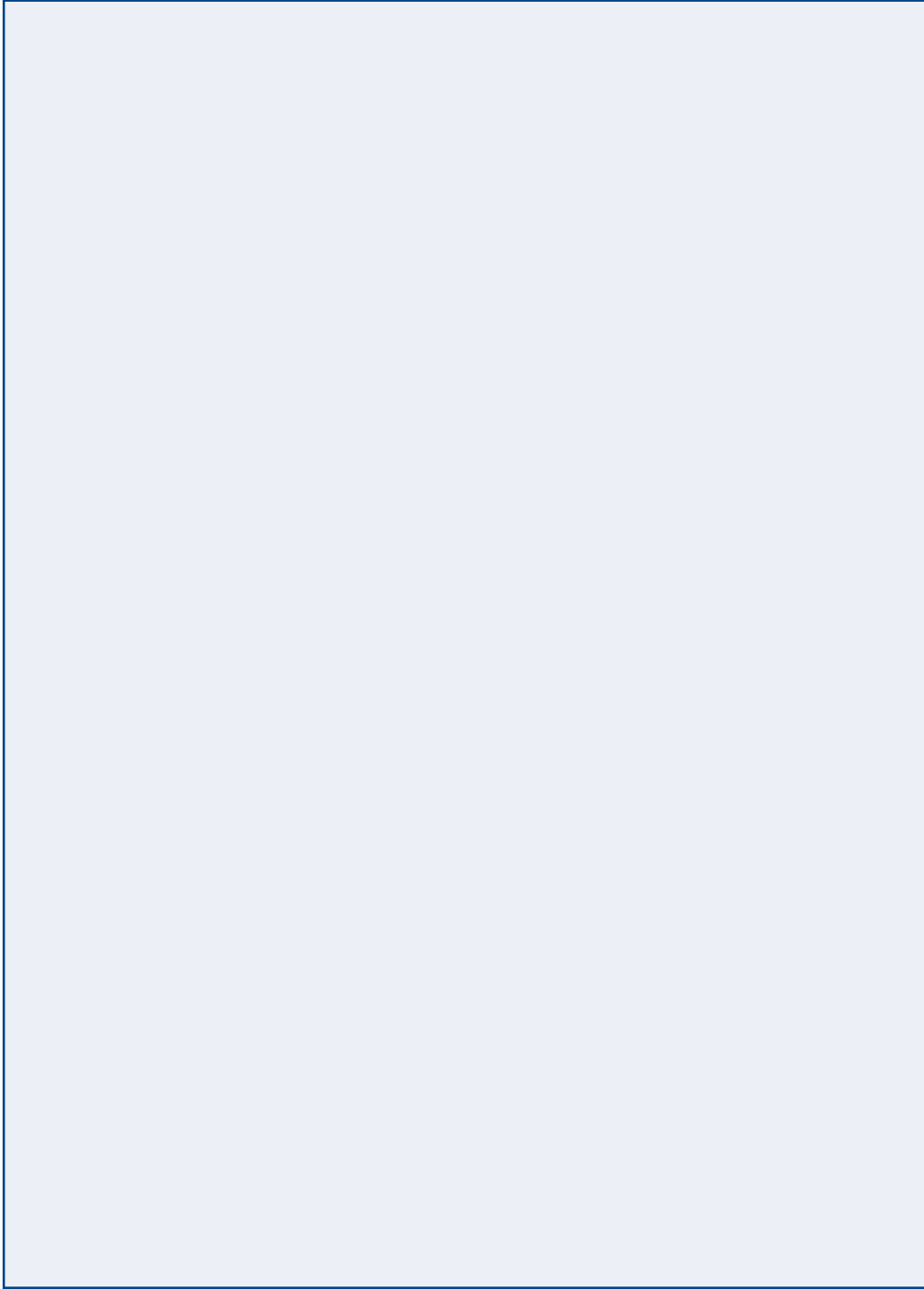
Designing Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I take “social risks” it will increase my stress level (anxiety, frustration, and embarrassment) to unbearable levels. If I take “social risks,” I will misstep, and people will judge me negatively. If I take “social risks,” I might say the wrong thing or end up looking bad, things might go wrong, people will question my professionalism, and I will feel like a failure.	I will approach a professor at a nearby university about some research he was doing in the park on the preservation of natural habitats. I will express my interest in helping him do more related research projects here that could be used as a way to educate the local community about the complexity of the park ecosystem.	Data will be based on what I do and say, as well as how I feel. Will I express clearly how his work is important to my larger project (or will I say or do the wrong thing)? Will my behavior remain professional? How will he respond? Is there anyone to whom you’d like to give a “heads-up” or ask to serve as an observer who can give you feedback after the fact? Not really.	I can increase my skills in communication. I can lessen the risk involved in this work to manageable levels. I can take risks that are at an acceptable level. I can act on the responsibilities of my work rather than procrastinating out of dread.

Review your test on these criteria:

CRITERIA	YES	NOT SURE
Is it safe? (If the worst case were to happen, you could live with the results.)	✓	
Is the data relevant to your Big Assumption?	✓	
Does it have face validity? (The test actually tests your Big Assumption.)	✓	
Are the data sources valid? (No one is either out to get you or wants to protect or save you.)	✓	
Might it “re-true” your Big Assumption? (Is it designed so that it surely will lead to bad consequences, just as your BA tells you? Are you setting yourself up to fail? Is there any data you could collect that could disconfirm your BA?)	NO	
Is it actionable in the near-term? (E.g., the people or situation you need in order to enact the test are available, you are reasonably certain you know how to do what you plan, and you can run the test within the next week or so.)	✓	

Your Comments



Our Comments

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach was Thinking
My Big Assumption Says: If I take “social risks” it will increase my stress level (anxiety, frustration, and embarrassment) to unbearable levels. If I take “social risks,” I will misstep, and people will judge me negatively. If I take social risks I might say the wrong thing or end up looking bad, things might go wrong, people will question my professionalism, and I will feel like a failure. So I will change my behavior is this way: I will approach a professor at a nearby university about some research he was doing in the park on the preservation of natural habitats. I will express my interest in helping him do more related research projects here that could be used as a way to educate the local community about the complexity of the park ecosystem.	OK, he wants to test 3 BAs at once. I could be ok with that because they all have the same “if” clause. They focus on different parts of taking social risks – the stress he will experience, his skill (or lack of) in having these conversations, and the ultimate result of how others will judge him. I can see how his ideas for how to change his behavior will allow him to collect data about these BAs, except for the second one. How will he know if people are judging him negatively? Is he open to excluding that BA, at least for now? Part of his BA is around his skill and ability to engage in social interactions (saying the wrong thing, looking bad, other types of missteps). So, in order to be a fair test (and not just re-true his BAs), I think it makes sense to increase the chances that these missteps won’t happen. Maybe I’ll suggest that he plan what he wants to say. Then we can do a couple of role plays, where I am the professor and I respond in different ways (e.g., enthusiastically, with reserve, distracted, not interested, etc.). I also want to make sure that Andrew is clear that the purpose of the test isn’t to find a way to ensure that the professor responds with enthusiasm. Andrew could present his case eloquently – with charm, precision, skill – and the professor could still decline. And that would be an equally happy result in terms of overturning his BA. Another part of this involves his internal experience. I think the planning and practicing might also help decrease the chances that he’ll feel high levels of stress. AND, I want to make sure that in doing the preparation, we aren’t building this test up to be something that feels SO IMPORTANT AND CONSEQUENTIAL to him that he actually feels more stress as a result. I want to ask him to monitor his internal experience as we plan to see if that starts to build or decrease.

Our Comments continued

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach was Thinking
And Collect the Following Data: Data will be based on what I do and say, as well as how I feel. Will I express clearly how his work is important to my larger project (or will I say or do the wrong thing)? Will my behavior remain professional? How will he respond?	How will he collect these data? If he reads from his notes, that could be the data. Except for if he departs from those. Can he write down what he said immediately after the call? Write down his reflections on his inner experience right after the call too? This last part connects to his second BA. If Andrew really wants that one to be part of the test, we should be clear about the way this professor's response could provide important data? One way that it could be is if the prof doesn't understand Andrew or clearly is offended or uncomfortable by something Andrew does. (I think this is unlikely. Andrew can be a little nervous and awkward but I can't imagine him offending. Still, he worries about this.) How to increase the quality of that data? Maybe ask the professor something like, "Have I been clear about what I'm proposing?" Or, if he is worried about the professor's reaction, to ask, "Can you let me know how all of this is sitting with you? What's appealing? Unappealing?"
In order to find out whether: I can increase my skills in communication. I can lessen the risk involved in this work to manageable levels. I can take risks that are at an acceptable level. I can act on the responsibilities of my work rather than procrastinating out of dread.	These all make sense – as well as, "Does planning what to say in situations that I perceive to involve social risk help increase the chances that I'll communicate effectively and feel less stress?"
Andrew's responses in the table confirm that this test meets the S-M-A-R-T criteria.	I agree that this test does seem to meet the S-M-A-R-T criteria. I want to make sure to check back in with him about this at the end of our conversation, to make sure it still does (especially around the "safe" criterion).

Appendix A

Potential Tests

Big Assumption: *If I am not perfect and strong... I will not be respected in my role.*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I am not perfect and strong... I will not be respected in my role.	I will read biographies and memoirs of great leaders who changed history but were also able to show a softer, more vulnerable side – maybe even make mistakes.	Did they lose respect from others? Did they lose ground?	It is possible to show a weaker, softer side and still be respected as a leader.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I am not perfect and strong... I will not be respected in my role.	I will ask for more input on the upcoming presentation from the three other presenters (even though they are subordinates).	Did they lose respect Does the team become chaotic, feel like a free-for-all, or can I still step in and make an executive decision when I need to?	I have to hold the reins so tightly or if I can allow others to help me without being seen as weak.

Big Assumption: *I don't deserve the recognition because everything is easier for me.*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I don't deserve the recognition because everything is easier for me.	Make a list of all my accomplishments – large and small, those that came easy and those that came hardest. Put an asterisk next to the ones for which I received recognition from others.	How do I feel about the accomplishments for which I wasn't recognized? How many were recognized (vs. unrecognized)? How were they recognized?	I am uncomfortable with any recognition... I am comfortable only when I'm not recognized.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I don't deserve the recognition because everything is easier for me.	I will accept praise and compliments graciously, without offering apologies, self-criticism, or making a joke. I will listen carefully to their praise in order to learn what it is that they appreciate.	How do I feel? What do I learn from what they say?	I can feel comfortable with recognition – even enjoy it – without immediately thinking about whether or not it is deserved? Can I learn from others' praise about what is important to them?

Big Assumption: *If I don't drink or eat, I won't be as fun, I won't fit in.*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I don't drink or eat, I won't be as fun, I won't fit in.	Watch other people at the party who don't eat or drink much.	Do they seem to be having fun? What are they doing instead of eating and drinking?	Other people can have fun without eating or drinking so much.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data ...	In Order to Find Out Whether ...
If I don't drink or eat, I won't be as fun, I won't fit in.	I will have only one small plate of food and one glass of wine at the party. Then I'll take a glass of water or seltzer (as many as I want) and walk away from the food table and mingle with guests who are far away from it.	Do they seem to be having fun? Does the glass of water/seltzer allow me to feel I have enough to keep my hands occupied, or do I feel too awkward just sipping the same glass? Do I talk to different people than I usually do? Am I having any fun?	I feel comfortable...if I have fun... if I enjoy the conversations as much as when I'm buzzed.

Big Assumption: *If I have to engage in all the tedious details, I will go out of my mind with boredom and will hate my work.*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I have to engage in all the tedious details, I will go out of my mind with boredom and will hate my work.	Set aside 15 minutes before lunch and before going home just for tedious details. Don't think about them except during those times.	How much can I get done in that time? How do I feel about it?	Giving myself set times when I have to focus only on them (and other times when I am not allowed to) helps me feel less controlled by them.

Test #2

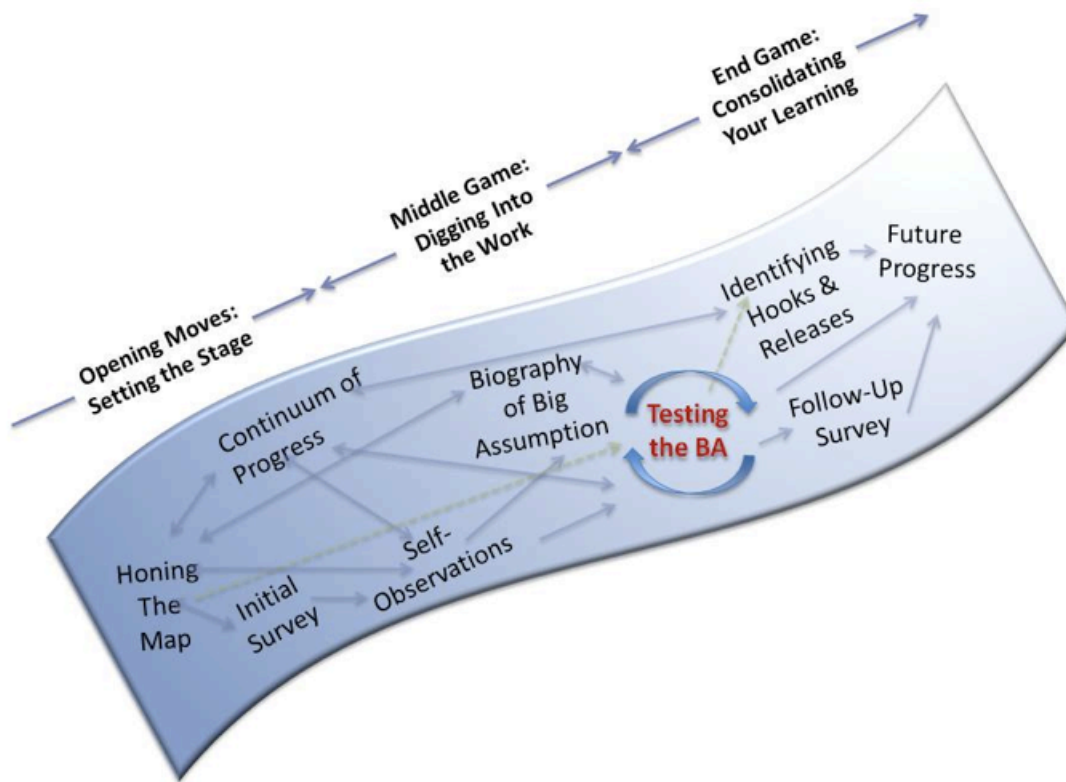
My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I have to engage in all the tedious details, I will go out of my mind with boredom and will hate my work.	Talk to my boss about giving some of those details to Mia's new assistant.	Does he say yes or no? Will he negotiate?	I actually have to engage in all the tedious details (or not).

Chapter 7

Running and Interpreting Tests of the Big Assumption

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Context for this Exercise

Testing Big Assumptions is at the heart of the Immunity-to-Change coaching process and serves as the biggest lever for a client to overturn his immune system. This is especially the case when tests are run iteratively and each subsequent test examines a next layer or portion of a Big Assumption.

By this time, your client has taken a first step in the testing progression by designing a test of his Big Assumption. Your client should have planned a test that meets the S-M-A-R-T criteria, feeling sufficiently confident that he knows how to enact the test. He planned what data he intended to collect, including data that could lead him to doubt the encompassing truth of his Big Assumption.

Hopefully, your client ran his test (the second step) since you last met. This next step, Interpreting Tests of the Big Assumption, is the last one in any one test iteration. Future tests of the Big Assumption will repeat the same sequence — design a test, run it, and interpret the results to understand what these data suggest about his Big Assumption. Over time, the purpose of testing his Big Assumptions is for your client to make progress on his Column 1 improvement goal.

Designing a test of a Big Assumption prepared your client to run a high-quality test of her Big Assumption. Hopefully, she has run that test and collected data about what happened (internally and externally) when she enacted behaviors contrary to her Big Assumption. Keeping in mind that the immediate purpose of a test is to learn about the accuracy of the Big Assumption (and not immediately to improve or “get better”), it is time for your client to explicitly interpret those data.

Your job in this next step, Interpreting Tests of the Big Assumption, is to help your client look at the data she collected to understand what they suggest about her Big Assumption. Ideally, she should be able to see if there are any aspects of her Big Assumption that are confirmed by the data, as well as any aspects that are disconfirmed. Remember that the purpose of running a good test is not for your client to see whether she was able to change her behavior (with successful or unsuccessful results), or to “prove” her assumption right or wrong, but rather to use the test results to inform her Big Assumption. The intended outcome of a given test cycle is for your client to have a realistic, data-based version of when, where and with whom her Big Assumption is relevant. The intended outcome of the iterative test cycle extends to your client moving towards, even reaching, her column 1 improvement goal.

Purpose and Benefits

- ✓ To learn about the accuracy (or inaccuracy) of her Big Assumptions.
- ✓ To create more “space” between the client and her Big Assumptions, especially where they are inaccurate.
- ✓ To make progress on her Column 1 improvement goal.
- ✓ To increase motivation for overturning her immunities.
- ✓ To increase ownership over the work and progress.
- ✓ To develop understanding of the connections between behavior, mindset and change.
- ✓ To gain enough skill and experience in designing, running and interpreting tests so as to continue testing even after contracted coaching period has ended.

Two General Points about Interpretating Data

Before we get into any details about and examples of interpreting tests in the sections below, here are two general points to keep in mind about interpretation:

1. Even relatively modest changes to a Big Assumption can overturn an immunity to change. The point of a test is not that your client outright reject a Big Assumption in order to accomplish his column 1 goal, but rather that he has a realistic, data-based version of when, where and with whom his Big Assumption is relevant (if at all). A Big Assumption automatically informs how we see reality, i.e., it is “behind” the eyes, so to speak, rather than in front of our eyes. What makes a “Big Assumption” more than merely “an assumption” is the belief, implicit or explicit, that what we assume is *always and completely* right. Perhaps no person’s Big Assumption is completely and always either “right” or “wrong.” The problem is that we don’t know about its accuracy because of our subjectivity to it. Consequently, we tend to overuse it and over-generalize its applicability far beyond its scope. If through testing his Big Assumption your client discovers that it is only accurate, say 90% of the time, his acting in new ways in just that newly found 10% can lead to significant gains on his improvement goal.

2. No one experiment is likely to be conclusive about a Big Assumption. This is why we suggest that you make sure to leave time for your client to design and run at least two tests. Often the second and third tests a person runs are similar to his first one, designed to build on what was already learned by experimenting in additional contexts and/or with different people. The test may also appear to introduce a higher level of risk (based on what were initial estimates, before the first test was run). In these cases, the findings from the first test illustrated that a more ambitious test now appears safe enough to run.

In-depth Examples: Jackson & Amanda

Jackson

Let's return to Jackson, and pick up where we left off in the last chapter (Designing Tests; see p. 249 for a copy of his 4-Column map). As a follow-up to his last meeting with his coach, Jackson revised his initial test design so that he was clearer about what he wanted to do differently when he met with his boss, and what data he wanted to collect. You may remember this is the test he intended to run:

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I will plan what I want to say to my boss about the difficulties we faced – and overcame – in the work we did with client X. Planning will help me take the time and choose words carefully to convey the right emphasis/ tone. I will frame this report to focus on what we learned in overcoming these obstacles without minimizing or misrepresenting my role in doing so. I'll let Larissa know what I'm up to, will rehearse with her, and will ask if she can observe the meeting. I will want her to watch for: how I came off (arrogant, etc.)? How was my tone? Did I back off?	Can I plan what to say that will strike the right tone – maintain the focus on the org. learning while also conveying my own part/contributions? When I say what I have planned, do I feel like I maintain that desired tone and focus? What else do I notice about how it went? How does my boss respond to my report? (Does he get impatient, wave me on to suggest I get to the point, lose eye contact, get distracted...?) How do others (e.g., Larissa) respond to the things I've asked her to look for?	I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting embarrassed.

Jackson then met with Larissa to practice his test with her beforehand and asked her if she would give him feedback about his tone, choice of words, comfort level, etc. She agreed to do that.

Jackson's Test Interpretation

Jackson ran his test, completed the test interpretation table in his workbook, and reflected on the data he and Larissa had collected. He emailed it to his coach. Here is what it looked like:

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I told my boss about the difficulties we faced (and overcame) in the [work we did with client X] – relying pretty much on what I had planned – focusing on what we learned in overcoming these obstacles. For most of it, I didn't minimize or misrepresent my role.	For the most part, I think I did strike the right tone and stayed focused, mostly because I was talking from my notes. My boss didn't really react. He seemed fine. Larissa was really enthusiastic about my report. She felt like I was still erring on the side of too much humility (which was a relief to me – baby steps). She agreed that my boss seemed pretty unfazed. Certainly not offended by any “bragging” on my part. She felt he could have been more supportive.	With proper planning, I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting (too) embarrassed.

Upon reading it, his coach was excited that Jackson seemed to be beginning to reformulate his Big Assumption. She also wondered why Jackson used the phrase “for the most part” in his description of what he did – is this a significant qualifying phrase or was Jackson just generalizing? She made a note to inquire about this phrase in her next conversation with Jackson. She reminded herself to first highlight all the valuable learning Jackson was engaged in and the ways that the test succeeded on many levels (e.g., high quality data, connections to the Big Assumption).

While talking with his coach about the whole test and whether there had been any exceptions to his ability to stay focused on his goals for the conversation, Jackson realized that there were some additional insights he could gain from his test. His additional notes appear following (in red).

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I told my boss about the difficulties we faced (and overcame) in the [work we did with client X] – relying pretty much on what I had planned – focusing on what we learned in overcoming these obstacles. For most of it, I didn't minimize or misrepresent my role, with one exception. The exception: after I was done, and my boss began to ask me a couple of questions, I played up others' roles in the process, maybe more than I wished (or was accurate). I think I was feeling nervous.	For the most part, I think I did strike the right tone and stayed focused, mostly because I was talking from my notes. I think I did get a little embarrassed at the end, when I was going more off-script. I started talking about how hard everyone had worked, and I felt like I was watching myself do that and thinking, "Now you sound like somebody's cheerleader, going on and on about what others did." It made me realize that in addition to down-playing my own role, I may have a tendency to overplay others' roles when it is not necessary. Other than comments and questions about the content of what I said, my boss said things like, "OK. Good to know. Keep me in the loop. Good job." Not much more. Larissa was really enthusiastic about my report. She felt like I was still erring on the side of too much humility (which was a relief to me – baby steps).	With proper planning, I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting (too) embarrassed. When I overplay others' contributions, it may sound over-the-top and be counter-productive.

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
		She thought my back-sliding comments about other team members were hilarious. (“You just can’t help yourself, can you? Are you really doing anyone any favors?”) She also felt that was maybe the only time when the boss seemed distracted. HM!	

Then Jackson and his coach discussed the next test for him to run. Ever since Jackson’s annual performance review for the previous year had been cancelled (and not yet rescheduled), Jackson had been imagining how he would like that conversation to go. In his Continuum of Progress, he had included requesting the performance review be scheduled as a “first step forward.” In his “significant progress” column, he had included “I am able to speak clearly and convincingly of my contributions to my department and the entire organization. I ask for a raise, and I am not embarrassed to do it.” Having struck a new tone in the meeting with his boss that was the focus of his first test, Jackson wants to capitalize on his sense of momentum and new insight and run this more ambitious test.

Here is what Jackson sends his coach:

Jackson's Test #2 Design

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I will request that my boss schedule and complete my performance review. I will prepare my own responses to the review questions, again without minimizing or misrepresenting my role in doing so. I will focus on my own contributions – not others'. I will ask for a raise. I'll send my written plan to Larissa and role play the performance review conversation with her. I'll ask her to listen for whether or not I've taken the right tone and whether I maintain the focus on my role (or if I back off).	Can I ask for the review to be rescheduled? Can I plan what to say that will strike the right tone – to convey the range and value of my contributions without sounding arrogant? When I say what I have planned, do I feel like I maintain that desired tone and focus? Can I keep the focus on me? What else do I notice about how it went? How does my boss respond to my own responses to the review questions? (Do I persuade him of my value and that I deserve the raise? Does he disagree with my own assessments? Does he agree with my own sense of my value?) How do others (e.g., Larissa) respond to the things I've asked her to look for?	I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting embarrassed. If I do get embarrassed or flustered, do I default again to talking about others' contributions?

Jackson's coach immediately hoped that Jackson wasn't stepping up the risk level too quickly or too high. She made a note to confirm with Jackson that the test indeed felt safe enough to run. She also wanted to make sure Jackson was incorporating what he learned from the last test, namely that if and when he gets nervous, he may be more likely to get triggered by his Big Assumption and revert back to familiar (but unwelcome) behaviors. Could Jackson identify ways that he could be on the alert for feeling nervous and have some strategies ready for not letting those nerves trigger the Big Assumption? Finally, his

coach was worried that Jackson was focusing on factors that were not within his control (and not necessary for collecting quality data about his Big Assumption), specifically, how his boss would react. She hoped that she could help Jackson see that he could present an eloquent and air-tight case without a trace of arrogance *and* his boss could still disagree or turn down his request for a raise. She planned to discuss what made it tricky to collect data about his boss' view.

As he discussed these ideas with his coach, Jackson added some additional features to his test design.

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I will request that my boss schedule and complete my performance review. I will prepare my own responses to the review questions, again without minimizing or misrepresenting my role in doing so. I will focus on my own contributions – not others'. If I begin to get nervous or flustered, I will take a deep breath and remind myself that I am not doing anyone favors when I overplay others' contributions. I will imagine that I am not actually talking about myself but about someone else – a colleague I respect, admire, and want to support. In that way, I will regain the right tone. I will ask for a raise.	Can I ask for the review to be rescheduled? Can I plan what to say that will strike the right tone – to convey the range and value of my contributions without sounding arrogant? When I say what I have planned, do I feel like I maintain that desired tone and focus? Do I feel that I effectively make my case? Can I keep the focus on me? What else do I notice about how it went? Do I actually feel nervous or flustered? When? What triggers those feelings? Do my strategies help me relax and refocus to achieve my purpose?	I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting embarrassed. If I do get embarrassed or flustered, do I default again to talking about others' contributions?

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
	I'll send my written plan to Larissa and role play the performance review conversation with her. I'll ask her to listen for whether or not I've taken the right tone and whether I maintain the focus on my role (or if I back off).	Does my boss' response indicate that he thinks I'm overplaying my own role and contributions? Are there any clear indications that he feels I'm being arrogant? (Does he scoff? Show offense?) How do others (e.g., Larissa) respond to the things I've asked her to look for?	

Jackson's Test #2: Interpretation

Jackson ran his second test, completed the test interpretation table in his workbook, and reflected on the data he and Larissa had collected. He emails it to his coach. Here is what it looks like:

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I did request that my performance review be rescheduled and completed. We just had it last week. I prepared my own responses to the review questions, again without minimizing or misrepresenting my role in doing so. In the review conversation, I kept the focus on my own contributions – not others'. The only time I got nervous was before the conversation started. I remembered to take a deep breath and remind myself that I am not doing anyone favors when I overplay others' contributions. I also imagined that I was not actually talking about myself but about someone else – a colleague I respect, admire, and want to support. I did ask for a raise. I discussed my written plan with Larissa, and we did role play the performance review conversation. She gave me feedback.	It went really well! I was worried that my boss would tell me we were too busy to do the review at this time, but he actually rescheduled it right away and apologized that we hadn't done it sooner. I was nervous before we actually met, but it helped to have some reminders. I think that also helped me make sure I was really prepared with what to say and how to say it. In the conversation itself, my boss was really apologetic again. He basically agreed with everything I said, nodding his head and offering no arguments. It was so easy. I actually shortened some of the points I wanted to make because it seemed unnecessary to elaborate further. The hardest part of the whole thing was doing the preparation with Larissa. I felt most embarrassed with her – during the role play – because I was much more self-conscious. I knew she was looking for any signs of weakness.	I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting embarrassed. If I do get embarrassed or flustered, do I default again to talking about others' contributions?

Upon reading this test interpretation, Jackson's coach realized that Jackson was likely to be very excited about his new successful communication strategies and his success in getting a raise. She certainly didn't want to burst that balloon and made a mental note to celebrate those successes with Jackson. But she also wondered if the results were all as good as Jackson suggested. Why had Jackson shortened his planned list of points? Perhaps he had interpreted his boss correctly – that these points were unnecessary, perhaps even overkill. But how would he know that? Would he be more likely to assume that to be the case, as sensitive as he was to not overplaying his own contributions and value? Could he have asked his boss what he was thinking as a way to determine if he should, in fact, shorten his list of points or not?

Also, his coach thought it too bad that the role play with Larissa had been uncomfortable for Jackson. Was there anything they could have done (and could do in the future) to help him feel more support to use a role play as effectively as possible?

Finally, his coach noticed that Jackson had not yet made an explicit connection between his observations and his Big Assumption. He could imagine this was a simple oversight, and she wrote herself a reminder to leave sufficient time in the session to debrief the implications for his Big Assumption.

After later talking with his coach about these points, Jackson captured the additional insights he now gained from his test.

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I did request that my performance review be rescheduled and completed. We just had it last week. I prepared my own responses to the review questions, again without minimizing or misrepresenting my role in doing so. In the review conversation, I kept the focus on my own contributions – not others'.	It went really well! I was worried that my boss would tell me we were too busy to do the review at this time, but he actually rescheduled it right away and apologized that we hadn't done it sooner. I was nervous before we actually met, but it helped to have some reminders. I think that also helped me make sure I was really prepared with what to say and how to say it.	I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting embarrassed, but I'm still looking for escape hatches that can undermine my progress! I can see that the real danger comes when I make snap judgments (without good data) about how the other person is responding to me. This is what I need to keep working on, how to make sure I don't get hooked by my BAs when I don't even know they're there!

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
	The only time I got nervous was before the conversation started. I remembered to take a deep breath and remind myself that I am not doing anyone favors when I overplay others' contributions. I also imagined that I was not actually talking about myself but about someone else – a colleague I respect, admire, and want to support. I did ask for a raise. I did not actually say what I had planned.	In the conversation itself, my boss was really apologetic again. He basically agreed with everything I said, nodding his head and offering no arguments. I did NOT check in with him to see what his silent nodding meant – was he in total agreement? Was he impatient, thinking I was overstating my case? Was he in basic agreement but curious to hear more (with more elaborate detail than I actually gave)? I shortened some of the points I wanted to make because I convinced myself it was unnecessary to elaborate further. The hardest part of the whole thing was doing the preparation with Larissa. I felt most embarrassed with her – during the role play – because I was much more self-conscious. I knew she was looking for any signs of weakness. I think I should have said something to her about that, so we could have talked about what would help me feel like the role play wasn't an examination.	If I do get embarrassed or flustered, do I default again to talking about others' contributions?

Amanda's Test

In the last chapter, Amanda decided she wanted to run a test of her Big Assumption that she would feel badly if she didn't have a lot of food choices in the moment. Remember, her goal is to lose weight and lower key health warning signs (see p.254 for her 4-Column map).

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	When I go to the holiday party, I will survey the buffet and make a conscious choice about what foods I will allow myself to eat and how much. I will not limit the amount of fresh fruit and vegetables I can have. I will allow myself one beer or glass of wine. I won't stand next to the buffet during the party. I'll get my food and then walk away. I will give a "heads up" about my plans to Josslyn (my ITC partner), who is working on similar issues. She will also be at the party and will observe whether I can effectively change my behavior.	Do I feel in charge, like I make my own choices or that I am forced to live by someone else's choice? How does it feel to make my initial decision after surveying the buffet? How do I feel during the party (especially, regarding decisions about what to eat)? How do I feel afterward? Did I feel like I had some choice? How did I feel about that? Was I realistic in setting goals and limits about what I could and couldn't eat? (Was I still hungry?) Was I overly restrictive in my initial decision? Did I develop counter arguments in my head to overrule my initial decisions? Could I use self talk to talk back to and overrule those counter arguments? Did I enjoy the party? Did I enjoy what I ate and drank? Did I enjoy other parts of the party (met new people I liked, had interesting conversations, etc.)?	Being in charge means following my impulses and indulgences or following my conscious decisions. I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, stressed. I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

Amanda's Test Interpretation

Amanda ran her test and emailed her results to her coach:

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	At the holiday party, I decided I could eat some cold cuts and cheese, one quiche, and an unlimited amount of fresh fruit and vegetables. I drank two glasses of wine because they were small glasses. I didn't stand next to the buffet but did make a few trips to it, to get a refill on the strawberries. I spent most of the party with Josslyn because I knew then that I wouldn't cheat. I also helped her not to cheat I think. The dessert table looked incredible, but we didn't even go over to that part of the room!	I felt very proud of how well I stuck to my plan. And, I noticed that this did allow me to feel that I am in charge of what I eat and when. For the most part, that felt good. I think I was realistic in setting goals and limits about what I could and couldn't eat. I did notice that I wanted to bend the rules a bit—like when I saw that the wine glasses were small ones and not filled too much. I was still hungry. It was hard to not go over to the desserts! I did enjoy the party, but I think maybe I was relying on Josslyn too much. That kept me from meeting new people, and I think I probably thought more about food (what I wanted) because I was with her. It was like we were constantly reminding each other.	I can feel in charge by following my conscious decisions. I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

After reading these results, Amanda's coach made note of the following questions she planned to ask Amanda:

- How did she know she was still hungry afterward? What might have helped her feel less hungry?
- How did she feel about spending the whole night with Josslyn and not meeting any new people?
- How did she feel about what she is learning about her Big Assumption? (E.g., how did it feel to be in charge?)

As Amanda discussed her test results and these questions with her coach, she captured the additional insights that arose for her.

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	At the holiday party, I decided I could eat some cold cuts and cheese, one quiche, and an unlimited amount of fresh fruit and vegetables. I drank two glasses of wine because they were small glasses. I didn't stand next to the buffet but did make a few trips to it, to get a refill on the strawberries. I spent most of the party with Josslyn because I knew then that I wouldn't cheat. I also helped her not to cheat I think. The dessert table looked incredible, but we didn't even go over to that part of the room!	I felt very proud of how well I stuck to my plan. And, I noticed that this did allow me to feel that I am in charge of what I eat and when. For the most part, that felt good. I think I was realistic in setting goals and limits about what I could and couldn't eat. I did notice that I wanted to bend the rules a bit—like when I saw that the wine glasses were small ones and not filled too much. I was still hungry. Or maybe it was just that I wanted to eat – and eat something decadent. It was hard to not go over to the desserts! I did enjoy the party, but I think maybe I was relying on Josslyn too much. That kept me from meeting new people, and I think I probably thought more about food (what I wanted) because I was with her. It was like we were constantly reminding each other.	I can feel in charge by following my conscious decisions. But I think I don't want to be thinking so much about food. That makes me feel hungrier I think, and also a little resentful and stressed. When I'm out for a special occasion, I feel like I should be eating "special" food (E.g., desserts). I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I want to be able to do more of this – not just spend the whole time with Josslyn because I'm so focused on being on a diet. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

Reflecting on her test, Amanda and her coach discussed what a next test might look like. Amanda felt that a next step for her would be to succeed in eating healthily at a large family holiday gathering the following week. She felt that this test was a bit harder because

she wouldn't have Josslyn there to "keep me honest," and she also knew that she had an opportunity then because she couldn't tether herself to Josslyn either. She would try to be more ambitious in enjoying the non-food related aspects of the gathering. She would try to distract herself from thinking about food all the time. And, she would ask her mother to prepare at least one healthy dessert, in an effort to feel like she could eat "special food" on a special occasion.

Amanda recorded her plans and emailed them to her coach.

Amanda's Test #2: Design

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	I'll ask my mom to prepare a healthy dessert for the family holiday party. When I go to the party, I will make a conscious choice about what foods I will allow myself to eat and how much. I will allow myself to eat one piece of healthy dessert. I will not limit the amount of fresh fruit and vegetables I can have. I will allow myself one beer or glass of wine. Before the party, I will think about who I want to talk with – what I want to ask them about, the kinds of conversations I'm hoping we'll have.	Did I develop counter arguments in my head to overrule my initial decisions? Could I use self talk to talk back to and overrule those counter arguments? Did I enjoy the party? Did I enjoy what I ate and drank? Did I enjoy other parts of the party (met new people I liked, had interesting conversations, etc.)?	Being in charge means following my impulses and indulgences or following my conscious decisions. I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, stressed. I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

Amanda's coach read over this test design and immediately saw a key question he wanted to ask:

- Could her mother serve a larger function in this test beyond just making the dessert? Could Amanda let her in on her goals and ask for support? What type of support would be helpful? Could her mother help collect data?

He also wanted to better understand what Amanda meant in the last column (In order to Find Out Whether...) by, "Being in charge means following my impulses and indulgences or following my conscious decisions." It occurred to him that Amanda might be setting herself up by framing this issue too starkly (as an either/or).

Amanda's coach also saw a few places where the test design could get a bit clearer (that Amanda was in fact intending to seek out these conversations at the party, that Amanda also had additional questions she was hoping to answer by running this test).

After she discussed her test design with her coach, Amanda added the following ideas:

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	I'll tell my mom about my eating goals for this party and ask her to help me meet them. I'll ask my mom to prepare a healthy dessert for the family holiday party. When I go to the party, I will make a conscious choice about what foods I will allow myself to eat and how much. I will allow myself to eat one piece of healthy dessert. I will not limit the amount of fresh fruit and vegetables I can have. I will allow myself one beer or glass of wine.	Do I feel in charge, like I make my own choices or that I am forced to live by someone else's choice? How does it feel to make my initial decision about what to eat? How do I feel during the party (esp. regarding decisions about what to eat)? How do I feel afterward? Can I consciously decide to "indulge"? Did I feel like I had some choice? How did I feel about that? Was I realistic in setting goals and limits about what I could and couldn't eat? (Was I still hungry?) Was I overly restrictive in my initial decision?	Being in charge means following my impulses and indulgences or following my conscious decisions. I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, stressed. I can enjoy healthy food. I still feel like I can have something special on a special occasion without completely ruining my diet. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I am not thinking about food the whole time. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

continued

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
	Before the party, I will think about who I want to talk with – what I want to ask them about, the kinds of conversations I’m hoping we’ll have. At the party, I will seek out these people and generate conversations I’m hoping to have.	Was I realistic in setting goals and limits about what I could and couldn’t eat? (Was I still hungry?) Was I overly restrictive in my initial decision? Did I develop counter arguments in my head to overrule my initial decisions? Could I use self talk to talk back to and overrule those counter arguments? Did I enjoy the party? Did I enjoy what I ate and drank? Did I enjoy other parts of the party (met new people I liked, had interesting conversations, etc.)? Did focusing more on people help me block out thoughts about food?	

Amanda’s Test #2: Interpretation

After running her test at the family party, Amanda emailed her interpretation to her coach.

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	I did tell my mom about my eating goals for this party and asked her to help me meet them. And she agreed to prepare a healthy dessert for me. When I got to the party, I made a conscious choice about what foods I could eat and how much. I did allow myself to eat one piece of healthy dessert. I did not limit the amount of fresh fruit and vegetables I could have, although there weren't too many of these. I didn't drink any beer or wine. Before the party, I did think about who I wanted to talk with and was really looking forward to seeing my cousin Cheryl and her new baby. I was also really eager to talk with my brother, whom I haven't seen in a while. I spent most of my time holding Cheryl's baby while he slept. A great way to keep your hands busy so you don't eat. I think that's probably why I didn't have a beer or even wine. I did also talk to my brother and got caught up with him. I felt like I wanted to have an even longer conversation than we did have, so we made plans to talk by phone soon.	I did feel in charge, like I was making my own choices, and I was really pleased by what and how much I ate. Because I knew that I would eat the "healthy" dessert, I was really careful not to eat too much before that. Afterward, I was so pleased that I did so well! The best thing was that I was so distracted by the baby and the conversations I was having that I didn't really think so much about what I was eating (and not eating). I didn't develop any counter arguments or need self talk.	I can feel in charge by following my conscious decisions. When I'm out for a special occasion, I can indulge myself a little bit without going off my diet completely. I can eat less during the meal so that I can have healthy dessert. I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

Amanda's coach immediately saw that the strategy of focusing more on the social components of a celebration could help Amanda enjoy these gatherings and not focus all her attention on the food. He was excited to see that and wanted to make sure they captured all that Amanda could learn from the ways that strategy succeeded. His main concern was that Amanda not focus her attention just on whether or not she succeeded in sticking to her diet but also on what her strategies (which helped her succeed in staying on her diet) could tell her about her Big Assumption. From the notes Amanda sent, it appeared she might be losing that focus.

After talking about her test interpretation with her coach Amanda added her new insights:

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	I did tell my mom about my eating goals for this party and asked her to help me meet them. And she agreed to prepare a healthy dessert for me. When I got to the party, I made a conscious choice about what foods I could eat and how much. I did allow myself to eat one piece of healthy dessert. I did not limit the amount of fresh fruit and vegetables I could have, although there weren't too many of these. Next time, I'll ask mom to have those too – or I'll bring some myself. I didn't drink any beer or wine.	I did feel in charge, like I was making my own choices, and I was really pleased by what and how much I ate. Because I knew that I would eat the "healthy" dessert, I was really careful not to eat too much before that. Afterward, I was so pleased that I did so well! The best thing was that I was so distracted by the baby and the conversations I was having that I didn't really think so much about what I was eating (and not eating). I didn't develop any counter arguments or need self talk. A couple of people volunteered to get me food or something to drink while I had the baby. It was easy to say no thanks.	I can feel in charge by following my conscious decisions. Being in charge can mean not only making decisions about food but about what I choose to focus on, what's most important to me about social occasions. When I'm out for a special occasion, I can indulge myself a little bit without going off my diet completely. I can eat less during the meal so that I can have healthy dessert. I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I can emphasize these more when I look forward to and am at the party. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

Amanda's Chart continued

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
	Before the party, I did think about who I wanted to talk with and was really looking forward to seeing my cousin Cheryl and her new baby. I was also really eager to talk with my brother, whom I haven't seen in a while. I spent most of my time holding Cheryl's baby while he slept. This is a great way to keep your hands busy so you don't eat. I think that's probably why I didn't have a beer or even wine. I did also talk to my brother and got caught up with him. I felt like I wanted to have an even longer conversation than we did have, so we made plans to talk by phone soon.		

Often, clients are inclined to debrief a test quickly, focusing on their own sense of whether it was successful or not. Sometimes their own interpretation of the test is sound, based on clear and conclusive data and connected closely to their Big Assumption. However, unless clients have fairly sophisticated abilities to observe, interpret, and consider other possible interpretations, they will need help from their coach to debrief a test carefully, systematically, and with depth. And even very sophisticated clients can get caught up in the “behavioral results” to the exclusion of the implications for their Big Assumptions.

Debriefing a Test

Even very sophisticated clients can get caught up in the “behavioral results” to the exclusion of the implications for their Big Assumptions.

In particular, debriefs should focus on:

- **Data:** What data did the client collect? What is the quality of that data? Are there additional data that should be collected?
- **Interpretation:** How does the client interpret the data? Are there other plausible interpretations? What would help you gain clarity about which interpretation(s) is/are most plausible?
- **Connection to the Big Assumption:** How does your client's interpretation inform his assessment of his Big Assumption? Does it run completely counter to the Big Assumption? Is the interpretation conclusive about some particular contexts or with some people (but not others)? Are there elements of the Big Assumption that are confirmed? What elements of the Big Assumption remain untested?
- **A next test:** What are the implications of what you have learned (and still need to learn) about the Big Assumption for the next test?

When the Client Didn't Enact the Planned Behavior

Sometimes the client doesn't actually run the test that the two of you had planned. That can happen when the client was not able to enact new behavior. In these cases, identifying how and why this happened will clearly lead you to insights for how to debrief the test (if that is still possible) and how to design the next one. For example:

- She did attempt new behavior, and may even feel like she successfully enacted it, but you feel like her behavior did not cross the threshold you understood she had planned for when you discussed her test design. In these cases, your client may need additional skill development before running a similar test again.
- The client did not attempt the new behavior she had planned because she got cold feet. In these cases, the test may not have been sufficiently safe and modest, and your client recognized this only when trying it in real time.
- The client attempted some of the new behavior but departed from the plan. In such cases, she may still have been able to collect data that can inform the Big Assumption. In debriefing these tests, it is important to be clear about what data are available and what the quality of those data is.

When the Data Aren't High Quality

If your client ran a poorly-planned (or perhaps unplanned) test, it is likely that the data will not be of very high quality. If his test didn't go as planned, that may also be the case. The data you do have may still provide useful information about the accuracy of the Big Assumption and can be debriefed as such. However, you can also help your client to assess the quality of those data and to consider what additional data might have strengthened the test. In some cases, those data might still be available to be collected. For example, there may be someone who witnessed or was involved in the test who can still be enlisted to provide her take on what happened. In other cases, determining what additional data might have been useful to collect can help the client design a better next test that can lead to more powerful learning.

When the Test Results Aren't What Your Client Hoped For

Sometimes the client feels that the test didn't go well. Maybe he wasn't able to enact new behaviors, or the new behaviors were not met with success. Perhaps others didn't welcome the new behaviors, or the new behaviors didn't lead to the hoped-for results. Your client may even have been disappointed to learn that his Big Assumption was in fact accurate in that particular context. All of these scenarios can inform your client about his Big Assumption – under what conditions it is and isn't accurate. And they can also suggest ways that the two of you can review the test design to see if it can be modified for new tests.

The test results may also allow you to identify additional assumptions that may be at play. For example, a client was testing his Big Assumption that he didn't have what it takes (self-discipline, belief, talent) to become a full time free-lance writer. He had designed a test in which he planned to write regularly every day, producing articles and essays to submit for publication. His initial tests had gone well, and he was enthusiastic when he saw that his daily hard work was leading to a good number of articles he could publish. He began to increase his expectations for the number of hours he would work and the number of articles he would complete. And then he hit a road block. One article that he was working on just wasn't progressing. He felt stuck about how to solve the problem. His writing output stalled and his motivation dipped.

Test results may also allow you to identify additional assumptions that may be at play.

In debriefing this test with his coach, he reflected that he seemed to be generating data to confirm that his Big Assumption was true. However, as coach and client reflected on his struggles with this particular article, they began to explore a previously unnamed assumption that the client had been making: that making progress in one's writing is best indicated by the number of hours one puts in and the number of words, pages, or articles that are produced. This assumption does not account for the possibility that the creative nature of this work actually makes it more likely that writing will proceed in fits and starts, and that

when obstacles arise, motivation and output may predictably dip until the writer works through (or around the problem). Challenging this assumption required redefining the client's definition of what a successful writing career looks like from day to day and week to week. He began to see that having what it takes to be a full-time free-lance writer would also mean developing strategies to weather these rough periods, as well as strategies for how to address the times when a writing problem is producing only frustration and self-blame. Surfacing and challenging this related assumption, which was contributing to his immunity, allowed him to design new tests to further his progress.

Sometimes, even when a test goes well and allows the client to redefine her Big Assumptions, there may be unintended (perhaps unpredictable) negative results. For example, one client was running tests on the following Big Assumption: "I assume that if I set higher ambitions for my career, I'll fail to reach these goals. I will find out that I am basically average." After conducting a survey and self-observations, she began to feel more confidence in her ability to take on greater leadership in her organization. The initial tests she ran also ran counter to her Big Assumption – she was actually succeeding in taking on additional responsibilities and fulfilling them successfully. For her final test, she formally requested and received a promotion. Elated to discover that others believed in her potential, and that she also had developed new-found self-belief, the client was saddened to find out that some of her colleagues were critical of the promotion. Not only did they do little to mask their disappointment at the news of her promotion, these co-workers were tense and reserved in their interactions with the client. This unexpected result led the client to puzzle over how to interpret these data: Should she see them as a sign that her leadership skills were lacking? Was their behavior motivated by jealousy? Was their reaction more a matter of how the organization made decisions (and announcements) about promotions? How much should she take to heart her colleagues' reactions?

In a case such as this, where the test results are complex and difficult to interpret, it is important to be very disciplined in:

- Identifying what data are (and what data are not) available, as well as what additional data they might seek to collect.
- Developing a range of possible interpretations for the available data.
- Determining what aspects of the situation connect to the client's original immunity map and can be addressed with future tests; which aspects might connect to other, perhaps related, immunities that can be best addressed by developing a new map; and which aspects are not immunities that might resolve themselves through other means.

In the case of our client whose colleagues responded negatively to her promotion, she generated multiple plausible interpretations for their reactions and sought to collect better data by talking with these colleagues directly. She learned that there were complex and varied reasons that were the basis for these reactions, including some feelings that they

were frustrated that they were not receiving greater recognition and promotion opportunities themselves, and that they were not fully aware of the additional responsibilities she had successfully taken on. Pursuing these data helped the client better understand the culture of her organization (as one that could be “stingy” in providing praise or rewards) and the importance of maintaining open lines of communication with her colleagues. Both insights contributed to a richer understanding of how to overturn her own immune system.

When the Data Are What Your Client Hoped For

Sometimes the client feels that the test went very well and is excited about the results. This may be the result of learning, i.e., his seeing the limitations of his Big Assumption for the first time. However, it may also be an expression of his “event-focused” frame on testing (see Designing Tests chapter for more details). A client operating from this mindset views “success” as either about performance (i.e., he performed the activity specified in the test, such as “I said I would have that conversation and I had it”) or about a good outcome of that activity (“Everything is cleared up between us now!”). While your client may feel relief in either case, he is not learning about his Big Assumption. You will need to help him to understand that a test is “successful” in this particular kind of coaching when he assesses his Big Assumption in light of the results.

Just as a test isn’t completed simply by doing a “successful” action, it is possible to run a valuable and complete test (for this step) without having been “successful” in performing some action. For example, your client may not have been able to hold the difficult conversation, but he gathered data that allowed him to learn something new about what holds him back, and this leads to a further refinement of his Big Assumption.

What Can Be Learned From Tests

We cannot emphasize enough that the purpose of designing and running tests is to see what happens when you intentionally alter your usual behavior to learn about the accuracy of your Big Assumption. That should always remain the focus as well when debriefing a test. However, clients often can gain additional important insights from their tests. Your client may:

- Identify additional assumptions he has been holding that relate to his immunity and have been interfering with progress – add these to the ITC map.
- Develop useful strategies that he can continue to use that allow him to release himself from the grips of his Big Assumption (see the exercise “Identifying Hooks and Releases”).
- Gain more specific information regarding what progress looks like and what needs to happen to make progress (insights which should be recorded in the Continuum

of Progress).

- Improve his ability to observe and interpret, which may help him be quicker to notice and reflect on data that counter his Big Assumption, as well as to refrain from jumping to unsubstantiated conclusions about data.
- Alter his Column 1 goal (and perhaps the rest of the map) so that it is more specific or perhaps even more ambitious based on what he is learning.
- Improve his skill and experience in designing, running and interpreting tests.
- Sometimes the client will be aware of this new learning, but many times, the coach will need to be listening for evidence of these insights and drawing the client's attention to them.

As clients get more proficient at designing tests, observing, and interpreting data, the process of testing often becomes much more spontaneous and fluid. They may spontaneously act in ways their Big Assumptions wouldn't have them act, and their increasing awareness allows them use these situations as further opportunities to learn about their Big Assumptions.

Other clients will still need your explicit help and structured planning and debriefing in order to continue to run effective tests.

Tips and Pitfalls

Coach's Tips for Running and Interpreting Tests

Overall Tips

1. Keep the purpose and intended results in mind throughout the process of debriefing a test (i.e., is to see what happens when you intentionally alter your usual behavior to learn about the accuracy of your Big Assumption). The overall purpose of the test phase is to help your client make progress on her improvement goal.
2. Plan to have enough time to work with your client so that she can design and run at least two tests.
4. Clients will vary in their ability to debrief their own tests. Be clear about your own expectations for what will constitute a robust debrief of any test.

4. Do not forget the “Two Hats” of the coach: being an empathetic listener and probing for the ITC implications of what is said.
5. Be alert to the ways that your meetings with your client provide you with information relevant to your coaching.

1. Develop a shared picture with your client of what the exact data are and multiple plausible interpretations that can be drawn from that data.
2. Connect these interpretations back to the Big Assumption(s) in question to identify how these interpretations in form it (as to its accuracy or innaccuracy).
3. Identify and additional assumptions the client has been holding that relate to her immunity and have been interfering with progress - add these to the ITC map.
4. Be alert to any strategies the client used that allowed her to release herself from the grips of her Big Assumption (to be collected in “Hooks and Releases” exercise).
5. Determine whether you and your client have gained more specific information regarding what progress looks like and what needs to happen to make progress (and record in the Continuum of Progress).

*Tips for Debriefing
a Well-Run Test*

1. If the client didn’t enact the planned behavior, identify how and why this happened. Then determine if/how to debrief the test and how to design the next one.
2. If the data aren’t high quality, assess them together with your client to determine if the data still provide useful information about the accuracy of the Big Assumption; what additional data might have strengthened the test; and whether useful data might still be available to be collected.
3. If the results aren’t what you had hoped, they may still provide important learning about the Big Assumption. They may also shed light onto other aspects of the client’s immunity or additional immunities she may hold.

*Tips for Debriefing
a Problematic Test*



Potential Pitfalls

Coach	Client
Loses sight of the purpose of developing a test (gathering data to learn about the BA). Gets pulled into client's enthusiasm for successfully enacting new behaviors.	Experiences his new behavior as exciting and even powerful, but not because he is overturning his immune system. Behavior changes are likely to be short-lived.
Assesses the quality of the test but does not make that process transparent for client or share criteria with him.	Runs a "correct" test according to coach's standards, but not powerful to himself. Does not improve his ability to design and run tests on his own.
Interprets data loosely, without clear evidence and/or considering possible alternative interpretations.	Draws unsubstantiated conclusions about test and/or feels pressure to accept coach's interpretation.
Neglects to consider test in terms of other potential learning outcomes (e.g., implications for map, CoP, Hooks and Releases).	Learning is less explicit and powerful. Misses seeing the implications of test to inform his immunity and/or the design of future tests.
Gets overly focused on debriefing the test according to the criteria, not carefully listening to (and getting disconnected from) client's own meaning, understanding, and/or experience.	Feels confused, intimidated, and/or infantilized. May feel misunderstood and loose motivation. Loses sight of the overall purpose of testing in focusing on so many details.
Doesn't help client see connections and possibilities for the next test.	Client sees the test as an event rather than one element of larger, ongoing learning process regarding BAs.

Practice Time: Over To You

Now it's your turn to assess the quality of test debriefings, drawing on the points in this chapter. If you were wondering about what happened with Andrew and what he learned about his Big Assumption, you're in luck because we'll be following him here. We will also introduce a new person, Maura. In both cases we will show you the person's initial test design. That will be followed by several tests that the person ran and interpreted, with space after each of these to record your comments (both your assessment of strengths and weaknesses, as well as your thoughts about what you would ask or say to improve any limitations). We hope the iterative nature of the testing Big Assumptions process comes through clearly in these examples.

After you write your comments, you can read our comments on these designs. Our intent in providing a coach's inner dialogue is to show you an example of what a coach with an Immunity-to-Change approach pays attention to and thinks about. Again, we think you will get more out of the practice here if you do not look ahead to our commentary until after you have completed your own. You may find yourself noting different points than we do, and that is fine! Some of these differences may be germane to Immunity-to-Change coaching, and others not so much. In either case, the point is to make sure you can see the core Immunity-to-Change ideas in practice.

Andrew

Andrew's improvement goal is "to identify and build strong partnerships and coalitions to not only move the park's sustainable wildlife program forward, but to mend relationships that have recently broken down between the park and surrounding businesses." When we last peeked in on him, he had designed a test of his Big Assumption about the consequences of taking social risks in his job. Here's the actual test:

Andrew's Test #1 Design

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I take "social risks" it will increase my stress level (anxiety, frustration, and embarrassment) to unbearable levels. If I take "social risks," I will misstep, and people will judge me negatively. If I take social risks I might say the wrong thing or end up looking bad, things might go wrong, people will question my professionalism, and I will feel like a failure.	I will approach a professor at a nearby university about some research he was doing in the park on the preservation of natural habitats. I will express my interest in helping him do more related research projects here that could be used a way to educate the local community about the complexity of the park ecosystem.	Data will be based on what I do and say, as well as how I feel. Will I express clearly how his work is important to my larger project (or will I say or do the wrong thing)? Will my behavior remain professional? How will he respond?	I can increase my skills in communication. I can lessen the risk involved in this work to manageable levels. I can take risks that are at an acceptable level. I can act on the responsibilities of my work rather than procrastinating out of dread.

Andrew's Test Interpretation

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
If I take "social risks" it will increase my stress level (anxiety, frustration, and embarrassment) to unbearable levels. If I take "social risks," I will misstep, and people will judge me negatively. If I take social risks I might say the wrong thing or end up looking bad, things might go wrong, people will question my professionalism, and I will feel like a failure.	I approached a professor at a nearby university about some research he was doing in the park on the preservation of natural habitats. I told him I would like to help him do more related research projects here that could be used as a way to educate the local community about the complexity of the park ecosystem. I planned what to say to him in advance and practiced it.	I spoke from my notes and right away, he responded saying that he has an interested graduate student, who has funding for this type of project. I was nervous at first and glad to have the notes. After he showed interest, he asked a few questions, but they were basically requests for more information, and I could answer easily enough.	I made a new contact and started some communication between this professor and the park service. The timing of this type of research couldn't be better. I have been hesitating to call this professor. I waited and waited. It turns out he has been waiting for me to contact him.

Your Comments

What are your thoughts about Andrew's test interpretation?

Our Comments

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
My Big Assumption Says: If I take “social risks” it will increase my stress level (anxiety, frustration, and embarrassment) to unbearable levels. If I take “social risks,” I will misstep, and people will judge me negatively. If I take social risks I might say the wrong thing or end up looking bad, things might go wrong, people will question my professionalism, and I will feel like a failure. So I changed by behavior in this way: I approached a professor at a nearby university about some research he was doing in the park on the preservation of natural habitats. I told him I would like to help him do more related research projects here that could be used as a way to educate the local community about the complexity of the park ecosystem. I planned what to say to him in advance and practiced it. This is what I observed happening: I spoke from my notes and right away, he responded that saying that he has an interested graduate student who has funding for this type of project. I was nervous at first and glad to have the notes. After he showed interest, he asked a few questions, but they were basically requests for more info, and I could answer easily enough.	It looks like the test followed what we had planned pretty closely. Glad that the notes and preparation served our intent – to decrease his stress level as well as the chances that he will say or do the wrong thing. Makes sense. As we have discussed before, he is pretty comfortable talking about technical information, where his knowledge and expertise are clear.

Our Comments continued

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
And this is what it tells me about my BA: I made a new contact and started some communication between this professor and the park service. The timing of this type of research couldn't be better. I have been hesitating to call this professor. I waited and waited. It turns out he has been waiting for me to contact him.	OK, but those responses aren't necessarily connected to his BA as clearly as I'd like. It seems like maybe he is focused on the positive response from the professor in agreeing to cooperate and focused less on his own ability to communicate effectively and not feel stressed out. I need to emphasize that with him. And, I can also see how this response provides him with data about the costs of his immunity and the potential for progress on it! Makes me wonder about additional, related assumptions he may have been making: I assume that people don't like to be approached or asked questions? I assume that people will form negative and lasting opinions about me based on even one thing that I say? I assume that the safety and comfort of silence is always better than the risks involved in speaking/asking questions? I assume that if people misperceive what I say then I won't have the opportunity to correct or clarify? Was he making these (or others) that now seem inaccurate? I want to check in with him about these. And, what should his next test be? Maybe something a little less choreographed if he feels ready, where he can still plan but can't rely so much on his notes? I'll see what he feels ready for.

Andrew's Test #2 Design

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I take “social risks” it will increase my stress level (anxiety, frustration, and embarrassment) to unbearable levels. If I take “social risks,” I will misstep, and people will judge me negatively. If I take social risks I might say the wrong thing or end up looking bad, things might go wrong, people will question my professionalism, and I will feel like a failure.	Next week I will be going to a community event that tends to draw local small business leaders. It is a big deal for them – lots of networking and informal politic-ing, the kind that always makes me uncomfortable. I will have the opportunity to introduce myself and share some of my ideas surrounding the park’s sustainable wildlife program. A good test may be to simply introduce myself and to strike up conversations with these individuals. I will also look for ways to talk with them about our program goals.	I think it is important for me to recognize the feelings I have prior, during, and after these “encounters.” I will monitor if I pass up opportunities and why. From past experiences like this I know that I tend to talk myself out of these types of situations. I play out the encounter in my mind and never follow through. It will also be good to monitor the results of these encounters – what was the outcome, how did the “encounter” go, what I learned from the experience. Is there anyone to whom you’d like to give a “heads-up” or ask to serve as an observer who can give you feedback after the fact? No	I honestly think this will test all three of my assumptions since they all relate to taking “social risks.” For me, my biggest “social risk” is introducing myself and striking up conversations in these professional type settings. These assumptions will be tested because I will have to face my fears and deal with the anxiety surrounding this issue. Also, if there is a positive outcome that will cast doubt on my big assumption.

CRITERIA	YES	NOT SURE
Is it safe? (If the worst case were to happen, you could live with the results.)	✓	
Is the data relevant to your Big Assumption?	✓	
Does it have face validity? (The test actually tests your Big Assumption.)	✓	
Are the data sources valid? (No one is either out to get you or wants to protect or save you.)	✓	
Might it “re-true” your Big Assumption? (Is it designed so that it surely will lead to bad consequences, just as your BA tells you? Are you setting yourself up to fail? Is there any data you could collect that could disconfirm your BA?)	NO	
Is it actionable in the near-term? (E.g., the people or situation you need in order to enact the test are available, you are reasonably certain you know how to do what you plan, and you can run the test within the next week or so.)	✓	

Your Comments

What do you think about Andrew’s 2nd test design?

Our Comments

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
My Big Assumption Says: If I take “social risks” it will increase my stress level (anxiety, frustration, and embarrassment) to unbearable levels. If I take “social risks,” I will misstep, and people will judge me negatively. If I take social risks I might say the wrong thing or end up looking bad, things might go wrong, people will question my professionalism, and I will feel like a failure. So I will change my behavior in this way: Next week I will be going to a community event that tends to draw local small business leaders. It is a big deal for them – lots of networking and informal politic-ing, the kind that always makes me uncomfortable. I will have the opportunity to introduce myself and share some of my ideas surrounding the park’s sustainable wildlife program. A good test may be to simply introduce myself and to strike up conversations with these individuals. I will also look for ways to talk with them about our program goals.	As I read about his proposed behavior changes, this test definitely seems to have a higher risk level than the previous one. For one thing, the interactions can cover a much longer time period (the whole day), which will require more stress management and/or number of potential interactions. It also seems like a much more complex set of social interactions. I want to check with him to see if he has been to something like this before, knows what to expect (I’m not sure I do), and can imagine how these conversations might actually take place. I might start off by asking him an open-ended question about how things might go awry and how he could plan for what to do. If he doesn’t raise these points, I will and see what he thinks. Maybe also create some release valves for him if he anticipates getting tired or overwhelmed. There seem to be two distinct goals here: 1. Just to meet and chat with attendees, to form relationships that may lay the ground for future interactions. 2. To discuss the program Andrew is running. Will this be appropriate? How will he introduce it? Better to see if it comes up naturally in the conversation (or if he can bring it up very casually)? Here seems to be a place where things could get awkward if he forces the issue and/or sets too ambitious goals for these conversations. We need to talk this through. I think maybe he shouldn’t include this goal as part of this test.

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
And collect the following data: I think it is important for me to recognize the feelings I have prior, during, and after these “encounters”. I will monitor if I pass up opportunities and why. From past experiences like this I know that I tend to talk myself out of these types of situations. In my mind I play out the encounter in my mind and never follow through. It will also be good to monitor the results of these encounters – what was the outcome, how did the “encounter” go, what I learned from the experience.	Good that he is tuning into his own feelings and internal dialogue. Does he mean engaging in chitchat or bringing up his project? We definitely can work on how to introduce himself and just socialize, if that’s what he means. What kind of preparation might we need to do that will help him assess whether and how to bring up this project? What outcome does he expect or hope for? How will he collect data on what he says and does? I notice he didn’t answer the question about someone who could help him collect data. I want to encourage that, if possible. It will be hard for him to remember everything that happened (although he is pretty good at separating what happened from his interpretation). I also think it will be hard for him to assess his own skill level in communicating.

Andrew’s Test #2 Interpretation

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
If I take “social risks” it will increase my stress level (anxiety, frustration, and embarrassment) to unbearable levels. If I take “social risks,” I will misstep, and people will judge me negatively.	I approached a professor I had many opportunities to run my test. Part 1: During the morning sessions, many of the business leaders didn’t show up. But when I saw how small the group was, I felt unprepared so I got a little anxious. By mid-morning, most people were there. I said a few inconsequential remarks (“Hey,” “How’s it going”) to people seated near me.	Part 1: I feel it was a success just going up to them and introducing myself. I noticed that my mind would tell me “just forget about it,” but when I would actually follow through I felt relieved and more confident.	Looking at the entire meeting it was a successful bunch of tests. I realize that my anxiety is mostly related to the initial introduction. I also realize that when I am in a conversation (or in a group of people having a conversation) I get uncomfortable when questions are not posed towards me. That feeling immediately disappears if a question is directed to me or the topic is something I can give input.

Andrew's Test #2 Interpretation continued

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
If I take social risks I might say the wrong thing or end up looking bad, things might go wrong, people will question my professionalism, and I will feel like a failure.	Part 2: The big test for me was to introduce myself and some of my ideas to these important business leaders. This opportunity presented itself during the lunch break. I was outside on my way back into the meeting center. The group was standing outside and they kind of caught me off guard. One member asked me where I got my (local sports team) T-shirt. I explained who I was and got introduced to the group. Part 3: During lunch, I purposely sat next to a few members of the group. We talked about weather, news, etc. They also talked about topics they shared information on (local gossip, I guess). I listened. Part 4: At the end of the day, as people were leaving, I had a short conversation with one of the individual leaders. And I handed out a bunch of my cards and said I would be interested in giving presentations or answering any questions they have about our program.	Part 2: The conversation was a little uncomfortable because I didn't have anything to say. I asked them where they were the day before and this extended the conversation. I felt awkward, but I also felt good because the initial test of introductions was done. Part 3: I didn't bring up anything about the program yet; it was good just being part of some of their conversations. Part 4: I hadn't planned to hand out cards and let people know of my interests. But when I got them out to give one to the first guy I talked to, I kept them in my hand, and then it was easy just to keep giving them out. I did start to feel a little strange about that though – like I was trying to drum up business or something.	It reminds me of when I was in high school or at a social event where groups of people were talking and how awkward the silence was for me. If I am part of the conversation I feel comfortable, if I am just listening (just part of the group), I get uncomfortable and try to find reasons to leave. This is a realization (maybe another BA or related assumption) that resulted from running these tests. I tend to avoid making initial introductions because I'm avoiding those future moments of "awkward silence!" These tests in some ways complicated my BA. I realize that there are layers upon layers of issues that are all related. Just becoming more aware of this internal dialog and feelings I have is helping me to be more outgoing and more social. I feel good about my accomplishments for the week. I have set up the opportunity to really move forward and approach some of the leaders I met for their support when it comes to the work I want to do here at the park. I notice a difference with these feeling of anxiety. It is getting easier to overcome my fears related to taking "social risks." I don't judge myself as hard as I used to.

Your Comments

What do you think about Andrew's interpretation of the results of test #2?

Our Comments

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
My Big Assumption Says: If I take “social risks” it will increase my stress level (anxiety, frustration, and embarrassment) to unbearable levels. If I take “social risks,” I will misstep, and people will judge me negatively. If I take social risks I might say the wrong thing or end up looking bad, things might go wrong, people will question my professionalism, and I will feel like a failure.	

Our Comments continued

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
So I changed my behavior in this way: I had many opportunities to run my test. Part 1: During the morning sessions, many of the business leaders didn't show up. But when I saw how small the group was, I felt unprepared so I got a little anxiety. By mid-morning, most people were there. I said a few inconsequential remarks ("Hey," "How's it going") to people seated near me. Part 2: The big test for me was to introduce myself and some of my ideas to these important business leaders. This opportunity presented itself during the lunch break. I was outside on my way back into the meeting center. The group was standing outside and they kind of caught me off guard. One member asked me where I got my (local sports team) T-shirt. I explained who I was and got introduced to the group. Part 3: During lunch, I purposely sat next to a few members of the group. We talked about weather, news, etc. They also talked about topics they shared information on (local gossip, I guess). I listened. Part 4: At the end of the day, as people were leaving, I had a short conversation with one of the individual leaders. And I handed out a bunch of my cards and said I would be interested in giving presentations or answering any questions they have about our program. This is what I observed happening: Part 1: I feel it was a success just going up to them and introducing myself. I noticed that my mind would tell me "just forget about it", but when I would actually follow through I felt relieved and more confident.	His increased anxiety suggests that when things don't go exactly as planned or are by nature unpredictable he is still likely to feel stress. That completely makes sense. It sounds like the bulk of Andrew's interactions were purely social (chatting, getting to know each other). That reflects our agreement about where he should put the emphasis for this test. I need to find out more data from him about what he said and did. Were the conversations easy to have? Were there parts when he didn't know what to say or do? Etc. How did he feel about listening? (Look for any BAs around that.) I need more data about these conversations to know how to interpret what happened in light of his BAs. Did he use any of the "ice breaker" questions or topics of conversation we had discussed? Did he find other ways to participate? How comfortable was he as the day went on?

Our Comments continued

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
This is what I observed happening continued: Part 2: The conversation was a little uncomfortable because I didn't have anything to say. I asked them where they were the day before and this extended the conversation. I felt awkward, but I also felt good because the initial test of introductions was done. Part 3: I didn't bring up anything about the program yet; it was good just being part of some of their conversations. Part 4: I hadn't planned to hand out cards and let people know of my interests. But when I got them out to give one to the first guy I talked to, I kept them in my hand, and then it was easy just to keep giving them out. I did start to feel a little strange about that though – like I was trying to drum up business or something. And this is what it tells me about my Big Assumption: Looking at the entire meeting it was a successful bunch of tests. I realize that my anxiety is mostly related to the initial introduction. I also realize that when I am in a conversation or in a group of people having a conversation I get uncomfortable when questions are not posed towards me. That feeling immediately disappears if a question is directed to me or the topic is something I can give input. I relate the feelings of awkward silence to when I was in high school or at a social event where groups of people are talking. If I am part of the conversation I feel comfortable, if I am just listening (just part of the group), I get uncomfortable and try to find reasons to leave. This is a realization (maybe another big assumption or related assumption) that resulted from running these tests. I tend to avoid making initial introductions because I subconsciously am avoiding those future moments of “awkward silence”.	Using self-talk as a strategy to get past negative voice in his head. Let's explore this (add to the CoP? Remember when we get to consolidating as a “release” mechanism he has learned). That's good to hear that he is paying attention to how he felt in the situation. Asking questions as a good way to contribute to the conversation without having to know something (offer answer, expertise). And here's more data about how he felt. That's great he was able to notice that he felt good, as well as uncomfortable. I want to hear more about handing out the cards at the end – how it felt, whether it was appropriate for that setting, etc. I need to ask him for more data. In particular, I want him to check in with Jim Daly, the guy he thought might be a good data collector. Was he at the meeting? What did he observe? Again, these data suggest ways that his BAs can be disconfirmed in the right circumstances (some skill development, preparation, self-talk, etc.). It seems to me, from what he has written here, Andrew was able to follow through with his new and more desired behavior of introducing himself, making conversation, putting himself in the position to have conversation (by being in the same meeting, sitting next to people) and talking for a bit (and inviting others to talk more with him). Sometimes the opportunities for these conversations came up in surprising ways – he may have felt unprepared or caught off guard. If so, how did he feel after initially feeling unprepared? How did he respond to these things? Are there ways he would have preferred to respond?

Our Comments continued

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
And this is what it tells me about my Big Assumption continued: These tests in some ways complicated my BA. I realize that there are layers upon layers of issues that are all related. Just becoming more aware of this internal dialog and feelings I have is helping me to be more outgoing and more social. I feel good about my accomplishments for the week. I have set up the opportunity to really move forward and approach some of the leaders I met for their support when it comes to the work I want to do here at the park. I notice a difference with these feeling of anxiety. It is getting easier to overcome my fears related to taking “social risks”. I don’t judge myself as hard as I used to.	Does he feel that he must be talking in order to be establishing relationships? Or, is he worried that he is expected to say something? Good to hear that he is feeling like it’s getting easier to get past his fears and that he is not judging himself as harshly as he used to. Is that because he can see progress and can see that he is working hard? And/or, is he less likely to feel like these issues have the same “Big Time Bad” quality to them as they used to? Or, something else? What should be the next test – to get new insight, move further along, find new things to test, and generate new ideas and assumptions.

Andrew’s Test #3 Design

Andrew then ran a spontaneous test. He hadn’t discussed this with his coach beforehand but in the midst of the meeting, he realized that he couldn’t keep silent in the meeting with local farmers and businessmen.

Here is his description of what happened:

The area has been experiencing mild droughts in recent years. I attended a meeting of local farmers and some businessmen to talk about potential ways to address the implications of these droughts. I waited to the very end of the meeting to address some things that I felt were very important. I made some suggestions related to fire suppression tactics, irrigation, and pest control. My intentions were to raise some questions and bring some awareness to these topics.

Andrew's Test #3 Interpretation

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
If I take "social risks" it will increase my stress level (anxiety, frustration, and embarrassment) to unbearable levels. If I take "social risks," I will misstep, and people will judge me negatively. If I take social risks I might say the wrong thing or end up looking bad, things might go wrong, people will question my professionalism, and I will feel like a failure.	I made some suggestions related to fire suppression tactics, irrigation, and pest control. My intentions were to raise some questions and bring some awareness to these topics.	A few people got defensive and I know many others disagree with my opinions.	I am ok with this because I know that these issues need to be addressed. I know I am right about the safety concerns I addressed. I will not compromise my safety or the safety of others. I realize that it doesn't matter what people think of me professionally when I am expressing my opinions and questions. As long as I am confident and truthful about what I say.

Your Comments

What do you think about Andrew's interpretation of the results of test #3?

Our Comments

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
My Big Assumption Says: If I take “social risks” it will increase my stress level (anxiety, frustration, and embarrassment) to unbearable levels. If I take “social risks,” I will misstep, and people will judge me negatively. If I take social risks I might say the wrong thing or end up looking bad, things might go wrong, people will question my professionalism, and I will feel like a failure. And so I changed my behavior in this way: I made some suggestions related to fire suppression tactics, irrigation, and pest control. My intentions where to raise some questions and bring some awareness to these topics. And this is what I observed happening: A few people got defensive and I know many others disagree with my opinions. This is what it tells me about the Big Assumption: I am ok with this because I know that these issues need to be addressed. I know I am right about the safety concerns I addressed. I will not compromise my safety or the safety of others. I realize that it doesn’t matter what people think of me professionally when I am expressing my opinions and questions. As long as I am confident and truthful about what I say.	I need lots more data: What did he say? How did he say it (tone of voice etc)? Did others respond at the moment? Later? Anyone else who could offer their sense of the data? Again, I need more data! How does he know they were defensive? What did they do or say exactly? How does he know others disagree with his opinions? This is quite interesting. Part of me feels excited that he has a perspective he can express clearly and directly. The issue of it being in the area of his expertise makes sense with his comments so far – in that realm he feels most comfortable. It could also be a big breakthrough for him since here, for the first time, he seems to uncouple his idea of success from other people’s reactions. The big question is how it relates to his column 1 goal? Did he deliver his position in a way that could/did alienate people and burn bridges, actually undermining his column 1 goal? If so, is he ok with that? If he is ok, what’s the difference for him in this situation compared to the ones where he’s not? Are there ways he could have been equally clear but less likely to push people away? (And, how will we know if he did push them away anyway – and if so, to what extent?) We need to brainstorm about how to get better data here.

Maura

Maura is the Director of Curriculum and Instruction in a mid-size school district. As her district has focused increasingly on improving instruction, Maura's role has shifted as well – from more administrative matters to working directly with the principals (as a group as well as individually) to raise their abilities to be instructional leaders in their schools. While she is committed to making this shift in her role, she has found that she often reverts back to focusing on her old duties.

Maura's Map

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
I am committed to spending the majority of my time in the schools without having to work absurdly long hours (bringing a lot of work home, losing my personal life).	I say "yes" to things I like to do that aren't in the sweet spot of this work. I haven't been taking charge and telling the principals when I'll be there – making a schedule for when I'll be in the schools and sending it to the principals. I am easily distracted. I get caught up in things in my office (like responding to email) that can take up a lot of time. When the principal can't accompany me on the focus walks, I have just cancelled them instead of doing them by myself.	Fears – things will fall by the wayside; small gains made in other projects will be lost; others won't do a good job; people will get mad at me; people will question my abilities. I am committed to being seen as someone who can handle everything well. I am committed to pushing myself as hard as I can, until I get sick.	If I was not accepted, then people wouldn't like me and I wouldn't have value. I assume I couldn't feel secure in my relationship during conflict. I assume that to disagree is to be cold and uncaring (or seen that way). I assume that the relationship will not remain if I disagree.

Although Maura had not yet reached the testing phase in her ITC work, she did run a spontaneous test. At a meeting she was facilitating with all the principals, she decided to ask them if they felt she was pushing them enough (or too much or too little), and in the right ways.

Maura's Test #1 Interpretation

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that if my relationship with the Principals doesn't progress (or even deteriorates) because I push too hard or not hard enough, then I won't be able to do my job.	I asked them.	They said they want me to keep pushing them.	I can collect data about whether I am pushing the right amount. But my data wasn't great because some people didn't say anything. Also, I don't trust Ella to speak up and disagree with the others.

Your Comments

What do you think about Maura's interpretation of her test data?

Our Comments

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
My Big Assumption Says: I assume that if my relationship with the Principals doesn't progress (or even deteriorates) because I push too hard or not hard enough, then I won't be able to do my job. And so I changed my behavior in this way: I asked them. And this is what I observed happening: They said they want me to keep pushing them. This is what it tells me about the Big Assumption: I can collect data about whether I am pushing the right amount. But my data wasn't great because some people didn't say anything. Also, I don't trust Ella to speak up and disagree with the others.	Maura is the type of client who doesn't write down all that she is thinking. I find that what she learns is usually quite aligned with ITC criteria, but making this learning explicit (by articulating it and pushing it further) happens in our conversation (not in what she writes). So, when we meet, I'll need to ask her lots of questions to find out what she actually said to the principals and how they responded. OK, so she was testing a specific part of her BA – whether she was in fact pushing too hard or not. (This doesn't tell us what would happen if she did push too hard. It does give us a sense, though, of one way she might gauge that.) I also wonder if she has been assuming something like, "I assume that I can't talk openly with the principals about the nature/terms of our relationship without alienating them." Need to check in with her about this. It sounds like people basically thought she wasn't pushing too hard (not so clear from what she says), but that not everyone spoke. So, she is aware that this test didn't necessarily produce data that are as reliable as they could be. Again, I'm curious to know more about who said what, and who didn't speak, and what Ella was doing, etc. We should talk about possible ways to generate better data (for this test that she already ran and for future tests). I wonder if one way to get better data (and it would also be a next test) would be to talk to Ella directly about this issue?

Maura's Test #2 Design

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that if I'm not seen as someone who can handle everything well, then people will think less of me, won't value me. I assume that if I don't push myself so hard (to the point of getting sick), then I won't be seen as someone who can handle everything well, and then people will think less of me, won't value me. I assume that the best way for me to help create change is by getting to the place where the Principals and I have an honest relationship – they can push back on me, and I can push back on them. And I assume that if my relationship with the Principals doesn't progress (or even deteriorates) because I push too hard or not hard enough, then I won't be able to do my job.	To have a conversation with Ella about how I can be most helpful to her. I will mention that she seems to have a lot on her plate and that I might be able to help her in ways that fit with my current job description (that gives me an out if she suggests ways I can help that wouldn't really use my time well). I need to be clear with her that I am aware that we have very different styles and that I don't want to push her too hard (and also not hard enough). If she asks me for my ideas about how I could help, I will suggest: Helping her plan and practice difficult conversations. Helping her think through how she might handle other difficult situations that arise. I probably won't suggest I could help her improve her relationships with her teachers, but I might ask her how those relationships are going. Finally, we will discuss what "success" would look like. How will we know if I am helping her in the most effective ways?	My own feelings, thoughts, interpretations of the conversation before, during and after. I'll need to acknowledge my own discomfort, know that it might feel awkward. Will I feel like I am pushing too hard or not hard enough? What Ella says and does. What we both say and do after the conversation. (E.g., Do things change? Does she follow through?) Is there anyone to whom you'd like to give a "heads-up" or ask to serve as an observer who can give you feedback after the fact? No, I think I need to do this one-on-one.	The conversation might help us both get clearer about how we can work most effectively together. We can come to a shared sense of how much I should push (and how/when I shouldn't).

Maura's Test #2 Design continued

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
	How will we check in with each other to see what's going well, what needs work, how each other is feeling, etc? To increase the chances that the conversation will go well, I will be planning out the conversation in detail ahead of time and allowing myself ways to buy time to think if I begin to feel too awkward or uncomfortable during the conversation (e.g., "why don't we both think about this some more and find another time to discuss it further...?")		

Review your test on these criteria:

CRITERIA	YES	NOT SURE
Is it safe? (If the worst case were to happen, you could live with the results.)	I think so	
Is the data relevant to your Big Assumption?	✓	
Does it have face validity? (The test actually tests your Big Assumption.)	✓	
Are the data sources valid? (No one is either out to get you or wants to protect or save you.)	I don't think she's out to get me!	
Might it "re-true" your Big Assumption? (Is it designed so that it surely will lead to bad consequences, just as your BA tells you? Are you setting yourself up to fail? Is there any data you could collect that could disconfirm your BA?)	NO	
Is it actionable in the near-term? (E.g., the people or situation you need in order to enact the test are available, you are reasonably certain you know how to do what you plan, and you can run the test within the next week or so.)	If I don't put it off! Hee hee.	

Your Comments

What do you think about Maura's next test design?

Our Comments

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
My Big Assumption Says: I assume that if I'm not seen as someone who can handle everything well, then people will think less of me, won't value me. I assume that if I don't push myself so hard (to the point of getting sick), then I won't be seen as someone who can handle everything well, and then people will think less of me, won't value me. I assume that the best way for me to help create change is by getting to the place where the Principals and I have an honest relationship – they can push back on me, and I can push back on them. And I assume that if my relationship with the Principals doesn't progress (or even deteriorates) because I push too hard or not hard enough, then I won't be able to do my job.	These are her BAs, but this isn't a test of all of them. (I thought we talked about this.) As I see it, she is really testing a version of her 3rd assumption – "I assume that I can't talk openly with the principals about the nature/terms of our relationship without alienating them." That's one I raised with her in our last session, but the fact that she isn't listing it here makes me wonder if she really owns it. I'll check that out when we debrief.

Our Comments continued

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
So I will change my behavior in this way: To have a conversation with Ella about how I can be most helpful to her. I will mention that she seems to have a lot on her plate and that I might be able to help her in ways that fit with my current job description (that gives me an out if she suggests ways I can help that wouldn't really use my time well). I need to be clear with her that I am aware that we have very different styles and that I don't want to push her too hard (and also not hard enough). If she asks me for my ideas about how I could help... (see page above). To increase the chances that the conversation will go well, I will be planning out the conversation in detail ahead of time and allowing myself ways to buy time to think if I begin to feel too awkward or uncomfortable during the conversation (E.g., "Why don't we both think about this some more and find another time to discuss it further...?"). And collect the following data: My own feelings, thoughts, interpretations of the conversation before, during and after. I'll need to acknowledge my own discomfort, know that it might feel awkward. Will I feel like I am pushing too hard or not hard enough? What Ella says and does. What we both say and do after the conversation. (E.g., Do things change? Does she follow through?)	This test feels like it has higher stakes for Maura than the last one did. I'm glad that we planned this test together, with Maura taking notes (with my prompting throughout) about what she would do. While she was feeling a little pessimistic when we began to talk about this test, she let me know that by the end of our planning, she was more excited and felt like she had a good chance of opening up an honest conversation with Ella – or at least presenting a pretty good invitation to one.

Our Comments continued

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
In order to find out whether: The conversation might help us both get clearer about how we can work most effectively together. We can come to a shared sense of how much I should push (and how/when I shouldn't).	Good that she is focusing on her own sense of how successful she has been at presenting this invitation in terms of her own feelings. She doesn't mention here the important data of what she actually says and does (to see how successful she is in wording this carefully, not taking charge of the conversation). We will need that data! Even if Ella doesn't open up, Maura could still have presented a very gracious invitation (or she could kind of steamroll). That's really the part that is most in her control that we need to focus on. Actually, the first thing we want to find out is whether Maura can skillfully invite Ella into this conversation. Then we can look at Ella's response. Ah, I see here how she is hoping this will connect to her BA about pushing. Hopefully we will learn about that too!

Maura's Test #2 Interpretation

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that if my relationship with the Principals doesn't progress (or even deteriorates) because I push too hard or not hard enough, then I won't be able to do my job.	I had a couple of opportunities to talk with Ella. The first was a conversation about how I could be of most help to her. She said I could help her most in planning and having successful difficult conversations with teachers who need to be confronted.	While I had anticipated that this might be an uncomfortable conversation for me, I felt fine. Ella was open to and interested in my ideas.	I am interested in supporting Ella to take more risks with the other principals and to create more trust among them.

Maura's Test #2 Interpretation continued

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that I can't talk openly with the principals about the nature/terms of our relationship without alienating them.	The second conversation was when she was meeting with Steven about the teacher leader position, and Steven was expressing his concern about whether or not XX should be a teacher leader. When he asked about the criteria for who should be a teacher leader, Ella turned to ME for the answer! I suggested that this would be a great question for all the principals to discuss and suggested she email them. I thought that might help her build relationships with the other principals. She has not actually done that though. However, since then, XX did drop out of the teacher leader group. He sent an email saying he shouldn't be included. I also need to tell you about my visit to the high school and my conversation with Doreen – good stuff!	While I had anticipated that this might be an uncomfortable conversation for me, I felt fine. Ella was open to and interested in my ideas.	In the last principal meeting, Ella was interrupted, and she mentioned to everyone, "You're not listening to me." After the meeting, I said to her, "You don't like being interrupted, do you? That's the first time you told them that. That was great!" I encouraged her to keep letting them know when they do that – I want to keep paying attention to that issue so that I can encourage her to keep trying on these new behaviors.

Maura's Additional Reflections

I am still aware of feeling a need to be liked and validated by others. But, I realize that I might need to look to other places and not to the principals for that validation. And, I can't let this part of me stop me from saying what I think or otherwise causing some tension in my relationships.

I was thinking about how I'll know if things are getting better with Ella:

- In our conversations together, she doesn't hedge as much but talks more directly (getting less defensive, not giving excuses). She is also able to contribute more of herself to these conversations, not just accepting what I say but also asking questions or challenging me. Then I won't be wondering what she is thinking so much and worrying that she doesn't like me.

I have gotten increasingly better at saying no to things that distract from my time in schools and with the principals, working to improve instruction. Yay! But, I am still overworked. Even when I focus just on my highest priorities, there is still tons to be done! I am trying to take better care of myself – using less Xanax – and trying to do fun stuff outside of work.

Your Comments

What do you think about Maura's interpretation of her test data?

Our Comments

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
My Big Assumption Says: I'll assume that if my relationship with the Principals doesn't progress (or even deteriorates) because I push too hard or not hard enough, then I won't be able to do my job. I assume that I can't talk openly with the principals about the nature/terms of our relationship without alienating them. So in order to test it, I changed my behavior in these ways: I had a couple of opportunities to talk with Ella. The first was a conversation about how I could be of most help to her. She said I could help her most in planning and having successful difficult conversation with teachers who need to be confronted. The second conversation was when she was meeting with Steven about the teacher leader position, and Steven was expressing his concern about whether or not XX should be a teacher leader. When he asked about the criteria for who should be a teacher leader, Ella turned to ME for the answer! I suggested that this would be a great question for all the principals to discuss and suggested she email them. I thought that might help her build relationships with the other principals. She has not actually done that though. However, since then, XX did drop out of the teacher leader group. She sent an email saying she shouldn't be included. I also need to tell you about my visit to the high school and my conversation with Doreen – good stuff!	It seems Maura has shifted the focus away from the original conversation she planned with Ella, perhaps because so many other things have started happening. She moved quickly to a new issue of how to help Ella form closer bonds with the other principals. She also mentions an important visit to the high school. And then her additional reflections focus mostly on other aspects of her immunity. These are also important issues, but I want to make sure we debrief each one carefully. Actually, realistically, we won't be able to debrief each one. So, I think it makes sense to focus on the test she planned and ran, and if there is time, maybe get to the changes (or lack thereof) she is seeing with regard to other aspects of her immunities. I'm not sure if helping Ella connect with the other principals keeps us in the sweet spot of her assumptions so much (although it seems quite pertinent to her column 1 goal). I want to talk with Maura about why I think we should focus our debrief on the test she planned.

Our Comments continued

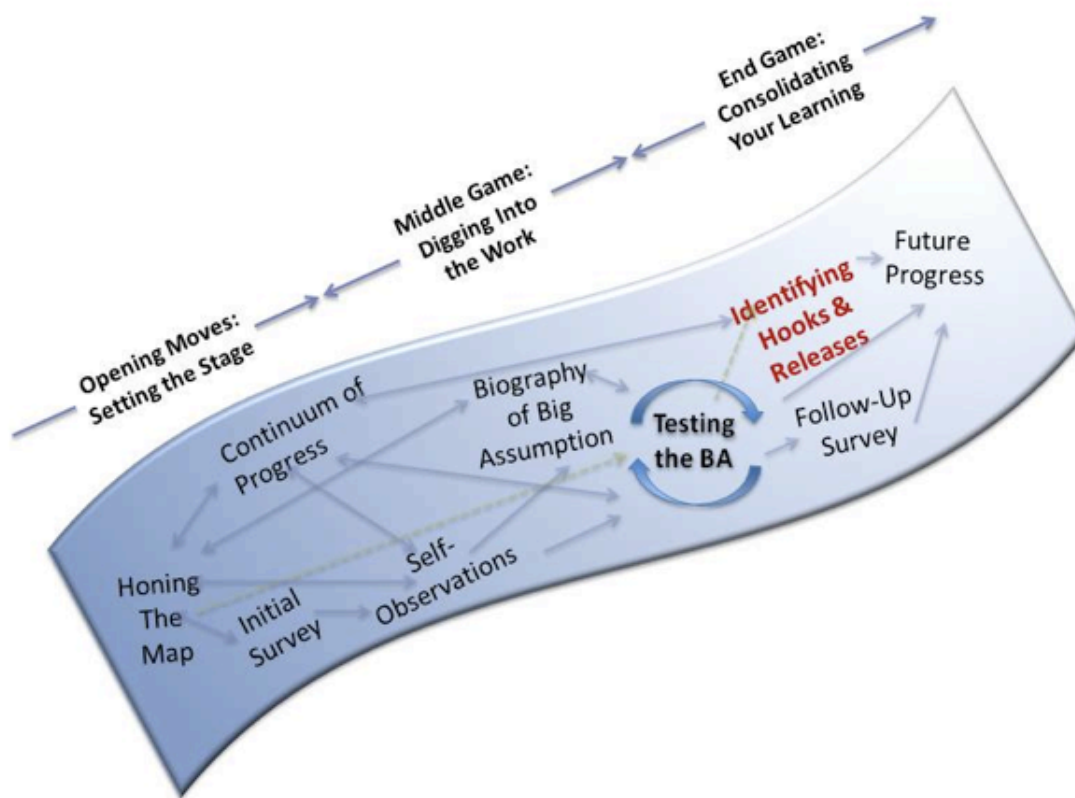
What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
And this is what I observed happening: While I had anticipated that this might be an uncomfortable conversation for me, I felt fine. Ella was open to and interested in my ideas. This is what it tells me about the Big Assumption: I am interested in supporting Ella to take more risks with the other principals and to create more trust among them. In the last LPC meeting, Ella was interrupted, and she mentioned to everyone, “You’re not listening to me.” After the meeting, I said to her, “You don’t like being interrupted, do you? That’s the first time you told them that. That was great!” I encouraged her to keep letting them know when they do that – I want to keep paying attention to that issue so that I can encourage her to keep trying on these new behaviors.	I need a lot more data re: what was said by each person. It is good to know that Maura felt fine, but how does she know that Ella was open to and interested in her ideas? What are the data that tells her that? Does she have good data? And what data will she be using to determine if Ella is “hedging” in their future conversations? How does this connect to her BA? I don’t see it. Unless it has to do with pushing Ella? Or, it could be another instance of Maura getting distracted by so many things going on. As we get clearer about what data we have (and don’t have) to determine how the conversation went, I want to ask her to connect back to the BAs we identified as the focus for this test. It seems like the test may have helped her overturn her assumption that “I can’t talk openly with the principals about the nature/terms of our relationship without alienating them.” But, what will be most important is not the “test result” <i>I</i> can derive from what she did, but the result <i>she</i> can derive – Is she even aware still of “running a test”? How do I raise all this while not dampening her enthusiasm for the progress she sees/feels she is making both at the behavioral and mindset levels?

Chapter 8

Identifying Hooks and Releases

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Context for this Exercise

You may already have been wondering how you will know when your work with your client is complete. Surely, the answer to that cannot be “when my client finishes all the exercises”! The Hooks and Releases exercise helps both you and your client derive a clear answer to the question.

The Hooks and Releases exercise is part of the “End Game: Consolidating Your Learning” and typically is part of the curriculum in the fourth or fifth month of ITC coaching. By the time your client has gotten to this point in the overturning-immunities process, we hope and expect that through “Digging into the Work” she has made progress in achieving her improvement goal. If your client did an initial survey, she may want to do a second survey at this time to get feedback confirming that growth; this is optional. She may also be seeing changes in other areas that she did not expect to see, as very often, altering Big Assumptions has benefits that go beyond the Column 1 commitment and touch on every part of our lives. At this point, you want to be helping your client to think about how to take stock of the progress she has already made and to consider how to augment and sustain this progress.

Overview

There are two parts to this exercise. In the first, a client is asked to assess the progress he has made so far, both in terms of changes to his behavior and his Column 1 goal, and also with regard to the state of his immune system. How far has he come toward completely releasing himself from the ways that his Big Assumptions is not valid? The client uses the developmental continuum (“consciously immune” to “consciously released” to “unconsciously released”), along with its accompanying definitions, to help make this self-assessment. (N.B.: This is the same developmental progression that we print on the back side of a 4-Column map worksheet.)

The second part of this exercise not only provides another form of stock-taking, it also asks clients to identify the types of tools he can use to continue to make and sustain progress toward becoming fully released from his immunities. He will consider the current status of his Big Assumptions, assess the risk factors in getting pulled back into it, and devise plans for how to guard against erosion.

A key outcome of the exercise is that a client has an informed assessment of his progress and capacity to continue progressing on his own. Most clients conclude that they feel prepared to do so.

Purpose and Benefits

- ✓ To take stock of the current status of her immune system.
- ✓ To identify risk factors for slipping back to an earlier status (what “hooks” her).
- ✓ To summarize what she has learned helps her to not slip back (what “releases” her from the hold of his Big Assumption).
- ✓ To name new strategies for nurturing progress.
- ✓ To increase ownership over the work and continued progress.

Three General Points about the “End Game: Consolidating Learning”

They know that it is normal to fall back into old patterns associated with the Big Assumption, and that knowing how to get unstuck is significant progress.

1. Many clients find it very satisfying to consolidate their learning. Even when they conclude that they have further to go before they become “Unconsciously Immune,” they can see what they *have* accomplished. As important, they know how they got there, and so they know how they can continue to work on their journey. They know that it is normal to fall back into old patterns associated with the Big Assumption, and that knowing how to get unstuck is significant progress. Those clients who want to renew their coaching contract typically begin to discuss that option at this time. The most common reasons clients want to continue with coaching are because they want additional support to strengthen

their “releases” or because they uncovered a deeper Big Assumption only later in the coaching process and need more time and support to test it.

2. A client might productively choose to do a second survey, assuming he did an initial survey, if he has significantly altered his Big Assumption. If he has not made such progress, it is likely to be difficult for other people to discern changes in his behavior

3. The Future Progress exercise essentially invites a client to consider whether there is a next improvement goal she wants to pursue that she suspects may be an adaptive one, and if so, to do a new 4-Column map and re-use the exercises she has learned how to use over the past months. The exercise is intended to be as much a reminder to a client to appreciate that she has learned a method for continued growth hereafter (and not necessarily a prompt to begin that process immediately). It also introduces them to (or reminds them of) the idea that overturning an immune system does not mean that we no longer have any immune system. Instead, our immune systems have simply grown – we have replaced the old one with a newer, more sophisticated one that we may also outgrow in time.

By self-assessing where he is in his developmental journey (“Consciously Immune” to “Consciously Released” to “Unconsciously Released”), a client gets a quick snapshot of his *current* relationship to his Big Assumption. Using the definitions provided in the exercise (see below), most clients have an easy time answering this question, and their answer helps them to see what, if anything, they need to continue working on.

Part I: Self-Assessment

Here are the definitions of the various points of development in overturning an immune system:

“Consciously Immune”: A client enters this realm when he successfully completes his 4-Column map: he now sees his immune system, but he is predictably subject to his Big Assumption (which is what keeps his immune system intact). For a client to remain here after completing all the overturning work is highly unlikely (in fact, we have never had such an experience or heard about one). One plausible situation is that the client remains here because he decides that his Big Assumption is too risky to test at all!

Once the client begins to see data that challenge his Big Assumptions (e.g., through observing counter-examples, or by generating such data through a test), he begins to move towards being consciously released. Building and using his budding muscle set to keep objectively inquiring into his assumptions will lead him more fully into being consciously released.

“Consciously Released”: A crucial part of this development phase is when your client tests her Big Assumption(s) and discovers the conditions under which it is and is not valid. This may include discovering that the Big Assumption is not warranted in *any* situation. A client often learns new behaviors and new “self-talk” scripts as a part of this testing process. When your client can act on her newly discovered knowledge to interrupt the Big Assumption (and the old behavior and self talk patterns associated with it) in those situations where it is not valid, she is demonstrating the new capacity to be “Consciously Released” from her Big Assumption. This takes mindful practice. The journey is not a bump-free or necessarily straight one. It is normal to fall back into old patterns associated with the Big Assumption. Still, your client’s knowledge that she is falling back, and that she knows how to get unstuck are all signs of development. In most cases, your client should also see that she has made progress towards meeting her Column 1 goal.

It is possible that your client may discover that the Big Assumption is warranted in some (or even, theoretically, all) situations. In the rare event that she does find her Big Assumption is valid, in every test she has run, she is still “released” in that she has consciously

chosen to claim this Big Assumption (rather than holding it unconsciously) and is likely to revise her relationship to her Column 1 goal (deciding, for example, that it is not in fact the thing she most wants).

“Unconsciously Released”: When your client no longer needs to stop, think and plan in order to interrupt his Big Assumption, he has developed the capacity to be “Unconsciously Released” from it. At this point, your client automatically acts and thinks in ways that run counter to his previously held Big Assumption in those situations where it is not valid. New beliefs and understandings, informed and developed mindfully throughout the process, have taken the place of the Big Assumption. Your client will have likely made significant progress, if not full success, towards meeting his Column 1 goal.

Part 2: Identifying Hooks and Releases

Many clients will know that they must still remain vigilant to keep their Big Assumptions from asserting themselves in certain contexts. After only four or five months of working to overturn their immunities, these clients are likely to feel they have not yet become fully released. They may see themselves as still “consciously released” or perhaps even “consciously immune” in some ways. At this point, they may feel (and/or you may recommend to them) that they need to continue to do further tests of their Big Assumptions. That is a good choice if they find themselves frequently in the grip of their Big Assumptions. You might remind your client that the testing process is iterative and there is no set number of tests that, if done, will overturn an immune system. When you and your client are ready to move on, the hooks and releases part of this exercise can help your client to increase the likelihood of his continued success.

This exercise asks the client to take stock of the current status of her Big Assumption, assessing her risk factors of getting pulled back and making plans for how to guard against slippage. We all have had experiences of slipping back into old habits and patterns, so we can legitimately wonder why this time should be any different. When done well, part two shows your client why this time will be different: the outcome is a highly personalized “Do’s and Don’ts Tip Sheet” for her. Different from the type of tips in magazine or self-help book, which usually focus only on behaviors, these tend to also include reminders to stay alert to:

- Common triggers (e.g., “when I’m with people who are one-upping each other” “when I feel stressed”).
- Self-talk that has sustained the Big assumption (e.g., “I can’t win here”).
- How to get unplugged from these automatic reactions (e.g., “I tell myself that I have a choice not to see this as a competition”).

If your client identifies himself as “Unconsciously Released,” and you agree, he may wish to stop there and refrain from completing this part of this exercise. Or, he may find it gratifying to complete it with you as a way to check and confirm his sense of his progress. Either way, it is valuable to discuss how he can engage in future improvement work (see section, Three General Points about the “End Game: Consolidating Learning,” point 3).

Marcos

You may recall that in the biography of his Big Assumption, Marcos described a very painful and unanticipated end of a romantic relationship that reverberated through many aspects of his life and left him feeling exploited, betrayed, and shattered. His coping strategy had been to bury his feelings and convert them into anger, which he had carried for a few years. A crucial moment in overturning his immunities came when Marcos shared the story of this break-up with one of his closest friends. In sharing his story, Marcos was a bit surprised and delighted to find that he felt less vulnerable, less angry, and much less lonely. After conducting a few more tests, Marcos then reached the place where he felt “unconsciously released.”

Brief Example of Hooks & Releases

Column 1 goal: *“To be able to relax, celebrate life, and stop constantly striving for more, for perfection.”*

Big Assumption: *“I assume I must always be strong and in control or people will think I am vulnerable and weak.”*

Reflection Question	Your Response
Where do you see yourself in the sequence at this time?	Unconsciously released! I now understand my BA is/was an illusion. I had made myself believe it because it suited me at one time. Now I am no longer in that place, but I had forgotten to keep up with the rest of me and evolve. This whole process has opened me up emotionally. I think my control issues spread from one difficult situation. I still had a great deal of fear about it, and felt that I couldn't accept it, and that fear seemed to have spread to all parts of life. Now I can see that and have reversed that process completely. I now see that when I have intense feelings, I can seek out trusted people with whom to share my feelings. Often, if I tell them how I am feeling, I immediately start to feel like the intensity of my feelings diminishes a bit. I am better able to process my thoughts and come to new understandings of myself and the situations that tend to get me upset in the first place. I can also share my feelings much more casually, like letting people at work know when I am stressed or worried about a project; when I feel proud of work we've done; when I feel uncomfortable with how a meeting is unfolding. It's not like I'm spilling my guts all over the place – I have just learned how and when it is relevant (and important) to communicate my feelings so we can keep communication channels open and do better work.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your Big Assumption is valid? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	After multiple tests, I don't believe I must always be strong and in control. And, I am not worried that people I confide in will think I am vulnerable or weak. My Big Assumption now seems untrue.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your BA is invalid? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	It is completely invalid with my close personal relationships and also no longer applies at work. I realize now that people are much more open to me when I can be open to them. I am much more relaxed with myself and am able to allow myself to feel deeply and to share my feelings with others. I just wish I had seen this sooner!

Reflection Question	Your Response
Do you find your BA asserting itself in situations you know it ought not? If so, do you have any generalizations about the conditions under which you are likely (more or less) to find yourself being sucked into the old patterns associated with the BA? What still sometimes hooks you?	Sometimes I still will experience some worry that another person won't want me to share my thoughts and feelings. But that worry erases so quickly! I find myself quickly able to move past it.
Are there key "releases" (i.e., self-talk that unhooks you) you have developed and can use to help yourself easily and readily when you are facing your Big Assumption in real-time?	About 95% of the time, I don't need an escape route, but on occasion, if it need to, I tell myself: "Let go!" or "Just be yourself!" or something similar. I think quite a bit about the tests I've run and the results I've seen. I still get so much feedback from others that welcomes this new openness I've found and that keeps me aware of this new place I've gotten to.
To what extent/how often can you use these "releases" to help you from being pulled into old patterns?	No relapses yet!
Have you developed new behaviors or ways of talking to yourself in situations that used to activate your BA?	I just focus on letting go, being me. I can count on one hand the times when I have had to remind myself of this in the last month or so.
Think about situations in which you think your BA is no longer accurate. What new beliefs or understandings do you hold about "how things work" or what will happen in these situations?	I am more aware of my tone of voice. I am a better listener now. I feel like I can really connect with other people I would have mistrusted in the past. I guess I can see that people might want to connect too – where I used to be much more guarded and suspicious. Now I can see that I was mostly trying to protect myself because I was afraid that something bad, something I couldn't handle, might happen to me again.

Reflection Question	Your Response
How would you rate your progress toward achieving your Column 1 goal? Has your understanding of or relationship to that goal changed in important ways?	My goal has been to relax, celebrate life, and stop constantly striving for more, for perfection. I definitely feel like this is coming true for me, and I also feel like I have a different idea of what my goal means – I see now that those feelings come only when I can stop being so obsessed with the idea of being in control of myself – what I am feeling and thinking as well as what I do. I see too in some ways how futile that control mindset has been – I was never really in control. I can't simply will myself to feel (or, maybe in my case, not feel) something.

For another example (in which the client identified several useful hooks and releases), please see Cathy's hooks and releases exercise in *Immunity to Change* (pp. 274-279).

Engaging your Client in this Exercise

Help your client understand the context for the assignment. Your job continues to be helping your client to understand how this exercise is connected to those he has already completed and to the core ideas of the immunity-to-change concept (especially the connection between making progress on his Column 1 goal and making changes to the Big Assumptions he currently holds). You can also highlight for your client the importance of this step in the process of overturning one's immunities.

What are the connections that you see between this exercise and the previous ones? Which exercises do you see Hooks & Releases as most connected to and why?

Did you see connections between the Hooks and Releases exercise and all of the prior ones? If you did, that's terrific, and is a sign that you understand how the ITC exercises build on each other. While some of them focus more on the improvement goal (e.g., survey, Continuum of Progress), and others focus on the Big Assumption (e.g., observations, the biography, and testing), the two foci are interconnected. Hooks and Releases emphasizes the Big Assumption (only one question is about the initial improvement goal) but only because of the crucial role the Big Assumption has played in keeping the client from making progress on her goal.

Before we turn to tips and pitfalls, we encourage you to consider the potential challenges to avoid with your client when inviting her to do this exercise.

In what ways might your client be drawn to or feel resistant to this exercise? What might you actually say to your client to help her make a good choice about how/whether to complete this exercise? Take a moment to write down your thoughts.

Tips and Pitfalls

Coach's Tips for Identifying Hooks & Releases

- Overall Tips*
1. Keep the purpose and intended results in mind throughout the process of presenting this exercise to your client and debriefing it. The purposes of Identifying Hooks and Releases are to take stock of the current status of your client's immune system; to identify risk factors for slipping back to an earlier status; and to name and discover new strategies for nurturing progress.
 2. Remember the coach's "Two Hats": being an empathetic listener and probing for the ITC implications of what is said.
 3. Be alert to the ways that your meetings with your client provide you with information relevant to your coaching. The ways in which her immunities do and don't show up with you are an important source of data as well.



Potential Pitfalls

Coach	Client
Loses sight of the purposes of exploring the client's progress to-date and identifying strategies for keeping BAs at bay. Suggests new, untested strategies and behaviors to client.	May have access to potentially useful strategies, but if they are not tested, they may not lead to new understandings of his BA(s). Feels less (rather than more) ownership over process.
Pushes client to accept coach's assessment of her progress – wants client to see himself as either more released or less released.	Feels manipulated, overwhelmed, judged, and/or resistant. Feels less (rather than more) ownership over process.
Feeling pressured by end of contracted arrangements, pushes client into completing this step too quickly.	Feels misunderstood or unsupported emotionally. Feels less (rather than more) ownership over process. Increases the likelihood of backsliding.
Believes that coachee has overestimated or underestimated his progress but does not share this different perspective. Does not engage client in discussion of what data supports her assessment.	Overestimates or underestimates her progress. Does not draw on all the relevant data or has a biased interpretation of them (perhaps based on her BA).

In-depth Examples:

Jackson's Hooks & Releases

Jackson & Amanda

Jackson's Big Assumption: *"I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend."*

Version 1

Reflection Question	Your Response
Where do you see yourself in the sequence at this time?	Somewhere between consciously immune and consciously released.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your Big Assumption is valid? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	I'm sure there are situations in which I could go self-publicize in a way that I see (and others see) as clearly bragging. I guess it's possible I could get to the place where I believe what I say. But, I've also learned that I am much more likely to feel like self-publicity is bragging than others are. I am much more focused on that problem than most others are. Most people just seem to take it for granted that is the way things work. Even other people like Larissa who notice bragging seem like they are much more forgiving of it than I am.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your BA is invalid? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	See above, plus, the one BA that clearly seems like it is no longer valid is the first one: I assume that saying anything about my accomplishments is bragging. I can now see how there are more artful ways of talking about what you've done that may demonstrate pride, excitement, even just plain honesty... that aren't really bragging at all.
Do you find your BA asserting itself in situations you know it ought not? If so, do you have any generalizations about the conditions under which you are likely (more or less) to find yourself being sucked into the old patterns associated with the BA? What still sometimes hooks you?	I think I still need to work on keeping them in the front of my mind. When I let them slip from there, I tend to think and act business-as-usual and don't actively look for (or try out) anything that contradicts my ingrained ideas about bragging.

Version 1: Jackson continued

Reflection Question	Your Response
Are there key “releases” (i.e., self-talk that unhooks you) you have developed and can use to help yourself easily and readily when you are facing your Big Assumption in real-time?	Reminders: Imagining how others (who are good at self-promotion) would handle a situation. Knowing that I shouldn’t rely on my own brag-o-meter to tell me if I’m doing enough/too much.
To what extent/how often can you use these “releases” to help you from being pulled into old patterns?	We’ll see!
Have you developed new behaviors or ways of talking to yourself in situations that used to activate your BA?	Be direct. Say what I intended to say. Ask for feedback.
Think about situations in which you think your BA is no longer accurate. What new beliefs or understandings do you hold about “how things work” or what will happen in these situations?	The clearest examples to me of when my BA is not accurate are when I see others who self-promote pretty well. What I notice most is that not only does this type of thing seem like it isn’t bragging, it doesn’t even always seem like self-promotion!
How would you rate your progress toward achieving your Column 1 goal? Has your understanding of or relationship to that goal changed in important ways?	I have wanted senior management to see more clearly my contributions to this organization, and I see that my role in that is to be able to promote myself skillfully. I see that happening now – both that I am better at self-promotion and that senior management is responding to that. What drove me to identify my goal was resentment I was feeling that I wasn’t getting what I deserved. I don’t have that resentment now – I feel much more optimistic now.

Jackson’s coach read over the draft of the *Stock-Taking* reflections Jackson sent. She was pleased how much Jackson seemed to understand the fundamental focus and process involved in overturning his immunities and felt that Jackson was now leading the work more, becoming less reliant on his coach. His coach looked forward to reminding Jackson of a few important pieces they had learned together (esp. underscoring the importance of preparation in enacting new self-promotion strategies). She also wanted to get a sense from Jackson about how he saw his next steps in maintaining progress in overturning his immunities and reaching his Column 1 goal.

Version 2

Reflection Question	Your Response
Where do you see yourself in the sequence at this time?	Somewhere between consciously immune and consciously released.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your Big Assumption is valid? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	I'm sure there are situations in which I could go self-publicize in a way that I see (and others see) as clearly bragging. I guess it's possible I could get to the place where I believe what I say. But, I've also learned that I am much more likely to feel like self-publicity is bragging than others are. I am much more focused on that problem than most others are. Most people just seem to take it for granted that is the way things work. Even other people like Larissa who notice bragging seem like they are much more forgiving of it than I am.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your Big Assumption is invalid? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	See above, plus, the one BA that clearly seems like it is no longer valid is the first one: I assume that saying anything about my accomplishments is bragging. I can now see how there are more artful ways of talking about what you've done that may demonstrate pride, excitement, even just plain honesty... that aren't really bragging at all.
Do you find your BA asserting itself in situations you know it ought not? If so, do you have any generalizations about the conditions under which you are likely (more or less) to find yourself being sucked into the old patterns associated with the BA? What still sometimes hooks you?	I think I still need to work on keeping them in the front of my mind. When I let them slip from there, I tend to think and act business-as-usual and don't actively look for (or try out) anything that contradicts my ingrained ideas about bragging.
Are there key "releases" (i.e., self-talk that unhooks you) you have developed and can use to help yourself easily and readily when you are facing your Big Assumption in real-time?	Reminders: Preparation Imagining how others (who are good at self-promotion) would handle a situation. Knowing that I shouldn't rely on my own brag-o-meter to tell me if I'm doing enough/too much. I have been assuming that what seems like bragging to me is the same as what others see as bragging... and that this is not true!

Version 2: Jackson continued

Reflection Question	Your Response
To what extent/how often can you use these “releases” to help you from being pulled into old patterns?	We’ll see! Plans for future tests: • Read/attend workshops on how to do self-promotion. • Watch and learn from those around me who do this well. • Watch for opportunities and take them.
Have you developed new behaviors or ways of talking to yourself in situations that used to activate your BA?	Be direct. Say what I intended to say. Ask for feedback. Still want to work on developing by repertoire of what to say.
Think about situations in which you think your BA is no longer accurate. What new beliefs or understandings do you hold about “how things work” or what will happen in these situations?	The clearest examples to me of when my BA is not accurate are when I see others who self-promote pretty well. What I notice most is that not only does this type of thing seem like it isn’t bragging, it doesn’t even always seem like self-promotion!
How would you rate your progress toward achieving your Column 1 goal? Has your understanding of or relationship to that goal changed in important ways?	I have wanted senior management to see more clearly my contributions to this organization, and I see that my role in that is to be able to promote myself skillfully. I see that happening now – both that I am better at self-promotion and that senior management is responding to that. What drove me to identify my goal was resentment I was feeling that I wasn’t getting what I deserved. I don’t have that resentment now – I feel much more optimistic now. In many ways, I actually feel more powerful, although that isn’t what I set out to do.

Amanda’s Hooks & Releases

Amanda’s coach explained the purpose and focus of the Hooks and Releases exercise and asked Amanda to try and fill it out on her own. He wanted to see how much Amanda seemed to be grasping the central ideas of ITC, as a way to inform them about how ready Amanda was to continue doing this work on her own.

Amanda emailed the following response to her coach in preparation for their next meeting:

Amanda’s Big Assumption: *“I assume that if I don’t have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.”*

Version 1

Reflection Question	Your Response
Where do you see yourself in the sequence at this time?	Consciously released? I'm doing lots of stuff in my CoP.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your BA is valid? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	I just have to tell myself that I can't eat the way I used to or even the way other people do and that's that. Stop feeling sorry for myself.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your BA is invalid? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	Nobody can tell me what to eat or not to eat but me. If you really want to reach your dreams, you can do it!! Just believe!!
Do you find your BA asserting itself in situations you know it ought not? If so, do you have any generalizations about the conditions under which you are likely (more or less) to find yourself being sucked into the old patterns associated with the BA? What still sometimes hooks you?	I still slip up but now I know that that is okay and nobody is perfect. I can make plans that will help me be good even when there is lots of good food around and people socializing. I can use my strategies and ask for help!
Are there key “releases” (i.e., self-talk that unhooks you) you have developed and can use to help yourself easily and readily when you are facing your BA in real-time?	Focus on people – who I want to see, what to talk about, what to do to keep me busy so that I'm not near food and thinking about food all the time. I know now that I like healthy food!
To what extent/how often can you use these “releases” to help you from being pulled into old patterns?	Just keep believing in myself and working hard. I know that I have gotten this far, and I'm not going back!
Have you developed new behaviors or ways of talking to yourself in situations that used to activate your BA?	It's good to tell people and ask them to help me eat right. I even got some of my family looking at the Weight Watchers site and planning to join too. I think I can be fun even if I'm not eating all the time.

Version 1: Amanda continued

Reflection Question	Your Response
Think about situations in which you think your BA is no longer accurate. What new beliefs or understandings do you hold about “how things work” or what will happen in these situations?	
How would you rate your progress toward achieving your Column 1 goal? Has your understanding of or relationship to that goal changed in important ways?	I’m pretty much there!

Imagine that you are Amanda’s coach (and if you opted earlier to remind yourself of what Amanda has been up to all along the ITC process, you’re all set to assume her coach’s role!). Take a moment to assess the quality of her work. To what extent do you think she grasps the central ideas of ITC? What does she say here that leads you to that assessment?

Your view of Amanda’s responses to Hooks & Releases:

Amanda's coach thought that Amanda had misunderstood the intent of the exercise. Her entries all had a kind of cheerleading stance, and her coach worried that Amanda was still missing a sufficient understanding of the concept of immunities and a focus on her Big Assumptions. He noticed Amanda did not mention her Big Assumption(s) at all and wondered if Amanda was afraid to consider that she might still be immune in important ways because admitting that would make it seem more likely that she would backslide? Perhaps she was worried also about how she would sustain the progress she had made once their coaching relationship had ended and Amanda was working more on her own.

Her coach knew that in addition to discussing the stock-taking exercise and trying to help Amanda reconnect to her immunities, they should probably also begin to talk about ways to sustain Amanda's work once she had completed their contracted sessions together.

Version 2

Reflection Question	Your Response
Where do you see yourself in the sequence at this time?	Consciously released? I'm doing lots of stuff in my CoP.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your Big Assumption is valid? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	I just have to tell myself that I can't eat the way I used to or even the way other people do and that's that. Stop feeling sorry for myself. I think that I'm still working hard to make sure I don't slip back. I don't even want to think about what could make that happen. So maybe my BAs are still there, but if I keep working, they'll go away completely. It's important that I keep putting the things into place that help me make progress.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your Big Assumption is invalid? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	Nobody can tell me what to eat or not to eat but me. If you really want to reach your dreams, you can do it!! Just believe!! I have worked really hard to not get caught in my routines and to see that I have choices. I need to keep reminding myself not to fall back into old ways of thinking – that I'm not in control, that it's too hard, that others aren't going to help me. I see that work as just as hard and just as important as what I put in my mouth (or what I don't!). When I keep doing that thinking, then my BAs aren't true at all.

Version 2: Amanda continued

Reflection Question	Your Response
Do you find your BA asserting itself in situations you know it ought not? If so, do you have any generalizations about the conditions under which you are likely (more or less) to find yourself being sucked into the old patterns associated with the BA? What still sometimes hooks you?	I still slip up but now I know that that is okay and nobody is perfect. I can make plans that will help me be good even when there is lots of good food around and people socializing. I can use my strategies and ask for help! I guess just that it is hard work shows me that they could still hook me, even though I've passed some really hard tests.
Are there key “releases” (i.e., self-talk that unhooks you) you have developed and can use to help yourself easily and readily when you are facing your Big Assumption in real-time?	Focus on people – who I want to see, what to talk about, what to do to keep me busy so that I’m not near food and thinking about food all the time. I know now that I like healthy food! Look at my thinking, not just at my eating.
To what extent/how often can you use these “releases” to help you from being pulled into old patterns?	Just keep believing in myself and working hard. I know that I have gotten this far, and I’m not going back!
Have you developed new behaviors or ways of talking to yourself in situations that used to activate your BA?	It’s good to tell people and ask them to help me eat right. I even got some of my family looking at the WW site and planning to join too. I think I can be fun even if I’m not eating all the time.
Think about situations in which you think your BA is no longer accurate. What new beliefs or understandings do you hold about “how things work” or what will happen in these situations?	I can feel in charge by following my conscious decisions. When I’m out for a special occasion, I can indulge myself a little bit without going off my diet completely. I can eat less during the meal so that I can have healthy dessert. I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

Version 2: Amanda continued

Reflection Question	Your Response
How would you rate your progress toward achieving your Column 1 goal? Has your understanding of or relationship to that goal changed in important ways?	My goal was: To develop healthier eating habits. To lose 25 pounds thereby lowering my blood pressure and improving my cholesterol. I have lost almost all the weight, and my bp and cholesterol numbers are so much better. The part where I still need to make progress is in making the changes I've made into true habits so that I don't start to ease up and gain back the weight!

As with the Biography exercise, there are relatively few criteria for writing a good Hooks and Releases exercise. Fundamentally, you want to make sure that your client accounts for what he has learned from the previous exercises he has completed (particularly the tests he has run) and identified useful (and tested) ways that he can:

Practice Time: Over To You

1. Keep himself from getting “hooked” by his Big Assumption; and
2. Release himself from it when it inappropriately asserts itself.

Given the relatively straightforward nature of this exercise, we haven't included other practice examples in this chapter.

Chapter 9

Putting the Pieces Together

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Introduction

We have structured this Guide (and the Participant Workbook) in linear sequence, suggesting that each exercise in the ITC process follows logically from those that come before it. Our rationale for presenting this material in that order is that there *is* a logical sequence to the order of the exercises. Obviously, it makes good sense to diagnose an immunity (in an ITC map) before overturning it. And often, it is useful to spend some time observing a Big Assumption (moving it from Subject to Object) before attempting to test it in hopes of altering it. In shorthand, there are “Opening Moves” followed by a “Middle Game” and then an “End Game.”

But this sequencing does not fully represent the spirit and nature of the work. As we have said elsewhere, we don’t intend to communicate that everyone must absolutely do every single one of the ITC exercises (notice the dotted lined arrow from “Map” to “Testing” to “Hooks & Releases” in the ITC Coaching Journey graphic) or in the order provided. (Notice the many arrows that lead towards and away from any one exercise indicating that there are various routes to and from a given exercise). We have seen that not all the exercises are necessary for every person to do in order to overturn an immune system. While the exercises tend to build on each other, this is not like an arithmetic course where the only way you can learn to multiply and divide is if you first learn addition and subtraction.

The sequence is also misleading in that the process of overturning an immunity is not linear. Overturning an immunity does not mean moving from one exercise to another as if climbing a staircase steadily away from the Big Assumption below and toward the Improvement Goal above. When altering an immune *system*, we must think systemically and remain aware of the complex dynamics we are working with. To study, put pressure on, or alter any part of the system causes ripples in all other parts of the system. When we pay attention to those ripples, we then see parts of the system we never saw before; we see new relationships between parts; we may see the entire system itself in new ways.

It is useful, therefore, to keep in mind that your client’s work on each exercise in the ITC process is always incomplete. Completing an immunity map does not signal that the diagnosis is complete. New Big Assumptions emerge, a deeper diagnosis is revealed, and the immune system is reconceived. Our initial visions

...keep in mind that your client’s work on each exercise in the ITC process is always incomplete.

in a Continuum of Progress of what it could be like to overturn our immunities and realize our column one goal give way to new visions that surface as we learn more about ourselves and as old ways of making sense give way to new ones. Part of the coach’s job is determining the right approach to and pacing of the work so that the client can progress through the work in a way that maximizes his motivation, momentum, learning, and results. When the coach is familiar with all of the exercises in the process and their relationship to each other, the overturning process begins to appear less like a sequence of exercises, and the iterative, cyclical nature of systemic work becomes evident.

This chapter is dedicated to helping coaches keep that overall picture in mind, by illustrating how the client may actually be in some way working on multiple exercises in simultaneously – moving “forward” and “backward” during the overturning process. It does not, therefore, provide support for helping clients engage in a particular exercise, but instead suggests a way that coaches need to be thinking about and guiding their clients’ work.

At a Glance

Overview

The process of overturning an immunity is not strictly linear, as suggested by the sequence of the exercises. Instead, it is an iterative process, where the learning accomplished in one exercise has implications for all of the other exercises. It is the coach’s job to help the client recognize these implications and cycle “back” (or “forward”) to make these implications explicit for the client in the written record of the process (in most cases, the Participant Workbook). When the coach understands the entire coaching arc – particularly the functions of each exercise and the connections between the exercises – the coach can best determine the most appropriate pathways for the client’s work.

Purpose and Benefits of Putting the Pieces Together

- ✓ The client’s learning and growth are the main drivers of the work.
- ✓ The client can see the exercises not as assignments or steps to complete but as structured opportunities to develop learning habits or muscles that when practiced and refined, can lead to overturning an immune system.

Looking “Backward”: Returning to Earlier Exercises

It is very common for clients to identify new Big Assumptions throughout the ITC process that they were not initially able to name during the Mapping exercise.

Whenever a client completes an exercise, part of the coach’s job is to see if the client has revealed any new learning that has implications for earlier exercises in the ITC process.

It is very common for clients to identify new Big Assumptions throughout the ITC process that they were not initially able to name during the Mapping exercise. For example, Elton was working on an immunity he had to giving difficult feedback to his direct reports. When he constructed his map, he identified a Big Assumption that had to do with how he understood the world to work:

“I assume that being very direct with people is rude.”

He also identified a couple of Big Assumptions that mostly focused on the most dreaded consequences he saw for himself:

“I assume that if I have to give direct feedback, I’ll get embarrassed and awkward.”

“I assume that if I am perceived as a ‘tough guy,’ people won’t like me, won’t like working for me. I will feel terrible.”

Observing his Big Assumptions in action helped him realize that he also held Big Assumptions that were more focused on the consequences for others – how they would feel, interpret his behavior, and think about themselves if he were to give them difficult feedback. He noticed:

“I assume that if I say something difficult, the employee may be so wounded that he or she will burst into tears, be seriously depressed, need therapy, bring their stress home, etc.”

“I assume that my employees would rather work in a “nice” office than one that runs more efficiently and effectively.”

Both of these assumptions struck him as likely to be incorrect (at least to some degree), and he felt a new eagerness at the possibility that he might be able to explore them further through tests. Elton’s coach suggested he add both Big Assumptions to his map and then

began to think about whether overturning these assumptions would also affect his Continuum of Progress. They discussed what it would be like for Elton to be fully successful in overturning these assumptions and be able to give difficult feedback. Elton suggested:

- I regularly check in with employees about their own hopes for the office – how it could function better – without assuming I know what they will think.
- During a difficult conversation, I know how to (and remember to) check in with the employee to gauge how he or she is responding, to make sure we share a similar sense of how serious (or not) the issue at hand is.

He then added two new entries to his Significant Progress Column:

- I actively look for evidence of how my employees might view situations differently than I do.
- I develop a list of ways to check in and see how someone else is feeling or making sense of our conversation.

In this case, Elton's coach helped him build on his realization that he was often held back by his fears of how others would respond to hearing difficult feedback. In "going back" to earlier exercises to weave these assumptions into the immunity map and the Continuum of Progress, Elton felt that both were now increasingly powerful and accurate, helping him get to a deeper level in his own learning. He also felt that he understood the way that the whole ITC process was designed to work – the exercises felt less like random "assignments" to complete and more like new habits of thinking to cultivate.

Similarly, clients often continue to observe their Big Assumptions long after they have officially engaged in the observations exercises. (Of course, the testing process always includes observation as well, looking to see how behavior change allows the client to collect data on the Big Assumption.) As clients begin to move from "consciously immune" to "consciously released," they almost always continue to conduct observations in addition to the tests they run. They are on the lookout for any situation that implicates their Big Assumptions.

For example, Adrienne had been working with two Big Assumptions she held:

"If I let colleagues or supervisors see work before it is fully completed, and I let them into my work process, they'll take over, and I will lose sight of my own goals and feeling of ownership."

"If I don't make sure that every detail is worked out, I feel like I've failed."

She had begun to run tests on her first Big Assumption and was learning that there were certain conditions in which it was most likely to be activated. When there was especially intense time pressure, Adrienne felt that her fear about missing a deadline would outweigh her commitment to advocate for her own ideas. Through testing, she had begun to learn how to clarify deadlines, more effectively determine priorities, and be more specific about the types of feedback or collaboration that would be useful to her. She was in the midst of designing a new test, when she told her coach of a new observation she had made:

“I was making my daughters’ lunches for school, and I was late. There was still laundry I wanted to fold, and my husband couldn’t find his shoes, and the dog was barking to be let out. I was running around doing it all and worried that everyone would be late, when suddenly, I thought, ‘My God. Here it is again.’ My husband can wear other shoes. The laundry can wait. Nobody else is as worried about any of this as I am.’ And I could see the same pattern we’ve talked about at work – that when I feel like I am running late, I don’t stop to think about what really needs to get done. I get really focused on managing every detail. I feel like if I don’t do it all, then... it’s not that I’ve failed. It’s more like there is a slippery slope, and I’m starting down it, and if I get far enough, I won’t be able to stop. So I can’t take even one step down it.”

Having identified the trigger in her work life, Adrienne could now recognize it operating in her personal life too. Making this observation also helped her clarify her second Big Assumption, which she reworded:

“If I don’t make sure that every detail is worked out, I have stepped onto a slippery slope and am in real danger of losing control completely and sliding all the way to bottom (failure).”

“I see my fears more clearly now,” she reflected. “Failing is one thing, and that’s bad enough. But the feeling of sliding, of falling, of being out of control is pretty bad too. Maybe worse. That’s why I’ve felt every detail matters.” Adrienne and her coach then began to focus more directly on this control aspect of her immunity, designing and running tests to explore what it meant to let details go, to recover from small lapses, and to build in types of support and “quality control” that would decrease the chances that important details would go unattended to.

There are times when your client may spontaneously start to behave, talk, or think in ways that may connect directly to exercises in the ITC process that you haven't introduced yet in your work together. They haven't been "officially assigned." If this is your first time working with a client overturning her immunities, it may be difficult for you to recognize that as the case. But the more that you familiarize yourself with all the exercises in the arc, the more you can get a sense of the trajectory and intention of the whole process.

Once you understand each of the exercises, you may see ways that your client is starting to refer to or even engage in "later" exercises in the process. That will help you be alert to the ways you can best support her. Sometimes, you may want to warn her that she is getting ahead of herself if she is taking on too much at an early stage of the work. This is often the case for clients who wish to begin testing immediately after diagnosing their immunities in the map.

Other times, you may find that it is quite useful for your client to begin engaging in other exercises, and you may want to spend time talking explicitly about what your client is doing (in ITC terms) and how to engage in the work of the exercise in a way that will be most beneficial to her progress. An example of when this might be useful to clients is when the client spontaneously begins to observe her Big Assumptions just after making the map. Or, a client may identify a powerful "hook" that activates her Big Assumption from her survey data. It is up to you, the coach, to determine how to discuss this learning with your client. You may simply decide to make a note of the learning for yourself to return to with your client when she is officially undertaking the exercise later in the process. Or, you may decide to explain to her what she is doing in brief terms, letting her know how what she is doing fits into the overturning work. In some cases, you may want to suggest she begin to engage officially in that later exercise, if she feels naturally drawn to and ready for the learning it is likely to produce. Here are some examples of all three of these types of situations.

Example: When the Client is Not Ready to Move to Later Exercises in the ITC Process

Andy's immunity work was based around a Column 1 goal of making personal relationships a higher priority in his life. In diagnosing his immunity to making better progress on this goal, he identified a couple of related Big Assumptions:

Looking "Forward": Forecasting Exercises to Come

There are times when your client may spontaneously start to behave, talk, or think in ways that may connect directly to exercises in the ITC process that you haven't introduced yet in your work together.

“I assume that the more successful I am in my career, the more likely I am to be attractive to women.”

“I assume that success means making lots of money and getting a lot of power/respect.”

After diagnosing this immunity, Andy was eager to get to work overturning his immunity and told his coach that he'd like to get in touch with an old ex-girlfriend as his first test. In the years since their break-up, he had been promoted and given a significantly higher salary than what he had made when he had dated her. Now, he felt it was a good time to see if her feelings for him had changed.

Andy's coach advised him strongly against running this test or in designing and running any tests at this point in time. First, this test seemed poorly designed and Andy seemed more likely to prove his Big Assumptions true than to challenge them. Further, his coach had a hunch that Andy's impulsivity (and frankly, arrogance) might be powerful factors that were getting in the way of him maintaining a successful romantic relationship. These factors would also likely interfere with his ability to collect and interpret data in any tests he ran at this point in the process. Instead, she suggested that they include the ex-girlfriend as one of his survey respondents, enabling them to collect data about how Andy behaved and was perceived. In that way, they could learn more about Andy's immune system and build up his ITC skills so that he would be ready for testing when that time came.

Example: When the Client Identifies Learning Relevant to Later Exercises but Does Not Officially Undertake Them

Mira's column 1 goal was to improve her effectiveness at work through getting better at time management and prioritizing. In her immunity map, she listed the following Big Assumption:

“I assume that everyone wants me to finish things perfectly and ASAP.”

She then began to work with her coach to set up her survey and begin the Continuum of Progress. At the beginning of her next meeting with her coach, Mira checked in by saying,

“This has been a really interesting week for me! I keep thinking about my immunities issues and how they have been getting in my way. I was having lunch with my girlfriends, and Cecilia was complaining about her work, just telling us how much she had to do. She was giving lots of examples of her complaints, and then said something like, ‘There is no way I’ll get my expense reports in to Accounting on time. They hate me down there. But they can wait.’ So that was really interesting to me because Cecelia is one of the most successful consultants we have here. It got me thinking, ‘Is that

true? Is she always late with her reports?’ I don’t know. But it just started me thinking that maybe not everyone feels like they have to treat all work the same – it’s not all at the level of emergency if one thing is late. Some stuff matters less.

So then later that day, I got a phone call from HR about some paperwork for a new person in my department. I guess they need some form signed, or something was missing, maybe. And I just thought, ‘Oh God. I don’t have time for this.’ And then I stopped myself and thought, ‘I’ll ask them. I’ll ask them when they need it.’ So I did. The lady didn’t really answer at first, so then I said, ‘I’ll have it to you next week, ok?’ And that was it. It wasn’t an emergency. Nobody HAD to have it right away.”

In this example, Mira has unofficially been at work on two ITC exercises – Observing her Big Assumption in Action (of which this example served as a “natural counter”) and Running a Test of her Big Assumption. Mira’s coach took some time to talk with Mira about what she was learning, explaining what she had been doing in ITC terms, illustrating for her how the first had been an observation of a natural counter to her Big Assumption and the second had been a modest test (in which Mira had changed her typical behavior by asking when a form was needed and offering a time by which she could complete the task). Mira’s coach then talked briefly about the data Mira had collected in each case, how it could be interpreted, and the implications for her Big Assumption. They then turned back to their work on survey development.

Example: When the Client Identifies Learning Relevant to Later Exercises and Officially Undertakes That Work “Out of Order”

Hiroko wasn’t surprised by her entries in the third column of her immunity map:

“I am committed to being another version of my sister.”

“I am committed to winning my sister’s approval.”

These commitments led naturally to her Big Assumptions, “I assume that I must always compare my decisions with my sister’s. I assume that my decisions must always meet with her approval.” As they worked together to hone her map, Hiroko repeatedly referred back to stories and incidents from her childhood that had shaped her own sense of self. Some stories were familiar – she had been recalling them for herself for years. Other stories began to touch on things she hadn’t recalled for a long time and hadn’t reflected on how they influenced her current way of thinking about herself.

Noticing how focused Hiroko was on uncovering these memories and understanding how her Assumptions had come into being, Hiroko’s coach suggested that she might want to

move immediately to the Biography exercise. He briefly explained the directions for that exercise to Hiroko, who readily agreed that it would be very useful for her to explore before she could begin to imagine (in the Continuum of Progress) how things could be different for her if she altered this assumption.

In his work in overturning his immunities, Nicholas also “jumped ahead” in the process. He was waiting for his survey feedback to come in when he let his coach know of an upcoming meeting that was likely to activate his Big Assumptions. While his coach felt that Nicholas was not quite ready to run a test of his Big Assumptions, she recognized that the meeting presented a very valuable learning opportunity of which they should take advantage. So, she suggested to Nicholas that they use the meeting as a way for him to begin observing his Big Assumption in action. Together they discussed the directions for that exercise, and Nicholas agreed to complete that section in his ITC Workbook for their next session together.

When to Encourage Your Client to Move Forward

In each of these cases, the coach needed to assess the costs and benefits to a potential change to the order of exercises the client was undertaking. That assessment requires the coach to understand and take stock of several things, including:

- **The nature and appropriateness of any exercise in relation to what the client is ready to learn.** An important factor to consider is whether the client is still quite “subject” to his Big Assumption. If he regards it as something that feels like an important truth in his life, he is likely still subject to it. That means that he is largely fused with it, unable to reflect on it or question it. On the other hand, if he can clearly see how his Big Assumption might be (or perhaps is fully) false but still acts as though it were true, he relates to his Big Assumption more as “object,” something that he can look at, question, and critique. The more the client is “subject” to his Big Assumption, the more important it is for him to spend time exploring it before testing it.
- **The client’s own abilities and likely success in undertaking an exercise.** Each of the ITC exercises prompt clients to practice certain skills and abilities. Testing, for example, requires multiple types of skills (enacting new behaviors adeptly, collecting quality data, interpreting those data, reflecting on those data in light of the Big Assumption). And despite our most careful planning, testing often involves some degree of improvisation with each of these skills. Accurately estimating your client’s skill level in relation to the demands of an exercise will help you determine whether it is advisable (or not) for your client to move ahead in the process.
- **The client’s own motivations for moving ahead.** To what degree is the motivation for moving ahead coming from your client or from yourself? If your client is motivated to move ahead, are those motivations reasonable? For example, maybe

he is eager to begin testing because there are multiple, low-risk, low-skill tests that he can immediately run. Maybe he is already conducting observations or reflecting on his biography in powerful ways and without the explicit prompting from you. These motivations and circumstances for moving ahead seem sound. However, other motivations (such as impulsivity or misunderstanding) give more cause for concern. Maybe he has missed the focus on the Big Assumption that is at the heart of the ITC process and so is most focused on changing his behaviors through tests? Maybe he underestimates the risks involved in changing his behavior before he has developed the necessary skills to do so effectively? In these cases, the coach will do well to advise against jumping ahead in the process.

Coach's Tips for Putting the Pieces Together

Tips and Pitfalls

1. Stay alert to the ways that any learning that results from your client's ITC work has implications for other exercises he has already begun working on. In particular, we find that any significant learning the client discovers will likely have implications for her immunity map and/or her Continuum of Progress.
2. Stay alert to any ways your client may be looking to engage (intentionally or unintentionally) in exercises that usually come later in the process. Think carefully about how and whether to move "ahead" in the work:
 - ✓ Are the purpose and intended results of that exercise most appropriate to your client's journey at this moment? In particular, is your client still quite subject to his Big Assumption?
 - ✓ Does your client's have the ability to undertake that exercise appropriately?
 - ✓ Will moving "ahead" create an unnecessarily high level of risk to your client (or anyone else)?
 - ✓ Are the client's own motivations for moving ahead strong enough and reasonable?
3. Remember the coach's "Two Hats": being an empathetic listener and probing for the ITC implications of what is said.
4. Be alert to the ways that your meetings with your client provide you with information relevant to your coaching. The ways in which her immunities do and don't show up *with you* are an important source of data as well.

Overall Tips

We find that any significant learning the client discovers will likely have implications for her immunity map and/or her Continuum of Progress.

Potential Pitfalls

Coach	Client
Moves client through the ITC exercises in linear fashion – in prescribed order and without referring “backward” or “forward” at all.	Experiences the ITC process as a series of assignments to be completed and left behind, and the power of his overall learning is depleted.
Moves “forward” quickly in the process (by own choice or through client’s impatience) without due consideration.	Runs higher risks and is less likely to generate meaningful or hopeful learning.
Jumps around in the ITC process without making explicit why or how the exercises relate to each other.	Can’t focus on the learning available in any one exercise. Feels overwhelmed by all of the different ways of exploring her immunity without engaging in any one effectively, in an order that makes sense for her own learning.

Appendices

What follows are two Participant Workbooks that should look very familiar to you by now – one is Jackson’s and the other Amanda’s. Here you can see in one place how their learning unfolded through all the exercises we’ve included in the earlier chapters. What you can also see are the ways that they (and their coaches) were also referring “backward” and “forward” to other exercises throughout. So as to bring these aspects of their work into relief as you read, those entries appear **in blue**.

A note about these workbooks: we have tried to represent the clients’ learning in writing to illustrate for you some of the ways that the process is non-linear. We’ve done that by capturing that learning in notes that Jackson and Amanda write to their coaches, as well as notes their coaches write back. We do not mean to suggest, however, that we expect ITC coaches to involve lots of diary-keeping or journalizing with their clients beyond the exercises, or that there should be some kind of robust exchanging of written memoranda between the coach and client throughout the process. Much of this learning will happen in live conversation, and coaches and clients will invariably have different appetites for keeping a faithful written record of the learning. We do think important additions to the map and Continuum of Progress, for example, should be recorded in the workbook, but we are not suggesting that a coach’s chief loyalty and focus should be to the written record. Instead, it should be on the more organized, systemically evolving learning process that the exercises and notes serve. We intend, therefore, that these workbooks function as illustrations of that learning (in written form) rather than as examples of our standard for what a completed workbook should look like or how the ITC learning should be accomplished. Finally, to create continuity for reading, we have eliminated the directions to the various exercises in these workbook examples.

Appendix A:

Jackson's Workbook

A WORKBOOK FOR Jackson

OVERCOMING THE IMMUNITY TO CHANGE

Exercise 1: Honing Your Immunity Map

Version 1

1. Commitment/Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter-Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
Having senior management see more clearly my contributions to this organization.	I don't offer status updates. I make self-deprecating comments which I think are funny and can put people at ease with me. When people praise me, I get embarrassed and try to change the subject. I don't like colleagues who look for any opportunity to publicize their accomplishments. I don't do what I plan or intend to.	Fears – being a jerk, selfish, opportunistic and blind. Losing touch. Convincing myself that I deserve more. I am committed to not being Kurt (or curt!) I am committed to not being an asshole. I am committed to not selling my soul for a little bit more power and \$.	I assume that if I am bragging, I am just like Kurt (also selfish, arrogant, etc.) I assume that if I publicize my successes, I'll believe that I am a hero.

Version 2

1. Commitment/Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter-Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
To get better at publicizing my accomplishments with senior management.	I don't request time for or offer status updates. I make self-deprecating comments. When people praise me, I get embarrassed and try to change the subject. I criticize colleagues who can publicize their accomplishments – I label that type of behavior as bragging, being arrogant. I imagine ways I could publicize my successes better but I don't act on these plans.	Fears – being a jerk, selfish, opportunistic and blind to my own human foibles. Losing touch with reality. Convincing myself that I deserve more than I do. I am committed to not becoming my brother (Kurt.) I am committed to not fitting the mold of the "asshole" executive. ...not finding out that I actually am an asshole executive.	I assume that saying anything about my accomplishments is bragging. I assume that if I am bragging, I am just like Kurt (also selfish, arrogant, etc.) I assume that if I publicize my successes, I'll believe what I say. Other people also hate to see people engage in self-promotion. Added after 1st set of observations.

Notes from Jackson to His Coach:

Feeds into tests.

I read the article you sent – “Feeling Like a Fraud” and found it very interesting. I like the way the author describes her discomfort with being seen as the expert as part of her discomfort with the whole system of hierarchies and rewards she works in. A very legitimate concern and speaks, perhaps, to some of my own discomfort with self-promotion – what makes me think I’m so deserving of fame and fortune? What makes me think that I should be at the top of the heap? And I also like her point that she actually does have some expertise, that she is skilled and can offer insight, so why hide that? I guess that’s the part of me that is ready to try harder at self-promotion, to see if I can do it and still live with myself.

Client spontaneously begins Bio Exercise.

I’ve also been thinking quite a bit about Kurt since our call. You asked me if Kurt was an “asshole executive,” which he isn’t. He started his own business and works out of his house. Yet in my mind, I very much associate my image of an asshole executive with Kurt. Why? Has gotten me thinking a lot about my childhood, and I wonder why I remember the things I do. A few years ago, my mother asked me why Kurt and I aren’t closer. I was really surprised that she seemed to think we would or should be. After all, she knows how different we were back then and still are.

Exercise 2: Column I Goal Survey

Summary of Jackson’s Survey Results

Jackson is interested in gaining greater visibility among senior management at XXX (names company) as a way to further his career. To do, he feels he needs get better at publicizing his accomplishments with senior management.

1. When you observe Jackson interacting with senior management, how often does Jackson take opportunities to publicize his accomplishments?

1 = Not at all

10 = All the time

Respondent Scores: 3, 3, 4, 5, 5, 5

Average (Mean) Score: 4.2

Self Score: 4

2. When you observe Jackson interacting with senior management about his accomplishments, to what extent does he communicate what he has accomplished effectively?

1 = Not at all

10 = To a great extent

Respondent Scores: 1, 2, 2, 3, 3, 4

Average (Mean) Score: 2.5

Self Score: 3

3. Comments: Please take a moment to expand on your answers to #1 and #2 to explain your answer, provide examples, or elaborate further:

- *He admits his accomplishments only when he is directly asked to report, and then he is pretty short, direct, too modest and humorous. He'll never get noticed this way.*
- *Jackson never lets them know the full extent of his talents and achievements. This contrasts sharply with others who tend to exaggerate. It also means that he gets overlooked when he shouldn't be.*
- *I have been telling him to do this for YEARS. I'm glad he is finally listening to me.*
- *Senior management knows that he has a great reputation with colleagues and those who work for him. But they don't really know why everyone likes him so much. Jackson needs to let them know!*
- *Jackson always makes decisions with XXX (the company's) interest in mind – but it's a well-kept secret.*
- *He's too much a team player. I watch Jackson allow others to take center stage, while he acts like they should be receiving praise and accolades. It makes me angry because then the ones who don't deserve this recognition continue to get it. Jackson, make them get out of your way! And not just by telling a joke!*
- *I understand this kind of thing (praise) makes him uncomfortable, and I worry that he is getting passed by.*
- *Jackson has a great sense of humor, but he lets the jokes get in the way of his message.*

4. Do you think this is the right area for Jackson to be working on:

1 = Not at all

10 = Yes

Respondent Scores: 8, 8, 9, 9, 9, 10

Average (Mean) Score: 8.8

Self Score: 9

5. If this is not the area you think Jackson should be working on, what alternatives would you suggest?
 - *If Jackson gets better at this, he should be senior management in 2-3 years.*
 - *This would complete the picture – he does everything else well.*
 - *I hope he does work on this!*
 - *I think he could also be gaining more international experience if he took a larger role in (names project).*

Reflecting on Your Survey Data

Your workspace: Consider the data *in the context of your most recently revised immunity map*.

Reflection Question	Your Response
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 1 commitment? (i.e., do the results suggest that you have targeted a powerful Column 1 commitment?)	Yes
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 2 behaviors? (i.e., are there additional Column 2 behaviors to add to your map?)	Yes. 3 respondents noted that I am too self-deprecating, which they seem to think is fine with anyone BUT senior management. One person noted that I am “too much a team player.” One person said that I appear “uncomfortable with praise.”
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Big Assumption?	Well, nobody sent out warnings about me getting too arrogant or blind to my faults. That surprised me. I wonder if because they know me, they would be less likely to see me that way, even if my behavior changed. It could also be that I am particularly sensitive to seeing self-promotion as bragging, and others don’t feel like that danger is always lurking nearby. Or they don’t care – that bragging is sort of normal in modern American business life, perhaps. Makes me realize how my own train of thought may be very unique to me in a way I hadn’t really considered before. Huh! I was also kind of impressed that they seem pretty generous in their estimations of my work and how high they think I could go at XXX. Makes me realize that maybe I’ve been assuming that I’ve almost maxed out my potential.

Reflection Question	Your Response
Compare your responses with those of your respondents: ☐ What's similar? ☐ Where are the differences? ☐ What's your take on those differences?	Similarities: Using humor as a defense, as easy-out. Differences: They like me more than I do? (ha ha)
What are your "take-aways" from thinking about this data?	What should be the limits of my ambitions? Who do I want to be when I grow up? There may be a connection between my distaste for self-promotion and my hesitancy to be ambitious in thinking about my long-term career goals.

Jackson's Notes to His Coach:

Added at time of completing survey

Decided to ask mom what she remembered about how Kurt and I got along as kids. She was really surprised I asked. She told me lots of stuff from when we were really little. Apparently we played together quite well then. When I asked her what she remembered from later years, high school particularly, she said something like, "Well, you were each doing more of your own things then. You played the piano, and Kurt was always involved in sports." But she also remembered things we had done together – like going to baseball games, helping dad with household projects, watching Saturday cartoons. I don't remember that stuff as much.

I did take a look at the Biography exercise you sent and have started to make some notes.

You asked me if I have made Kurt more one-dimensional in my mind than he really was. After talking with my mom, I realize that I think I have done that and probably do it with the guys at work who seem so arrogant and quick to toot their own horns.

Exercise 3: Continuum of Progress

Your workspace:

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
To get better at publicizing my accomplishments with senior management. <i>I assume that saying anything about my accomplishments is bragging. I assume that if I am bragging, I am just like Kurt (also selfish, arrogant, etc.).</i> <i>I assume that if I publicize my successes, I'll believe what I say.</i>	I request that my annual performance review be rescheduled. In the review conversation, I can talk confidently and assertively about my skills and accomplishments. I will strike the right tone so that I am not bragging or being arrogant. I am nervous about doing more self-publicity, but I don't let that feeling prevent me from doing it. I watch for occasions when I could do more self-publicizing than I do now. I look for examples of other people here who can self-publicize (in ways that don't strike me as bragging or arrogant.) <i>I reflect on key incidents where I back off to see if I have made a snap judgment about how the other person is responding to my self-promotion efforts.</i>	I keep senior management updated on my skills and accomplishments—especially when I think I have done something (or can do something) that would be worthy of a raise or promotion. I know how to prepare myself (and manage my feelings) so that I can self-publicize when opportunities present themselves. I have a repertoire of ways to word things so I can accurately describe my skills and accomplishments in ways that strike the tone that I am after. <i>I develop some strategies (e.g., ask if we can take stock of where we are in the conversation, ask them if they are on board, etc.) so that instead of assuming I know what the other person is thinking and backing off, I can check to see what they are thinking.</i>	→ I don't have to work so hard to identify opportunities to self-publicize. I can self-publicize without having to prepare or manage my feelings. I don't mind self-publicizing. I can actually enjoy communicating to others what I can do and have done. <i>I use these strategies automatically, without having to be so conscious of overriding my inclination to back off.</i> <i>All added after conducting test #1</i>

Jackson's Notes to His Coach:

More and more, I'm starting to see that my own tendencies to see self-promotion as bragging are pretty unique to me, that I am so quick to be critical of others who are self-promoting. I know there are a couple of colleagues whose opinions I trust who tend to see these things similarly, but now that I really look for it, I think they are much more forgiving than I am.

Spontaneous observations

Yesterday, I was at a meeting, and one guy was selling himself pretty energetically. I immediately started forming a negative opinion of him, thinking he was a jerk and opportunistic, kind of looking for any ways that I might disagree with him. I started looking around to see if I could gauge how others were reacting to him. After the meeting was over, I ran into Emily and asked her what her impression of him was. She said she thought he had some pretty interesting ideas, although she didn't know much about the area he was discussing. I then asked if she thought he was over-selling. She paused, thinking. Then she said that maybe he was, but I could see it hadn't really occurred to her before I asked. Makes me see how much energy I spend focusing on that, and how once I decided he was bragging, I decided not to like him and discounted everything he was saying.

Exercise 4: Observing the Big Assumption in Action & Observing Natural Challenges to the Big Assumption

Your workspace:

Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way	Describe costs to you ("What did it block, prevent or impair?")
Situation #1: I had lunch with some clients last week. Two pretty senior guys from XXX were at the lunch too. After the lunch, I could have found a way to walk back over to our building with the two guys – to talk casually with them and let them know what I have been doing for these clients. I hung back and didn't take that opportunity. I let them go ahead while I used the restroom, made some calls. I figure they don't want to be bothered, would see through my comments to find what I was doing to be bragging and pestering.	Situation #1: I missed an opportunity for them to hear what I have been doing.

Your workspace continued:

Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way	Describe costs to you ("What did it block, prevent or impair?")
Situation #2: Colleague who is generally assumed to be on the fast track here told me that he keeps a list of things he wants key people (like senior management) to know about. He updates the list regularly, and reviews it every Friday. Then he makes a plan for how during the following week he is going to let key people know about what's on the list. This kind of thing would never occur to me.	Situation #2: Well, I guess that's why he is on the fast track and I'm not!
Situation #3: My wife asked me why I don't read or go to a training on self-promotion. I dismissed this idea immediately.	Situation #3: I could have learned some new skills and strategies.

Reflection Question	Your Response
What stands out to you? What do you notice most of all?	It takes a lot of work for me to identify opportunities I don't take. Even when they occur to me, I have a really hard time imagining myself doing them.
What does your BA do to you? What thoughts, feelings, perspectives, actions, and choices do you experience as a consequence of your BA?	It keeps me from having to make myself uncomfortable, from worrying that I'm annoying other people and myself.
Do you see patterns, i.e., are there particular types of people, content areas, circumstances (inside yourself or in the environment) that activate your Big Assumption?	Senior management. Self-promoters.
Any "ah ha"?	I tend to notice (and think about) self-promotion as always done in a way that is bragging, arrogant. I don't pay attention to situations where it is done more skillfully.
Do you notice any additional Big Assumptions you are making? If so, add these to your 4-column map.	Self-promotion = bragging, arrogance. Other people also hate to see people engage in self-promotion (even though I can clearly see how self-promotion can pay off for others.) I've been calling that one into question since reading my survey results.
What are your key take-aways? Any implications for your Continuum of Progress? If so, add these.	

Your workspace:

Describe situation that casts doubt on your Big Assumption (including your thoughts & feelings)	How does what happened cast doubt on the absolute truth of your Big Assumption?
Counter Observation #1: There are a few people who do publicize their accomplishments in ways that seem much more elegant and classy. They seem to have a really good sense of when is the right time to do this. Mostly they seem to do it in very matter-of-fact ways – they don't get embarrassed to talk about (or have others talk about) what they did.	Counter Observation #1: I need to watch more carefully what they do and how they do it. Maybe talk to them about how they developed this approach.

Reflection Question	Your Response
What stands out to you? What do you notice most of all?	I haven't been looking for instances of when self-publicity is done well. It's like I don't even see it because I'm focusing so much on the bad things.
What thoughts, feelings, perspectives, actions, and choices did you experience in these instances?	
Do you see any patterns? Is the same doubt about your BA raised across the different instances? Is there anything in common across the examples that might account for the counter-data? (e.g., particular types of people, content areas, circumstances, inside yourself or in the environment).	I've been so focused on what I don't like and don't want to do that I haven't paid attention to what I could be doing better/instead.
Did you act differently than your Big Assumption would have you act? If so, what did you do? What are your hunches about why you acted differently? Was it because of something "out there," or something you said to yourself, or some combination of the two, or anything else?	
What does the counter-data suggest to you about your Big Assumption?	I don't see counter-data! I thought I was working hard to find instances of it, but I have probably been missing tons (and mostly counter-examples.)
What are your key take-aways? Are there any additions or revisions you'd want to make to your CoP based on these observations?	Add that I should be actively observing for when others publicize their accomplishments in ways I'd like to try on.

Jackson's Notes to His Coach:

After our last conversation, I added a new Big Assumption to my map: Other people also hate to see people engage in self-promotion. I can really see now, that that is probably not so true.

Writing the Biography of the Big Assumption

Events (the headlines)	What I was thinking (at that time)	What I was feeling (at that time)	Lessons learned/con- clusions drawn (at that time)
1. (Age 6-16) Kurt and I are close in age and are often compared to each other within the family and by others. Kurt is very smart, charismatic, athletic. He likes showing people what he has done/ can do. I constantly hear from people about how talented Kurt is.	I am not talented. I should be more like Kurt. I am a disappointment. People expect more from me.	I am not worth very much.	If I can't be more like Kurt, I should hide and hope no one will notice me or my mediocrity.
2. (Age 14) Our family moves out of state. Kurt is quick to make new friends in school, to join new clubs, sports teams. It takes me a long time to make new friends. I wish Kurt would include me more in what he does but I never ask.	I understand this means that I am unlikeable to many people. I don't want Kurt to see how unlikeable I am.	I feel like I have character flaws that I cannot control. I don't like myself. I also don't like Kurt because I don't think he deserves to have everything come so easily.	I cannot change myself and yet I feel like I should hide. I shouldn't want more than I am likely to get. I don't want anyone (especially Kurt) to see that I want what he has because I could never get that.
3. (Age 15) My best friend Jim and I get caught cheating on a test. Jim is expelled from the "honors" classes and enrolled in "regular" courses. I remain in the honors classes because I don't have a reputation for being a trouble-maker like Jim has.	I know I was just as responsible for the cheating as Jim was, but I am afraid to tell anyone that.	I feel bad/guilty, like Jim thinks I'm a bad or immoral person. I wonder if I am.	I am not punished because I hide (while Jim doesn't.) Continuing to hide by not taking responsibility for what I did too is the best strategy. I am a coward, but it is the safe way to be.

REFLECTIONS ON “THE BIOGRAPHY OF THE BIG ASSUMPTION”

Reflection Question	Your Response
In what ways does the biography (or biographic moment) explain your Big Assumption?	
Does your biography (or biographic moment) illuminate any additional Big Assumptions you might be making? Do you notice any definitive, i.e., this- always-happens, quality?	
To what extent do you believe and feel the situation or events from your biography (or biographic moment) apply to your current life? If you think they do, how so?	I had forgotten about the Jim/cheating incident until I started filling this out... seems powerfully related to me now. I can also see how I developed a whole personality around being the guy who doesn't stand out and sort of trying to claim that as cool. Looking back in this way, I see how much I didn't think it was cool at all.

Jackson's Notes to His Coach:

This was a really useful exercise to do. I've been thinking about it since I started my map but putting it all in writing helped me see it all more clearly. Actually, looking at what I remember, I was surprised there weren't more traumatic events. I feel like I just fixated so much on these issues with Kurt they became bigger than they actually were.

My wife showed me a website she found that has some tools to help people develop effective ways of promoting their work. I haven't had the chance to explore it much, but I see that there are also workshops you can attend where they will work with you to develop your skills. Maybe worth looking into.

Planting seeds for Tests

I have been paying attention to people at work who seem skilled at self-promotion. One big thing I notice – that they seem more excited about *the thing* they are talking about and not focusing really on *themselves*. They just seem genuinely excited by what they are working on, and that excitement is contagious. I realize I don't know if they are intentionally doing this or not. Maybe they just love what they do. But I think at least sometimes, they must be deliberately promoting an idea... Not sure. Something to keep exploring.

Exercise 6: Designing a Test of Your Big Assumption

My Big Assumption Says...	So I will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I will plan what I want to say to my boss about the difficulties we faced (and overcame) in the [work we did with client X]. I will frame this report to focus on what we learned in overcoming these obstacles without minimizing or misrepresenting my role in doing so.	Can I plan what to say that will strike the right tone? How well do I say what I have planned? How does my boss respond to my report? How do others respond to my report? Is there anyone to whom you'd like to give a "heads-up" or ask to serve as an observer who can give you feedback after the fact? Larissa, my good friend, shares my distaste for bragging and self-aggrandizement. She'll be at the meeting.	I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting embarrassed.

CRITERIA	YES	NOT SURE
Is it safe? (If the worst case were to happen, you could live with the results.)	✓	
Is the data relevant to your Big Assumption?	✓	
Does it have face validity? (The test actually tests your Big Assumption.)	✓	
Are the data sources valid? (No one is either out to get you or wants to protect or save you.)	✓	
Might it "re-true" your Big Assumption? (Is it designed so that it surely will lead to bad consequences, just as your BA tells you? Are you setting yourself up to fail? Is there any data you could collect that could disconfirm your BA?)	NO	
Is it actionable in the near-term? (E.g., the people or situation you need in order to enact the test are available, you are reasonably certain you know how to do what you plan, and you can run the test within the next week or so.)	✓	

If you made any changes to your original test design based on our phone meeting, capture them here:

My Big Assumption Says...	So I will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, <u>foolish</u> . It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I will plan what I want to say to my boss about the difficulties we faced (and overcame) in the [work we did with client X]. I will frame this report to focus on what we learned in overcoming these obstacles without minimizing or misrepresenting my role in doing so. I'll let Larissa know what I'm up to, will rehearse with her, and will ask if she can observe the meeting. I will want her to watch for: how I came off (arrogant, etc.)? How was my tone? Did I back off?	Can I plan what to say that will strike the right tone – maintain the focus on the organizational learning while also conveying my own part/contributions? When I say what I have planned, do I feel like I maintain that desired tone and focus? What else do I notice about how it went? How does my boss respond to my report? (Does he get impatient, wave me on to suggest I get to the point, lose eye contact, get distracted...?) How do others (e.g., Larissa) respond to the things I've asked her to look for?	I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting embarrassed.

Exercise 7: Running and Interpreting Your Test

My Big Assumption Says...	So in order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I told my boss about the difficulties we faced (and overcame) in the [work we did with client X] – relying pretty much on what I had planned – focusing on what we learned in overcoming these obstacles. For most of it, I didn't minimize or misrepresent my role, with one exception. The exception: after I was done, and my boss began to ask me a couple of questions, I played up others' roles in the process, maybe more than I wished (or was accurate.) I think I was feeling nervous.	For the most part, I think I did strike the right tone and stayed focused, mostly because I was talking from my notes. I think I did get a little embarrassed at the end, when I was going more off-script. I started talking about how hard everyone had worked, and I felt like I was watching myself do that and thinking, "Now you sound like somebody's cheerleader, going on and on about what others did." It made me realize that in addition to downplaying my own role, I may have a tendency to overplay others' roles when it is not necessary. Other than comments and questions about the content of what I said, my boss said things like, "OK. Good to know. Keep me in the loop. Good job." Not much more.	With proper planning, I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting (too) embarrassed. When I overplay others' contributions, it may sound over-the-top and be counter-productive.

continued

My Big Assumption Says...	So in order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
		Larissa was really enthusiastic about my report. She felt like I was still erring on the side of too much humility (which was a relief to me – baby steps). She agreed that my boss seemed pretty unfazed. Certainly not offended by any “bragging” on my part. She felt he could have been more supportive. She thought my backsliding comments about other team members were hilarious. (“You just can’t help yourself, can you? Are you really doing anyone any favors?”) She also felt that was maybe the only time when the boss seemed distracted. HM!	

Your workspace to design a next test:

My Big Assumption Says...	So I will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, foolish. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I will request that my boss schedule and complete my performance review. I will prepare my own responses to the review questions, again without minimizing or misrepresenting my role in doing so. I will focus on my own contributions – not others'. I will ask for a raise. I'll send my written plan to Larissa and role play the performance review conversation with her. I'll ask her to listen for whether or not I've taken the right tone and whether I maintain the focus on my role (or if I back off.)	Can I ask for the review to be rescheduled? Can I plan what to say that will strike the right tone – to convey the range and value of my contributions without sounding arrogant? When I say what I have planned, do I feel like I maintain that desired tone and focus? Can I keep the focus on me? What else do I notice about how it went? How does my boss respond to my own responses to the review questions? (Do I persuade him of my value and that I deserve the raise? Does he disagree with my own assessments? Does he agree with my own sense of my value?) How do others (e.g., Larissa) respond to the things I've asked her to look for?	I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, without bragging or getting embarrassed. If I do get embarrassed or flustered, do I default again to talking about others' contributions?

CRITERIA	YES	NOT SURE
Is it safe? (If the worst case were to happen, you could live with the results.)	✓	
Is the data relevant to your Big Assumption?		
Does it have face validity? (The test actually tests your Big Assumption.)	✓	
Are the data sources valid? (No one is either out to get you or wants to protect or save you.)	✓	
Might it “re-true” your Big Assumption? (Is it designed so that it surely will lead to bad consequences, just as your BA tells you? Are you setting yourself up to fail? Is there any data you could collect that could disconfirm your BA?)	NO	
Is it actionable in the near-term? (E.g., the people or situation you need in order to enact the test are available, you are reasonably certain you know how to do what you plan, and you can run the test within the next week or so.)	✓	

Your workspace to report on test #2, what happened and how you make sense of that:

My Big Assumption Says...	So in order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, <u>foolish</u> . It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	I did request that my performance review be rescheduled and completed. We just had it last week. I prepared my own responses to the review questions, again without minimizing or misrepresenting my role in doing so. In the review conversation I kept the focus on my own contributions – not others'.	It went really well! I was worried that my boss would tell me we were too busy to do the review at this time, but he actually rescheduled it right away and apologized that we hadn't done it sooner. I was nervous before we actually met, but it helped to have some reminders. I think that also helped me make sure I was really prepared with what to say and how to say it.	I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, but I'm still looking for escape hatches that may be undermining my progress! I can see that the real danger comes when I make snap judgments (without good data) about how the other person is responding to me. This is what I need to keep working on, how to make sure I don't get hooked by my BAs when I don't even know they're there!

My Big Assumption Says...	So in order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that I can't publicize successes skillfully – other people will view me as clumsy, silly, inept, <u>foolish</u>. It will have the opposite effect from what I intend.	The only time I got nervous was before the conversation started. I remembered to take a deep breath and remind myself that I am not doing anyone favors when I overplay others' contributions. I also imagined that I was not actually talking about myself but about someone else – a colleague I respect, admire, and want to support. I did ask for a raise. I did not actually say what I had planned. I'd discussed my written plan with Larissa, and we did role play the performance review conversation. I asked her to listen for whether or not I took the right tone and whether I maintained the focus on my role (or if I back off).	In the conversation itself, my boss as really apologetic again. He basically agreed with everything I said, nodding his head and offering no arguments. I did NOT check in with him to see what his silent nodding meant – was he in total agreement? Was he impatient, thinking I was overstating my case? Was he in basic agreement but curious to hear more (with the more elaborate detail than I actually gave)? I shortened some of the points I wanted to make because I convinced myself it was unnecessary to elaborate further. The hardest part of the whole thing was doing the preparation with Larissa. I felt most embarrassed with her – during the role play – because I was much more self-conscious. I knew she was looking for any signs of weakness. I think I should have said something to her about that, so we could have talked about what would help me feel like the role play wasn't an examination.	I can find more skillful ways to make my own contributions clear, but I'm still looking for escape hatches that may be undermining my progress! I can see that the real danger comes when I make snap judgments (without good data) about how the other person is responding to me. This is what I need to keep working on, how to make sure I don't get hooked by my BAs when I don't even know they're there! If I do get embarrassed or flustered, I don't need to default again to talking about others' contributions.

Jackson's Notes to His Coach:

[Return to COP](#)

We talked about how I make snap judgments (without good data) about how the other person is responding to me, and as you suggested, I went back to my COP to make some additions:

First Step Forward: I reflect on key incidents where I back off to see if I have made a snap judgment about how the other person is responding to my self-promotion efforts.

Significant Progress: I develop some strategies (e.g., ask if we can take stock of where we are in the conversation, ask them if they are on board, etc.) so that instead of assuming I know what the other person is thinking and backing off, I can check to see what they are thinking.

Full Success: I use these strategies automatically, without having to be so conscious of overriding my inclination to back off.

What do you think?

Exercise 8: Taking Stock

Your workspace:

Reflection Question	Your Response
Where do you see yourself in the sequence at this time?	Somewhere between consciously immune and consciously released.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your Big Assumption is <i>valid</i> ? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	I'm sure there are situations in which I could go self-publicize in a way that I see (and others see) as clearly bragging. I guess it's possible I could get to the place where I believe what I say. But, I've also learned that I am much more likely to feel like self-publicity is bragging than others are. I am much more focused on that problem than most others are. Most people just seem to take it for granted that is the way things work. Even other people like Larissa who notice bragging seem like they are much more forgiving of it than I am.

continued

Reflection Question	Your Response
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your Big Assumption is <i>invalid</i>? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	I'm sure there are situations in which I could go self-publicize in a way that I see (and others see) as clearly bragging. I guess it's possible I could get to the place where I believe what I say. But, I've also learned that I am much more likely to feel like self-publicity is bragging than others are. I seem to be much more focused on that problem than most others are. Most people just seem to take it for granted that is the way things work. Even other people like Larissa who notice bragging seem like they are much more forgiving of it than I am.
Do you find your BA asserting itself in situations you know it ought not? If so, do you have any generalizations about the conditions under which you are likely (more or less) to find yourself being sucked into the old patterns associated with the BA? What still sometimes hooks you?	I think I still need to work on keeping them in the front of my mind. When I let them slip from there, I tend to think and act business-as-usual and don't actively look for (or try out) anything that contradicts my ingrained ideas about bragging.
Are there key “releases” (i.e., self-talk that unhooks you) you have developed and can use to help yourself easily and readily when you are facing your Big Assumption in real-time?	Reminders: • Preparation. • Imagining how others (who are good at self-promotion) would handle a situation. • Knowing that I shouldn't rely on my own brag-o-meter to tell me if I'm doing enough/too much. I have been assuming that what seems like bragging to me is the same as what others see as bragging... and that this is not true!
To what extent/how often can you use these “releases” to help you from being pulled into old patterns?	We'll see! Plans for future tests: • Read/attend workshops on how to do self-promotion. • Watch and learn from those around me who do this well. • Watch for opportunities and take them.
Have you developed new behaviors or ways of talking to yourself in situations that used to activate your Big Assumption?	• Be direct. • Say what I intended to say. • Ask for feedback. • Still want to work on developing by repertoire of what to say.

continued

Reflection Question	Your Response
Think about situations in which you think your BA is no longer accurate. What new beliefs or understandings do you hold about “how things work” or what will happen in these situations?	The clearest examples to me of when my BA is not accurate are when I see others who self-promote pretty well. What I notice most is that not only does this type of thing seem like it isn’t bragging, it doesn’t even always seem like self-promotion!
How would you rate your progress toward achieving your Column 1 goal? Has your understanding of or relationship to that goal changed in important ways?	I have wanted senior management to see more clearly my contributions to this organization, and I see that my role in that is to be able to promote myself skillfully. I see that happening now – both that I am better at self-promotion and that senior management is responding to that. What drove me to identify my goal was resentment I was feeling that I wasn’t getting what I deserved. I don’t have that resentment now – I feel much more optimistic now. In many ways, I actually feel more powerful, although that isn’t what I set out to do.

Appendix B:

Amanda's Workbook

A WORKBOOK FOR Amanda

OVERCOMING THE IMMUNITY TO CHANGE

Exercise 1: Honing Your Immunity Map

Version 1

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
To get thin and healthy.	I don't follow diets carefully. I eat when I'm stressed or feeling down. I don't go to the gym (bad weather, too tired, too busy, etc.) I drink beer before, during, and after dinner. I eat for rewards. I think that I inherited these problems.	Fears: rules, trapped, inconvenienced, annoyed, bleak. I am committed to freedom. I am committed to rewarding myself.	I assume that if I don't have freedom, what's the point? I assume that if I don't reward myself, I'll be unhappy.

Version 2

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
To develop healthier eating habits. To lose 25 pounds thereby lowering my blood pressure and improving my cholesterol.	I don't count calories. I don't stick to diets. I eat when I'm stressed or feeling down. I use any excuse not to go to the gym (bad weather, too tired, too busy, etc.) I drink beer before, during, and after dinner. I use food and drink as rewards.	Fears – having to follow rules, feeling trapped, inconvenienced and annoyed by diet. Embarrassment that others will know I care about this stuff. That my life will be bleak. I am committed to always feeling the freedom of having lots of options, making my own decisions, not having to follow someone else's rules.	I assume that if I don't have lots of options, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak. I assume that if I don't reward myself with food or drink, then I will be less motivated at work and in my personal life.

Version 2 continued

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
	I tell myself that I can't change my habits or get thin, and probably can't improve my numbers (blood pressure, cholesterol) much because I inherited these problems.	I am committed to rewarding myself, getting what I deserve. Not admitting that the implications on my health are as bad as they might actually be.	I assume that if I were to take seriously the fact that my health is not great, I'll become depressed and maybe act in ways that are even more unhealthy. I assume that if my diet isn't going well, I should get mad at others who "make me" report to them. I assume that special occasions are times when we reward ourselves to show ourselves love and for others to reward us to show us they love us. I assume that we give those rewards through special food.

Coach's Notes for Amanda:

Amanda,

Coach introduces testing

As we discussed, the focus of your health club's dieting program is on behavior changes. From an ITC perspective, it's unusual, as we talked about, to begin testing the Big Assumptions so early in the process. But since you are ready to alter your behavior as part of that program, let's make sure that we tie that to what we're doing: the key is to be looking for what your efforts to change your behavior can tell you about your Big Assumptions. We talked about 3 specific behaviors your program asks you to do:

- Writing down everything you eat.
- Weigh yourself regularly.
- Drink more water.

Each of these behavior changes has some potential to trigger your Big Assumption that you don't feel like you have lots of options (in that you feel like you are following someone else's rules for how you should live.) So, we talked about the ways you can be reminding yourself that you are doing these things on behalf of your own goals, the choices you hope to be making for yourself. We also talked about the first two behavior changes as a type of feedback on the effects of the choices you are making. They give you information about what and how much you are choosing to eat (or not), as well as related other choices (such as exercise.)

And, I just want to remind you that the point of testing isn't to see whether you can successfully make these behavior changes, although I know that you are really motivated to make them. The biggest point is to see what we learn about your assumptions as you are working on changing your behaviors. And we hope to learn quite a bit!

Exercise 2: Column I Goal Survey

Amanda is committed to improving her health. She intends to do this by developing healthier eating habits.

1. To what extent do you observe Amanda eating in ways you would consider healthy?

1 = Rarely eating healthily

10 = Always eating healthily

Respondent Scores: 2, 4, 5, 5, 7, 7

Average (Mean) Score: 5

Self Score: 3

2. When you observe Amanda eating, to what extent does she choose unhealthy foods to eat?

1 = Rarely eating healthy foods

10 = Always eating healthy foods

Respondent Scores: 4, 4, 7, 7, 8, 9

Average (Mean) Score: 6.5

Self Score: 4

3. When you observe Amanda eating, to what extent does she eat too much food?

1 = Rarely eating too much food

10 = Always eating too much food

Respondent Scores: 3, 3, 3, 4, 7, 8

Average (Mean) Score: 4.7

Self Score: 8

4. Please provide some specific examples of what Amanda typically eats and how much she typically eats:
 - *Normal food – take-out from local restaurants. I guess she eats what they give her, one serving.*
 - *I don't see her every day. At family gatherings, she seems to eat a regular amount. Maybe snacks too much? Too many sweets?*
 - *She usually eats better than I do – eats more vegetables, salads, and fruits than I do. And she eats less. But because I am a man, I'm not sure how much women are supposed to eat.*
 - *I don't really notice (N=2).*
5. If improving her eating habits is NOT the most important area you think Amanda should be working on to improve her health, **what alternative suggestions do you have?**
 - *She's fine.*
 - *You can do it, Amanda!*
 - *Well, I guess more exercise would be the logical thing.*

Reflecting on Your Survey Data

Your workspace: Consider the data *in the context of your most recently revised immunity map*.

Reflection Question	Your Response
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 1 commitment? (i.e., do the results suggest that you have targeted a powerful column 1 commitment?)	It is very powerful to me, but I can see that others don't really care about it. If I want them to support me in changing my habits, I'm going to need to be really clear with them about why this is important to me so that they can help.
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 2 behaviors? (i.e., are there additional Column 2 behaviors to add to your map?)	I guess that they are normal things lots of people do. That tells me that maybe the people around me don't have healthy habits either, or else maybe they are not paying much attention to what I eat. Maybe I eat stuff sort of secretly, and so they don't know about it? Their answers make sense to me because I often feel like I eat the way others do, so why am I fat if they're not?

Your workspace continued

Reflection Question	Your Response
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Big Assumption?	Maybe part of the reason I feel like I deserve food is because I see what others eat and feel like I should have that too. I'm as deserving as they are. (Add to map: I assume that I should be able to eat what others eat and look the way they do. I assume that they all don't have to think about what they eat at all and don't have any negative results from bad habits.)
Compare your responses with those of your respondents. - What's similar? - Where are the differences? - What's your take on those differences?	I think I'm harder on myself than they are.
What are your "take-aways" from thinking about this data?	If I want others to support me, I'm going to have to be really clear with them about how they can help. I also realize that I have been jumping to conclusions (assuming) that I know what (and how much) they eat, and whether they have health issues or not – even though I don't really know this.

Coach's Notes for Amanda:

Coach checks in on informal testing

We also spoke about how your tests are going. You have worked hard to do the three things we talked about last time (writing down what you eat, weighing yourself regularly, and drinking more water), while engaging in self-talk about how these are all things you are choosing to do and things that give you information about your food/lifestyle choices. You did do each of the three things more often than you would normally, although you found it was easy to forget since they haven't become habits for you yet. **Most importantly, you were trying to pay attention to when and how your BA might get triggered.**

We talked about a couple of things you noticed from your tests:

1. Making a change in your behavior will probably feel harder (and more like an "assignment") when you are trying to break old habits and/or develop new ones. We expect

that the more these behaviors become routine, the less you'll resist them. That will be interesting to test.

2. You feel more energy, optimism, and sense of choice in the morning than you do later in the day. So, you plan to make sure to weigh yourself in the morning and to drink lots of water then (and make sure your pitcher is always pretty full.)
3. You have been starting to lose some weight – 3 pounds! You said that makes it easier to get on the scale, but that you didn't weigh yourself after times when you know that you had eaten a lot. So, that's also a good thing to be aware of. You said that on those mornings, you felt like "someone in your head" was scolding you. You imagined your diet counselor getting mad at you, and maybe I was getting mad at you too. After we talked about that for a bit, you said, "Having people I report to helps. It keeps me more disciplined than I would be on my own. But then if my diet isn't going well, I get mad too for waiting to report to them." We talked about this as an additional BA (even though you know this diet is for you, not for your diet counselor or for me) and how you might think differently about this issue, so that you are clear that you are working on your **goals**. And we decided that you won't tell me (and I won't ask) whether/how much weight you have lost or gained since our last meeting. You also decided to tell your diet counselor how you felt about reporting to her so that the two of you could figure out how to address the issue.

Exercise 3: Continuum of Progress

Your workspace:

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
To develop healthier eating habits. To lose 25 pounds thereby lowering my blood pressure and improving my cholesterol. I assume that if I don't have lots of options, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	Keep a record of everything I eat and drink. Drink 8 glasses of water per day. Weigh myself regularly. Switch to lite beer. Keep a record about when I want to eat stuff I shouldn't, when it feels good to eat right.	Follow WW plan as closely as I can, making choices within their guidelines. Keep lots of healthy foods on-hand to choose from at home. Have lots of ideas for healthy "to go" meals for work days. Or bring healthy meal from home.	→ Think of myself and feel like I am a healthy person. Think of my new eating habits as a way of life to be maintained. Am easily able to get myself on track when/if I don't maintain healthy habits.

Your workspace continued

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
I assume that if I don't reward myself with food or drink, then I will be less motivated at work and in my personal life. I assume that if I were to take seriously the fact that my health is not great, I'll become depressed and maybe act in ways that are even more unhealthy. I assume that I should be able to eat what others eat and look the way they do. I assume that they all don't have to think about what they eat at all and don't have any negative results from bad habits. I assume that I know what (and how much) they eat, and whether they have health issues or not – even though I don't really know this.	Read about the WW diet – note where I have choices. Go to the gym twice per week. Let others (esp. Josslyn) know what I'm working on and how they can help. Remind myself that I don't know what others eat when I'm not with them. I don't know what other health issues they may have. Remember my doctor's warnings and my mental image of what I will look and feel like if I lose weight. Forgive myself if I fall off the wagon but then get right back on it. I notice when I start to think of my diet as someone else's plan for me. I see how that thinking triggers my BA.	Develop and start to use strategies for keeping me on track and helping me get back on track if I screw up. Go to the gym four times per week. Feel good about how my body is getting stronger and healthier. Enjoy seeing changes when I look in the mirror or try on clothes. Stop comparing myself to other people. Track weight and cholesterol regularly. Develop and start to use other types of rewards that are healthier (e.g., massages, movie tickets, going dancing). Drink more of other types of drinks (like green tea or seltzer) instead of beer that will help me relax. I catch myself whenever I start to think of my diet as someone else's. I remind myself that I am the only one who should be angry when I don't make good choices. That anger feels good.	→ Go to the gym at least 4 times per week. This is built into my routine – I don't think about whether to go or not. I just go. I look forward to exercise and healthy eating because they make me feel good. I feel proud of how I look and feel. I regularly reward myself in healthy ways. I track my weight and cholesterol less frequently because numbers remain stable and low. I become a role model for others, showing them how to eat healthier. My goals and my decisions are all mine. I know that no one can make me eat something I don't want. No one can take that control from me. I only think about how others can help me reach my goals. I feel great about what I can do. <i>All added later from observations</i>

Coach's Notes for Amanda:

Foreshadows future tests as well as hooks and releases

We also talked about how you have started doing many of the things in your First Step Forward column already, and how important it has been for you to be working with Josslyn. Because the two of you are working together, you don't react to her support the same way that you have with your diet counselor and with me. So she can help keep you focused on your goals and choices without triggering your BA – that's great!

Exercise 4: Observing the Big Assumption in Action & Observing Natural Challenges to the Big Assumption

Your workspace:

Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way	Describe costs to you ("What did it block, prevent or impair?")
Situation #1: I've been trying to eat better, but whenever I go out with others, I want to order whatever I want. I want to have a beer or two, spend a long time catching up, order appetizers and/or desserts. I feel like if I can't eat what I want, I won't have as much fun.	Situation #1: I gained 2 pounds this week. I had fun while we were out, but then later I felt bad because I knew that I had messed up. I also felt too-full and too-buzzed, and I didn't like feeling that way.
Situation #2: When I get home from work, I'm really tired. I just want to put my feet up, watch TV, have a beer and a snack before getting up to make dinner. Sometimes I don't even feel like making dinner, so I'll just order out. The idea of getting home and not eating or starting to make just a healthy dinner and then going to the gym makes me too tired. I feel like I should be able to relax after a really hard day at work.	Situation #2: It gets me off track and then I give up. Once I start drinking and watching TV, I don't want to get up again. It's easier to order out. I don't eat very well and start to feel bad about myself that I can't do better. Then I give up and eat whatever I want, more than I should and things like dessert.

Your workspace continued

Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way	Describe costs to you ("What did it block, prevent or impair?")
Situation #3: My mom called me the other day because she is worried about my brother. She wants me to go over to her house and have dinner with her so we can talk. I want to go but I know I'll just eat a lot there. She doesn't really cook very healthy foods. But I can't tell her I don't want to go – she is already so stressed. I feel like I should be able to relax after a really hard day at work.	Situation #3: I mix food with other issues – I let my feelings about my mom control whether I eat with her and how much. Then I give up on my diet. I don't consider other ways I could help her – like going to talk but not eating with her, or asking her to help me eat healthier foods.
Situation #4: Yesterday I was really good. I didn't go out to lunch with co-workers, even though I really wanted to. I had brought a salad from home thought, which was in the fridge. I knew it would go bad if I didn't eat it. But it tasted pretty not-fresh. I felt hungry the rest of the day. Wished I could have gone with them and just ordered a salad at the restaurant. It would have tasted better!	Situation #4: I guess my BA got in my way in that I kind of dwelled on this and felt deprived. I felt like I didn't have choices, although I did make a choice, and there were probably different things I could have done.

Reflection Question	Your Response
What stands out to you? What do you notice most of all?	
What does your BA do to you? What thoughts, feelings, perspectives, actions, and choices do you experience as a consequence of your BA?	
Do you see patterns, i.e., are there particular types of people, content areas, circumstances (inside yourself or in the environment) that activate your Big Assumption?	
Any "ah ha"?	
Do you notice any additional Big Assumptions you are making? If so, add these to your 4-column map.	
What are your key take-aways? Any implications for your Continuum of Progress? If so, add these.	

Your workspace:

Describe situation that casts doubt on your Big Assumption (including your thoughts & feelings)	How does what happened cast doubt on the absolute truth of your Big Assumption?
Counter Observation #1: On Thursday I was really busy and didn't have time for a real lunch. I ate a quick and pretty healthy lunch at my desk while reading over Stan's report. I didn't feel terrible because I didn't have time to think about it. Maybe I need to get busier and more stressed! LOL!	Counter Observation #1: I didn't feel resentful, angry or stressed, even though I didn't have any good food options!
Counter Observation #2: I've been trying to go to the gym right after work (instead of going home first). It works as long as I remember to bring my gym clothes with me in the morning.	Counter Observation #2: OK – hard to remember to bring the clothes, esp. when I'm in a rush. Sometimes I forget that it's gym-time, and then when I remember, it's like, "Oh no!" I realize that I can change my familiar patterns and get used to a more active life without feeling like I am making a huge sacrifice.

Reflection Question	Your Response
What stands out to you? What do you notice most of all?	My life is pretty stressful. I use food and drink as a way to relieve stress. This may be more of what I'm used to doing and not something I need to do.
What thoughts, feelings, perspectives, actions, and choices did you experience in these instances?	I get annoyed when I think that I shouldn't eat or drink what I want and when I want. I focus my annoyance on other people or circumstances, as if someone else is doing something to me, not like it is me making that decision.
Do you see any patterns? Is the same doubt about your Big Assumption raised across the different instances? Is there anything in common across the examples that might account for the counter-data? (e.g., particular types of people, content areas, circumstances, inside yourself or in the environment).	Friends and family. Maybe certain times of day, when I'm tired. Having enough time free and the option to eat/drink. Getting into routines that aren't healthy – they are harder to break because it is easiest just to keep going with them.
Did you act differently than your Big Assumption would have you act? If so, what did you do? What are your hunches about why you acted differently? Was it because of something "out there," or something you said to yourself, or some combination of the two, or anything else?	I need to remind myself that I make my own choices!

Your workspace continued

Reflection Question	Your Response
What does the counter-data suggest to you about your Big Assumption?	I assume that other people (WW), are trying to make me stay on my diet. They don't understand my situation. They don't see how busy and stressed I am. OK – this is ridiculous, but it's true too. I assume that I deserve to keep my routines – something like that. Need to keep thinking about this one.
What are your key take-aways? Are there any additions or revisions you'd want to make to your Continuum of Progress based on these observations?	It is hard to diet when I'm stressed! I see my decisions to eat or not as my choices. To stay on my diet is my choice. To go off my diet is my choice, NO ONE ELSE'S!!!!

Coach's Notes for Amanda:

It has been a hard few weeks for you in that you haven't seen the results yet that you had hoped for despite the fact that you feel like you are working so hard. We also talked about it being hard that Josslyn seems to be losing weight very quickly, and it is difficult not to compare yourself with her.

Connects back to the Continuum of Progress

But, one place where you and I are both seeing noticeable progress is in your self-talk – staying focused on the idea that your health goals are yours and are about the choices you make and would like to make for yourself. When you start to blame others or get mad at them, you can now catch yourself and remind yourself that no one is doing this to you. At the end of our meeting, you said, “It’s funny. I haven’t been doing that well so far. But I’m more annoyed about this than you are. **You** have been making **me** feel better. I like that because it shows me this is **MY WORK**.”

We decided to make sure we explore the implications for this for your Continuum of Progress.

Writing the Biography of the Big Assumption:

Your workspace:

“I assume that if I don’t have lots of options, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.”

“I assume that if I don’t reward myself with food or drink, then I will be less motivated at work and in my personal life.”

Biography

- Growing up, my family always made food important. We ate big meals together, and if you ate everything on your plate, you got dessert. My mom always made really yummy desserts, so everyone wanted to make sure to get one. I saw dessert as a reward, and thought of eating to feel good about myself and to enjoy being with others.
- I remember my family always saying proudly that I was a good eater – not picky like my brother. I liked to please my parents, so I liked that they saw me as good at something. The more people praised me for eating, the more I liked eating. Eating became a way to feel good about myself.
- When I was little, my parents used to give lots of parties, and it was the kids’ job to pass around hors d’oeuvres. I remember my mom giving me specific instructions – that I shouldn’t interrupt conversations that people should barely notice I was there. They should just feel like delicious food is always appearing right at their elbows. Your reflection – “and I guess I learned that is the ideal way to experience food – not to think about it but to always have something delicious I could keep putting in my mouth!”
- I started gaining weight in college. I didn’t like the food in the cafeteria, but I think I ate more of it than I did at home! I liked to eat with my friends and take a break from studying by ordering pizza or making popcorn. I also started going to parties and happy hours and started liking to drink beer. I also started going on diets for the first time. I would starve myself on the weekdays so I could eat whatever I wanted and party on the weekends. I hated the end of the weekend, and every Sunday night I would stuff myself because I knew that the next day I could only eat toast or something. I would say it was my “farewell to food.” I saw two choices: eat lots and lots and have fun or eat almost nothing and feel deprived. Nothing in between. The less I ate during the week, the more I could eat during the weekend. And vice versa.

Amanda adds after debriefing test #2

- I gained weight after college too, but not too much. It wasn't until I started having kids that the weight really came on. I felt like being pregnant meant I could eat anything, and then the weight would just come off after that. But it didn't, and having little babies made it really hard to diet. My mom told me the same thing happened to her. At first I just kind of thought oh well, I'm married, who cares if I get fat? But then my doctor started getting on me to lose, and some of my girlfriends have stayed thin, and my husband makes some comments sometimes about how I don't want to do anything but sit on the couch. So I keep trying, but it's really hard to do now! I remember how easy it was when I was younger! I was thinking like being on a diet took so much energy, was hard work, starting feeling like I didn't have any extra energy or motivation to diet. I felt like I was giving all my energy to work and family and didn't see any extra that would keep me on a diet. I also started feeling like being thin only mattered in terms of attracting people, and since I was married it didn't matter if I wasn't.

REFLECTIONS ON “THE BIOGRAPHY OF THE BIG ASSUMPTION”

Reflection Question	Your Response
In what ways does the biography (or biographic moment) explain your Big Assumption?	It tells me how it came to be in my life and shaped me. I see eating and feeling good as the same thing because that's how my family taught me. I also developed some unhealthy ideas about how to lose weight or keep weight off that only made my habits worse. Made me even more likely to want to eat as much as I could, all the time. Ugh! I wish I knew then how it would turn out...
Does your biography (or biographic moment) illuminate any additional Big Assumptions you might be making? Do you notice any definitive, i.e., this- always-happens, quality?	My diets were so strict that I would always fail at them. Actually the way I thought of them is that they always would fail – at the end of the week. Diets were never a different way to eat every day. (Potential BA: Changing your eating habits by going on a diet is a temporary, drastic change and not a long-term way to change your lifestyle.)
To what extent do you believe and feel the situation or events from your biography (or biographic moment) apply to your current life? If you think they do, how so?	I still feel like eating and drinking are part of the best things in life. I also still feel like I need to eat and drink a lot when I'm with family and friends if I'm going to have a good time, and if other people are going to have fun too. If I don't eat, it's like, “what's with her?” Even my husband says this to me, even though he wants me to lose weight.

Coach's Notes for Amanda:

Hi Amanda – I see you included the new additions we discussed to your COP!

Exercise 6: Designing a Test of Your Big Assumption

Your workspace:

My Big Assumption Says...	So I will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	When I go to the holiday party, I will survey the buffet and make a conscious choice about what foods I will allow myself to eat and how much. I will allow myself one beer or glass of wine.	Do I feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed? Did I enjoy the party? Did I enjoy what I ate and drank? Did I enjoy other parts of the party (met new people I liked, had interesting conversations, etc.)? Is there anyone to whom you'd like to give a "heads-up" or ask to serve as an observer who can give you feedback after the fact? Josslyn – who has been my ITC partner, is working on similar issues, will also be at the party. She will observe whether I can effectively change my behavior.	I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, stressed. I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

CRITERIA	YES	NOT SURE
Is it safe? (If the worst case were to happen, you could live with the results.)	✓	
Is the data relevant to your Big Assumption?	✓	
Does it have face validity? (The test actually tests your Big Assumption.)	✓	
Are the data sources valid? (No one is either out to get you or wants to protect or save you.)	✓	
Might it “re-true” your Big Assumption? (Is it designed so that it surely will lead to bad consequences, just as your BA tells you? Are you setting yourself up to fail? Is there any data you could collect that could disconfirm your BA?)	NO	
Is it actionable in the near-term? (E.g., the people or situation you need in order to enact the test are available, you are reasonably certain you know how to do what you plan, and you can run the test within the next week or so.)	✓	

If you made any changes to your original test design based on our phone meeting, capture them here:

My Big Assumption Says...	So I will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	When I go to the holiday party, I will survey the buffet and make a conscious choice about what foods I will allow myself to eat and how much. I will not limit the amount of fresh fruit and vegetables I can have. I will allow myself one beer or glass of wine. I won't stand next to the buffet during the party. I'll get my food and then walk away. I will tell Josslyn my plan (just telling her will make me more mindful!)	Do I feel in charge, like I make my own choices or that I am forced to live by someone else's choice? How does it feel to make my initial decision after surveying the buffet? How do I feel during the party (esp. regarding decisions about what to eat)? How do I feel afterward? Did I feel like I had some choice? How did I feel about that? Was I realistic in setting goals and limits about what I could and couldn't eat? (Was I still hungry?) Was I overly restrictive in my initial decision?	Being in charge means following my impulses and indulgences or following my conscious decisions. I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, stressed. I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

continued

My Big Assumption Says...	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
		Did I develop counter arguments in my head to overrule my initial decisions? Could I use self talk to talk back to and overrule those counter arguments? Did I enjoy the party? Did I enjoy what I ate and drank? Did I enjoy other parts of the party (met new people I liked, had interesting conversations, etc.)?	

Exercise 7: Running and Interpreting Your Test

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me about my BA
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	At the holiday party, I decided I could eat some cold cuts and cheese, one quiche, and an unlimited amount of fresh fruit and vegetables. I drank two glasses of wine because they were small glasses. I didn't stand next to the buffet but did make a few trips to it, to get a refill on the strawberries.	I felt very proud of how well I stuck to my plan. And, I noticed that this did allow me to feel that I am in charge of what I eat and when. For the most part, that felt good. I think I was realistic in setting goals and limits about what I could and couldn't eat. I did notice that I wanted to bend the rules a bit — like when I saw that the wine glasses were small ones and not filled too much.	I can feel in charge by following my conscious decisions. But I think I don't want to be thinking so much about food. That makes me feel hungrier I think, and also a little resentful and stressed. When I'm out for a special occasion, I feel like I should be eating "special" food (e.g., desserts). <i>Client adds after running test</i>

continued

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
	I spent most of the party with Josslyn because I knew then that I wouldn't cheat. I also helped her not to cheat I think. The dessert table looked incredible, but we didn't even go over to that part of the room!	I was still hungry. Or maybe it was just that I wanted to eat – and eat something decadent. It was hard to not go over to the desserts! I did enjoy the party, but I think maybe I was relying on Josslyn too much. That kept me from meeting new people, and I think I probably thought more about food (what I wanted) because I was with her. It was like we were constantly reminding each other.	I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I want to be able to do more of this – not just spend the whole time with Josslyn because I'm so focused on being on a diet. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

Coach's Notes for Amanda:

We also talked about this new BA that you discovered: “When I’m out for a special occasion, I feel like I should be eating ‘special’ food (e.g., desserts).” It feels connected to your other BA about rewarding yourself with food and drink as a way to stay motivated, but you also felt like there was more there...

“I assume that special occasions are times when we reward ourselves to show ourselves love and for others to reward us to show us they love us. I assume that we give those rewards through special food.”

We added this BA to your map.

Your workspace to design a next test:

My Big Assumption Says...	So I will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	I'll tell my mom about my eating goals for this party and ask her to help me meet them. I'll ask my mom to prepare a healthy dessert for the family holiday party. When I go to the party, I will make a conscious choice about what foods I will allow myself to eat and how much. I will allow myself to eat one piece of healthy dessert. I will not limit the amount of fresh fruit and vegetables I can have. I will allow myself one beer or glass of wine. Before the party, I will think about who I want to talk with – what I want to ask them about, the kinds of conversations I'm hoping we'll have. At the party, I will seek out these people and generate conversations I'm hoping to have.	Do I feel in charge, like I make my own choices or that I am forced to live by someone else's choice? How does it feel to make my initial decision about what to eat? How do I feel during the party (esp. regarding decisions about what to eat)? How do I feel afterward? Can I consciously decide to "indulge"? Did I feel like I had some choice? How did I feel about that? Was I realistic in setting goals and limits about what I could and couldn't eat? (Was I still hungry?) Was I overly restrictive in my initial decision? Did I develop counter arguments in my head to overrule my initial decisions? Could I use self talk to talk back to and overrule those counter arguments? Did I enjoy the party? Did I enjoy what I ate and drank? Did I enjoy other parts of the party (spent time with the people I wanted to see, had interesting conversations, etc.)?	Being in charge means following my impulses and indulgences or following my conscious decisions. I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, stressed. I can enjoy healthy food. I still feel like I can have something special on a special occasion without completely ruining my diet. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I am not thinking about food the whole time. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

continued

My Big Assumption Says...	So I will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
		Did focusing more on people help me block out thoughts about food? Is there anyone to whom you'd like to give a "heads-up" or ask to serve as an observer who can give you feedback after the fact? My mom.	

CRITERIA	YES	NOT SURE
Is it safe? (If the worst case were to happen, you could live with the results.)	✓	
Is the data relevant to your Big Assumption?	✓	
Does it have face validity? (The test actually tests your Big Assumption.)	✓	
Are the data sources valid? (No one is either out to get you or wants to protect or save you.)	✓	
Might it "re-true" your Big Assumption? (Is it designed so that it surely will lead to bad consequences, just as your BA tells you? Are you setting yourself up to fail? Is there any data you could collect that could disconfirm your BA?)	NO	
Is it actionable in the near-term? (E.g., the people or situation you need in order to enact the test are available, you are reasonably certain you know how to do what you plan, and you can run the test within the next week or so.)	✓	

Your workspace to report on test #2, what happened and how you make sense of that:

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
I assume that if I don't have lots of choices in the moment, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.	I did tell my mom about my eating goals for this party and asked her to help me meet them. And she agreed to prepare a healthy dessert for me. When I got to the party, I made a conscious choice about what foods I could eat and how much. I did allow myself to eat one piece of healthy dessert. I did not limit the amount of fresh fruit and vegetables I could have, although there weren't too many of these. Next time, I'll ask mom to have those too – or I'll bring some myself. I didn't drink any beer or wine.	I did feel in charge, like I was making my own choices, and I was really pleased by what and how much I ate. Because I knew that I would eat the "healthy" dessert, I was really careful not to eat too much before that. Afterward, I was so pleased that I did so well! The best thing was that I was so distracted by the baby and the conversations I was having that I didn't really think so much about what I was eating (and not eating.) I didn't develop any counter arguments or need self talk. A couple of people volunteered to get me food or something to drink while I had the baby. It was easy to say no thanks.	I can feel in charge by following my conscious decisions. Being in charge can mean not only making decisions about food but about what I choose to focus on, what's most important to me about social occasions. When I'm out for a special occasion, I can indulge myself a little bit without going off my diet completely. I can eat less during the meal so that I can have healthy dessert. I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I can emphasize these more when I look forward to and am at the party. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.

Your workspace continued

My Big Assumption Says...	So in Order to Test it I Changed my Behavior This Way...	This is What I Observed Happening...	And This is What it Tells me About my BA
	Before the party, I did think about who I wanted to talk with and was really looking forward to seeing my cousin Cheryl and her new baby. I was also really eager to talk with my brother, who I haven't seen in a while. I spent most of my time holding Cheryl's baby while he slept. This is a great way to keep your hands busy so you don't eat. I think that's probably why I didn't have a beer or even wine. I did also talk to my brother and get caught up. I felt like I wanted to have an even longer conversation than we did have, so we made plans to talk by phone soon.		

Coach's Notes to Amanda:

Interpreting test results prompts clients to recall BA biographical material

One very powerful “ah ha” for you was the effect of being with your family and trying to maintain your healthy eating habits. One thing you noticed is how often people in your family just give each other food, without asking if the person wants food. As you put it, “we just act like of course everybody always wants food.” And, you mentioned that it was hard for you to refuse that food, that often it meant interrupting someone or calling attention to your diet in ways that felt awkward for you (and maybe the other person?). That realization triggered a key memory for you to add to your Biography.

Exercise 8: Taking Stock

Reflection Question	Your Response
Where do you see yourself in the sequence at this time?	Consciously released? I'm doing lots of stuff in my CoP.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your Big Assumption is <i>valid</i> ? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	I just have to tell myself that I can't eat the way I used to or even the way other people do and that's that. Stop feeling sorry for myself. I think that I'm still working hard to make sure I don't slip back. I don't even want to think about what could make that happen. So maybe my BAs are still there, but if I keep working, they'll go away completely. It's important that I keep putting the things into place that help me make progress.
Have you reached any conclusions, or have any hunches about conditions under which your Big Assumption is <i>invalid</i> ? Think about particular situations – who, what, where and when.	Nobody can tell me what to eat or not to eat but me. If you really want to reach your dreams, you can do it!! Just believe!! I have worked really hard to not get caught in my routines and to see that I have choices. I need to keep reminding myself not to fall back into old ways of thinking – that I'm not in control, that it's too hard, that others aren't going to help me. I see that work as just as hard and just as important as what I put in my mouth (or what I don't!). When I keep doing that thinking, then my BAs aren't true at all.
Do you find your BA asserting itself in situations you know it ought not? If so, do you have any generalizations about the conditions under which you are likely (more or less) to find yourself being sucked into the old patterns associated with the BA? What still sometimes <i>hooks</i> you?	I still slip up but now I know that that is okay and nobody is perfect. I can make plans that will help me be good even when there is lots of good food around and people socializing. I can use my strategies and ask for help! I guess just that it is hard work shows me that they could still hook me, even though I've passed some really hard tests.
Are there key “releases” (i.e., self-talk that unhooks you) you have developed and can use to help yourself easily and readily when you are facing your Big Assumption in real-time?	Focus on people – who I want to see, what to talk about, what to do to keep me busy so that I'm not near food and thinking about food all the time. I know now that I like healthy food! Look at my thinking, not just at my eating.
To what extent/how often can you use these “releases” to help you from being pulled into old patterns?	Just keep believing in myself and working hard. I know that I have gotten this far, and I'm not going back!

continued

Reflection Question	Your Response
Have you developed new behaviors or ways of talking to yourself in situations that used to activate your BA?	It's good to tell people and ask them to help me eat right. I even got some of my family looking at the WW site and planning to join too. I think I can be fun even if I'm not eating all the time.
Think about situations in which you think your BA is no longer accurate. What new beliefs or understandings do you hold about "how things work" or what will happen in these situations?	I can feel in charge by following my conscious decisions. When I'm out for a special occasion, I can indulge myself a little bit without going off my diet completely. I can eat less during the meal so that I can have healthy dessert. I can enjoy healthy food. I can appreciate non-food related aspects of the party. I can control my own self-destructive thoughts.
How would you rate your progress toward achieving your Column 1 goal? Has your understanding of or relationship to that goal changed in important ways?	My goal was: To develop healthier eating habits. To lose 25 pounds thereby lowering my blood pressure and improving my cholesterol. I have lost almost all the weight, and my bp and cholesterol numbers are so much better. The part where I still need to make progress is in making the changes I've made into true habits so that I don't start to ease up and gain back the weight!

